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THE ECONOMIC TIMES

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Now, FBI Knocks at Jensen Huang's Doors

AROUND THE WORLD ▸▸ 14

Oil Drops Below $90/bbl on Trump Remarks, Up Again

AROUND THE WORLD ▸▸ 14

PHD Chamber Calls for Axing LTCG Tax on Equities

ECONOMY: MACRO, MICRO & MORE ▸▸ 12

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OVER ₹6,400CR RAISE FINALISED

IIFL Announces Blackstone's ₹5,000cr Infusion

IIFL Finance's board on Tuesday announced investments by Blackstone, two IIFL promoters and Anchorage Capital, totalling about ₹6,414 crore, pending AGM approval. **ET was first to report in its Tuesday edition about the details of this fundraise.** ▸▸ 11

THE ECONOMIC TIMES
DEAL ANNOUNCEMENT EXPECTED TODAY
Blackstone set to Acquire 15% of IIFL for ₹5,000cr
Anchorage to pitch in with US PE firm; co promoters to put in ₹1,200cr to keep 25%
Atmadip Ray, Arijit Barman & Sangita Mehta
Fin-Fin Situation
Major recent foreign investments in domestic NBFCs
BankAm enters JV pact for 49.9% in Jio Credit for ₹18,286 cr
Japan's MUFG Bank acquires 20% in Shriram Finance for ₹39,618 cr
Bain Capital picks up 41.6% in Manappuram for
Mumbai: Blackstone, the world's largest alternative asset ma... invest around

MANY SEE 2X GROWTH OVER LAST YR

Qcomm Buoys Festive Sales for D2C Brands

Led by purchases on quick commerce platforms, direct-to-consumer (D2C) brands saw strong sales growth this festive season, with many nearly doubling their numbers over a year ago, reports **Disha Acharya**. ▸▸ 10

$400M GAINS FROM LENSKART, MEESHO

Indian Cos Silver Lining in SoftBank's Q2 Cloud

SoftBank posted a net loss of $7 billion globally for the September quarter, even as it realised gains of nearly $400 million from investments in Indian startups Lenskart and Meesho as part of its listed portfolio. ▸▸ 10

PLI Scheme for Medical Devices' Manufacture Extended for 9 Years

The ₹2,700-crore production-linked incentives (PLI) scheme for manufacturing of medical devices has been extended till FY36, reports **Teena Thacker**. The government has invited fresh applications, and eased norms. Under new guidelines, the minimum sales threshold for claiming incentives has been discontinued and the minimum investment requirement reduced. Multiple applications are also allowed. ▸▸ 12

PUREPOLITICS

Pannun Case: US State Dept Serves Summons to NSA, RAW Ex-Chief

The US State Department, at the direction of a court, has served summons to national security adviser Ajit Doval and former RAW chief Samant Goel through diplomatic channels in a civil lawsuit filed by Sikhs for Justice's Gurpatwant Singh Pannun. ▸▸ 2

■ Made it a Point to Speak Freely to Each Other: Sonia on Manmohan ▸▸ 2

■ Bengal Govt Announces Allowance Sops for IAS Officers this Diwali ▸▸ 2

ED Probe into Punjab CMO 'Parallel Power Centre' Underway

The Enforcement Directorate is conducting a money-laundering investigation into an alleged network of private intermediaries operating around the Punjab chief minister's office, even as the AAP government rejected the allegations, **Raghav Ohri** reports. ▸▸ 4

SPREADING REACH OF SHIPMENTS

India Drawing Up List of Export Snags in S Asia

Govt seeks info from industry on quality norms, acceptance of domestic lab tests

Kirtika Suneja

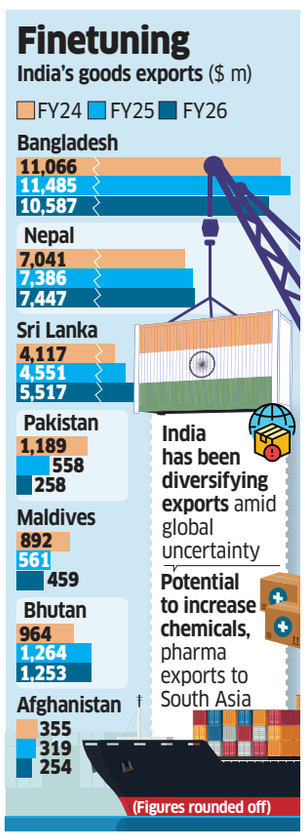
New Delhi: The government is mapping regulatory and market-access barriers faced by Indian exporters in seven South Asian neighbours as part of a drive to diversify overseas markets to achieve its $1-trillion total exports target this fiscal.

Exporters have been asked to flag hurdles such as import restrictions, licensing requirements, product standards, technical regulations, banking and payment restrictions, high import tariffs and delays in regulatory approvals, officials told **ET**. The government is also examining whether Indian testing laboratories are recognised in these markets.

India's merchandise exports to Afghanistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, Maldives and Pakistan fell 1.3% to $25.7 billion in FY26, after growing 2% in FY25 and declining 8.57% in FY24.

"While work is being done to resolve non-tariff barriers with all countries and broader trade facilitation measures, efforts are on to boost exports of certain products including chemicals and pharmaceuticals to South Asian markets," one of the officials said.

Tracing Potential ▸▸ 13



On Track for $1 Tn Exports: Goyal

India is on track to achieve its "sacrosanct" target of $1 trillion exports for this fiscal year, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said. The year's H1 has seen exports of $480 billion of goods and services, he said. ▸▸ 12

FEEDING WORLD DEMAND FOR NEW TECH

Electronics Inc Runs Ops Update to Build AI Infra

Manufacturers look to move up value chain to more high-tech components

Writankar Mukherjee

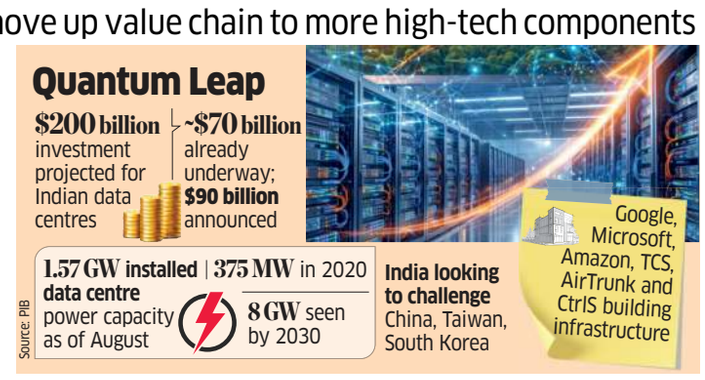
Kolkata: India's electronics manufacturing industry is expanding into high-tech products for data centres and artificial intelligence (AI) infrastructure, moving up the value chain after establishing a stronghold in smartphones and venturing into semiconductor chips, seeking to tap into surging global demand and position the country as an export hub.

Leading contract manufacturer Dixon Technologies plans to manufacture for AI infrastructure and hyperscale data centres, including silicon photonics-based optical transceivers and advanced packaging solutions. It may begin some production as early as next quarter.

Multinationals such as Samsung and LG, along with the homegrown Voltas, Blue Star and PG Electroplast, are also entering the market for specialised heating, ventilation and air-conditioning (HVAC) systems used in data centres. The products will cater to both domestic demand and exports, executives said.

"The biggest buoyancy today globally in electronics manufacturing is on the AI and data centre side, and the whole technology is shifting towards the optical domain," Atul Lall, managing director, Dixon Technologies, told analysts earlier this month. "Our global peers' performance, margin profile and growth, is coming mainly from this domain. We are attempting to ...bring this technology into India for servicing global markets."

Temperature Control Systems ▸▸ 13



Sovereign Infra Push to Supercharge Energy Hardware Startups' Funding

Renewables tech may get self-reliance boost

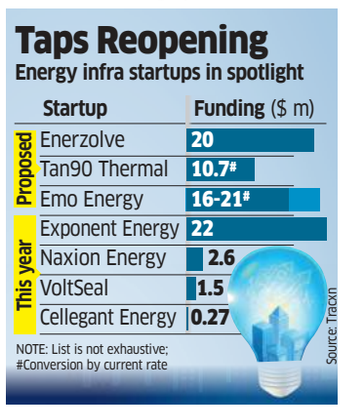
Ayanti Bera

Bengaluru: Startups building hardware for India's energy infrastructure are raising follow-on rounds several times the size of their previous fundraises, as risk investors deepen bets on technologies spanning grid management, storage and power electronics.

Bengaluru-based Enerzolve, which makes smart meters, power conversion systems and energy storage systems, is in talks to raise $20 million from existing investors Jungle Ventures and Kae Capital as well as Schneider Electric, people aware of the matter told **ET**. That's nearly four times the $5 million it raised in a January round.

Chennai-based Tan90 Thermal, which uses phase-change materials to keep food and pharmaceuticals chilled in transit without continuous refrigeration, is in talks to raise about ₹100 crore ($10.7 million) led by Blume Ventures, said people in the know. That's five times the ₹20 crore it raised last year.

Driven More by Need for Security ▸▸ 13



GAS LEAK DEATHS

Report Sought from Tata Electronics

The Krishnagiri district collector has directed Tata Electronics to review the safety performance of agencies maintaining its effluents treatment plant in Tamil Nadu, following death of three contract workers from asphyxiation. The company has been asked to submit a detailed action taken report, to ensure such incidents are not repeated. ▸▸ 10

GREENSHOE OPTION

Anthropic Eyes $90B IPO at $1.4 Tn Value

Anthropic is seeking a fully diluted valuation of about $1.4 trillion in its initial public offering, in a bid to make history as the first frontier AI lab to go public. The Claude maker and its cofounders are seeking to raise up to $90.4 billion in the IPO and a private placement. The base offering would raise up to $64.4 billion, with shares marketed for $70 to $78 each, according to an SEC filing. ▸▸ 11

ANOTHER JOURNEY IN INDIA

Local Partner Wanted for Xiaomi 'Home' Coming

Chinese co set to foray into home category with white goods production as it seeks to deepen revenue mix

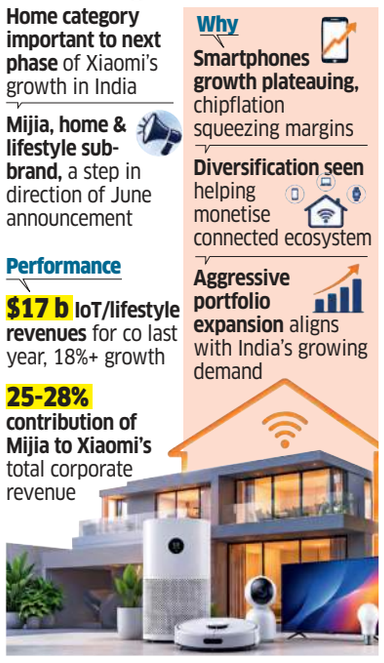
Dia Rekhi

Chennai: Xiaomi is scouting for local partners as it looks to manufacture white goods in India, months after it formally launched specialised home and lifestyle sub-brand, Mijia, in the country, said people familiar with the development.

The proposal is in the exploratory phase, but the Chinese technology company is set to begin evaluating potential Indian suppliers, according to one of the persons who did not wish to be identified. "It marks a natural progression for Xiaomi as it has committed to expanding beyond air purifiers into categories such as air conditioners, refrigerators and washing machines," the person said.

Queries sent to Xiaomi remained unanswered until press time.

Betting Big on Connected Devices ▸▸ 11



EXPANSION & LOWER LENDING COSTS IN FOCUS FOR INDIA INVESTMENTS

Prosus to Loosen Fintech Purse Strings

Prosus plans to up its fintech investments in India, focusing on the underserved as well as lowering of lending costs, reports **Nikhil Patwardhan**. It is also close to investing in AI-led credit management startup Oolka. ▸▸ 10

AI Pushes B-schools to Chart New Course

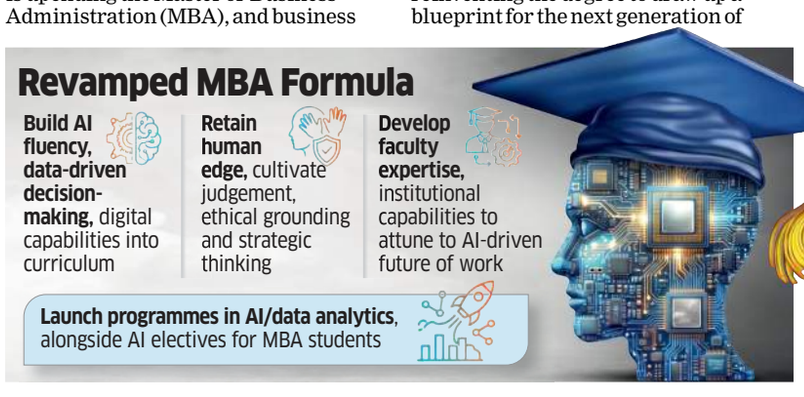
Institutions updating curriculum, expanding faculty to upskill next-gen biz leaders

Saumya Bhattacharya

New Delhi: Artificial intelligence (AI) is upending the Master of Business Administration (MBA), and business schools are rushing to adapt.

As AI automates many of the core technical skills traditionally taught in these elite programmes, institutions are reinventing the degree to draw up a blueprint for the next generation of leaders.

Freshly minted MBA graduates are now expected to build AI agents, question machine recommendations and take responsibility for the outcomes. They work through business problems alongside machines, then navigate the complex human aspects of the business.



WHO'S LEADING THE CHARGE

Business schools—including Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Kozhikode, IIM Lucknow, Indian School of Business (ISB), BITS School of Management (BITSoM), and global players like Nanyang Business School—are responding through changes in curriculum, practical learning and assessment, according to institution officials.

'Profound Transformation' ▸▸ 13

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MCPI Private Limited extends its sincere gratitude to Dr. Purnendu Chatterjee, Chairman of The Chatterjee Group, for his visionary leadership.

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Future Pipeline
Expanding PTA capacity at Haldia; advancing textiles and apparel in West Bengal; scaling Garden Vareli's fashion and retail footprint; and developing new verticals in Nutrifoods and Logistics.

LAWSUIT AGAINST DOVAL, SAMANT GOEL FRIVOLOUS, FABRICATED AND MALICIOUS: MINISTRY OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS

Pannun Case: US State Dept Serves Summons to NSA, Ex-RAW Chief

Summons served through Embassy of India in Washington DC

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The US State Department, at the direction of a US court, has served summons to NSA Ajit Doval and former RAW chief Samant Goel through diplomatic channels in a **civil lawsuit filed by Sikhs for Justice's Gurpatwant Singh Pannun**. The State Department served the summons through the Embassy of India in Washington DC.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told reporters here on Tuesday that the lawsuit was "frivolous, fabricated and malicious".

Jaiswal stressed that judicial documents in India must be routed through India's designated central authority, the Ministry of Law and Justice, rather than bypassing diplomatic channels.

Pannun's lawsuit names Ajit Doval and Samant Goel among the defendants. He has sought damages over an alleged attempt on his life and has accused Doval of orchestrating a plot involving RAW to assassinate him.

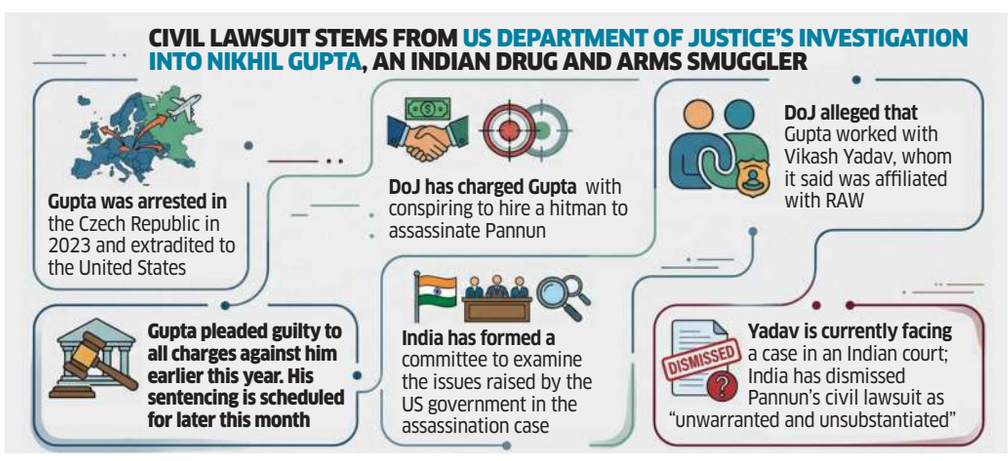
ASSERTS MEA

'Judicial documents in India must be routed through India's designated central authority – Ministry of Law & Justice – rather than bypassing diplomatic channels'

The civil lawsuit stems from the Department of Justice's (DoJ) investigation into Nikhil Gupta, an Indian drug and arms smuggler. He was arrested in the Czech Republic in 2023 and extradited to the United States.

DoJ has charged Gupta with conspiring to hire a hitman to assassinate Pannun. It alleged that Gupta worked with Vikash Yadav, whom it said was affiliated with RAW. Gupta pleaded guilty to all charges against him earlier this year. His sentencing is scheduled for later this month.

While the Government of India formed a committee to examine the issues raised by the US government in the assassination case, and Yadav is currently facing a case in an Indian court, India dismissed Pannun's civil lawsuit as "unwarranted and unsubstantiated".



Hasina has no Legal Option But to Face Death Sentence: B'desh Govt

DHAKA Ousted Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina has no legal option left but to face execution of her death sentence, the International Crimes Tribunal's Chief Prosecutor Md Aminul Islam said on Tuesday, rejecting the possibility of issuing her a passport or travel document. His remarks came a day after Hasina, through a London-based legal chamber, approached the Bangladesh High Commission in New Delhi seeking a new passport and national identity card. She has expressed her intention to return to the country in December and face legal proceedings. – PTI

APEX BODY LEH ANNOUNCES PROTESTS

Ladakh Council Polls Announced Amid Shutdown

Polling scheduled for Dec 4 and counting of votes and declaration of results on Dec 8

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: The State Election Commission of Ladakh on Tuesday announced the schedule for elections to all eight Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDCs), with polling scheduled for December 4 and counting of votes and declaration of results on December 8.

The announcement came on a day when Kargil and Sankoo observed a complete shutdown, demanding deferment of the polls and a review of the delimitation exercise. Meanwhile, the Apex Body Leh (ABL) announced a protest at the NDS Stadium in Leh on November 12, opposing the decision to hold elections during winter and pressing for the larger demands over which the ABL and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) are engaged in a dialogue with the Union Ministry of Home Affairs. ABL said its protest campaign will continue through the winter and reiterated its support for the election boycott call given by the Nambardar Association.

According to a notification issued by SEC Sudhanshu Pandey, the last date for filing nominations is November 17 while scrutiny of nomination papers will take place on November 18. Candidates can withdraw their nominations by November 20. Polling, if required, will be held on December 4 between 8 am and 5 pm, with the entire election process scheduled to be completed by December 8. Panchayat and municipal elections are scheduled for November 21.

"This is a watershed moment and a turning point for democracy in Ladakh. It is a crucial inflection point in the larger journey of democracy. People must demonstrate that they stand for democracy by participating in this festival of democracy," said Ashish Kundra, Chief Secretary of Ladakh, while addressing a press conference. "Protest is a democratic right, and so is voting. I hope leaders in Kargil and Leh will participate and encourage others to vote in these grassroots democratic elections," Kundra said. He also maintained that weather conditions were not a limiting factor, as schools in Ladakh remained open until December 15, and people could therefore participate in the elections on December 4.

The chief secretary further said that contrary to the public opinion being formed, LAHDCs retained the powers they had enjoyed earlier. Under the new arrangement, 36 of the 100 seats across all eight LAHDCs would be reserved for women.

CHIEF SECY ON POLL DATE

'Weather conditions not a limiting factor as schools remain open until Dec 15, and people can therefore participate in elections on Dec 4'

WINTER CONCERNS

'Elections have never been held in Dec... Schools are close to children's homes, but booths are far away. How will people and officials travel if it snows?'

Meanwhile, a candlelight march 'Save Democracy' was organised in Kargil on Tuesday evening to press for the demands for deferment of the elections and a review of the delimitation exercise. An all-party meeting was also held in Drass, where participants opposed the elections and reiterated their support for KDA and ABL.

"How can elections be conducted without people? 25% of our population is outside Ladakh. This is an attempt to rig the elections in favour of a particular party (BJP). We support the election boycott call given by the Nambardar Association," said ABL's Cherring Dorjay Lakruk.

EXCERPTS FROM SONIA GANDHI'S MEMOIR 'BELONGING – A JOURNEY OF LOVE'

Made it a Point to Speak Frankly to Each Other: Sonia on MMS

Perhaps it was time for a change at the top: Senior Congress leader recalls Pranab's suggestion

Our Political Bureau | New Delhi

Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's memoir, 'Belonging: A Journey of Love', hit the bookstores on Tuesday. The memoir chronicles Sonia's journey from her childhood in Italy, life in India to her personal losses and her political journey as the leader of the Congress party. Here are some excerpts from the memoir:

ON HER EQUATION WITH THE THEN PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH

"Both Dr Singh and I knew perfectly well that our opponents would lose no opportunity to try to create trouble between us. So, we made it a point to speak frankly to each other and sort out any differences or work problems. I always spoke my mind to him, and I felt that he, too, preferred to be open and straightforward. And so it remained throughout. I respected him as a trusted and experienced elder. I knew I could turn to him for guidance and advice on many matters and benefit from his wisdom, integrity and sincere concern for the disadvantaged. On one point, I was clear: he was the prime minister now and, while I could offer him my opinions or suggestions as party president, or even disagree with him, it was my duty to defer to him."

"I respected him as a trusted and experienced elder. I knew I could turn to him for guidance, advice"

PRANAB MUKHERJEE'S 'SHOCKING' SUGGESTION

"A core group met weekly with the PM (Manmohan Singh) to ensure coordination between the two (government and the party)... We also met regularly as members of the strategy group set up to discuss issues to be taken up in Parliament. Sometimes, Pranabji, as I always called him, would stay back for a chat. He had developed serious differences with the finance minister PC Chidambaram, and on one occasion in 2010, I think, after expressing his frustration, he shocked me by suggesting that perhaps it was time for a change at the top. I understood this as a hint of his long-held desire to become PM. I gently changed the subject and, although he may have been disappointed, he never made me feel that he held it against me. Our party did nominate him in 2012 as the UPA candidate for President, the highest office in our republic, and he was elected."

"Pranabji had developed serious differences with finance minister PC Chidambaram"

RAHUL GANDHI'S ROCKY ELEVATION AND WHAT FOLLOWED

"Our adversaries had all along mounted an attack on him, supported behind the scenes by some dissatisfied people within our own party"

"Finally, in 2017, the party elected Rahul president at its 84th plenary session after I resigned. Our adversaries had all along mounted an attack on him, supported behind the scenes by some dissatisfied people within our own party. Inevitably, there had been resistance to him from some sections of the old guard. His frank and outspoken views did not find favour with all. There were some who, like him, were pushing for younger leadership across the country so that the Congress could become a fighting force and others, who felt threatened and were unwilling to let go of their positions. Some wanted us to draw clear ideological lines against the BJP, while others feared that taking a stridently secular stand would damage us with the majority of the population. Differences within our ranks grew, proving damaging to the party, especially since the media was actively engaged in amplifying them. It broke my heart to witness the level of aggression Rahul had to endure."

'NO REAL CONTACT WITH PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI'

"Narendra Damodardas Modi has been the Prime Minister of India for more than 12 years as of this writing and is now in his third term in office. To this day, I have had practically no real contact with him. We meet at semi-official gatherings. For instance, at the end of every Parliament session, leaders of the major parties customarily gather in the Speaker's chamber. It is a very small room, and usually many people are present. But when he comes face to face with me, we greet each other with a formal namaste. This is different from the past, when leaders across party lines would treat one another with cordiality. He tends to look away, avoiding eye contact. On occasions when I had returned after a stint in hospital, he would ask, 'Theek hain aap?' And I would reply, 'Jee, ab main theek hoon, shukriya.' Apart from such brief exchanges, we have never really conversed, although we have exchanged formal birthday and New Year greetings over the years. We come from different ideological worlds."

"We have never really conversed, although we have exchanged formal birthday and New Year greetings over the years"

MANEKA 'HAD CONFIDED HER PLAN TO A JOURNALIST FRIEND IN ADVANCE'

"The final showdown came after Maneka took part in a supposedly non-political rally in Lucknow, organised by dissidents while Mrs Gandhi was in London on an official trip. She had received messages from her office that Maneka was having her belongings moved out of her rooms, clearly preparing for her exit. On her return from London, my mother-in-law made her displeasure known, telling Maneka that, as part of the family, she could not continue engaging in disloyal political activities. She had to make a choice: either refrain or live elsewhere.

She reiterated her position in a letter, to which Maneka responded with a missive full of accusations, obviously meant to damage her mother-in-law. It became clear that she was intent on creating a furore around her departure from the house, publicly placing the blame on Mrs Gandhi. She had confided her plan to a journalist friend weeks in advance."

"It became clear that she was intent on creating a furore around her departure from the house, publicly placing the blame on Mrs Gandhi"

TARGETING SONIA

Should have been Named Whitewashing: BJP Slams Book

BJP leader Phoolka accuses Sonia of 'misleading' people on anti-Sikh riots

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: BJP on Tuesday took a dig at former Congress president Sonia Gandhi for "justifying" the Emergency in her memoir and said the book should instead have been named 'Whitewashing'.

The motive of the book appears to be "sugar-coating the historical wrongs perpetrated" by the Nehru-Gandhi family, BJP's national spokesperson CR Kesavan stated on X.

BJP leader HS Phoolka also accused Sonia Gandhi of "misleading" the people and alleged that the Congress leader has given a "clean chit" to her husband Rajiv Gandhi by blaming the then Army chief AS Vaidya for the delay in the deployment of armed forces in Delhi after Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's assassination on October 31,1984.

Speaking to reporters at the BJP headquarters here, the Supreme Court lawyer, who has been fighting cases of anti-Sikh riot victims, claimed that Gandhi's assertion in her book that Vaidya had received his orders the same night as the assassination and decided not to mobilise the nearest units because they were manned by Sikh soldiers and called units from Dehradun is "against official records".

"Gen Vaidya never said that he had instructions from Rajiv Gandhi or the prime minister. Gen Vaidya said that he had himself checked (the availability of Army units) in Delhi," he claimed. "It is a massive attempt to mislead people in India and across the world. In her book, Sonia Gandhi is giving a clean chit to Rajiv Gandhi and her family..."

Sonia Gandhi is giving a clean chit to Rajiv Gandhi and her family: HS Phoolka

Suvendu Sarkar Rolls Out Grand Diwali Bonanza for Bengal Babus

50% hike in sumptuary allowance; soft loans of up to ₹50 lakh for children's higher education; LTC extended to Southeast Asia, Dubai, Mauritius; benefits for top-level retirees

Anubhuti Vishnoi

New Delhi: The Suvendu Adhikari-led West Bengal government has rolled out a grand Diwali bonanza for its battery of IAS officers, announcing a 50% hike in their sumptuary allowance, probably the highest in the country. The bonanza also includes soft loans of up to ₹50 lakh for the higher education of their children in India and abroad, an expanded leave travel concession (LTC) for Southeast Asian countries, Dubai and Mauritius, and post-retirement benefits for top-level retirees.

According to a November 6 memorandum issued by West Bengal's Department of Personnel and Administrative Reforms, senior officers at the levels of secretary, principal secretary and additional chief secretary will receive a 50% hike in their sumptuary allowance (meant for hospitality/entertainment expenses), taking it to ₹60,000, ₹70,000 and ₹80,000 per month, respectively.

The enhanced allowance will benefit well over 50 senior officials in the state and mark a significant increase in their take-home salary.

Incidentally, the last such hike in sumptuary allowance was introduced by the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool government in November 2021, amid the Covid-19 pandemic. It had attracted considerable attention at the time, with monthly hikes ranging from ₹17,000 to ₹34,000 for senior officers.

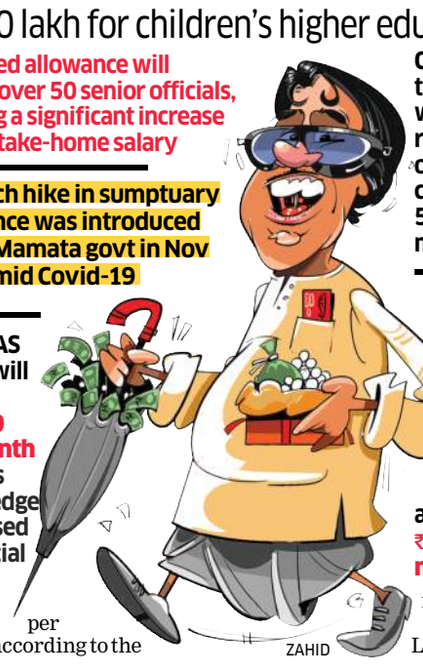
The 2026 memorandum also allows all 300-plus IAS officers in the state to avail themselves of education loans of up to ₹50 lakh for their children's education, including "study abroad and boarding school" expenses. The move cites the "increase in the cost of education in India and abroad and the start of hybrid degree" programmes, under which a part of graduate-level education is pursued overseas.

Officers above the rank of secretary will also get reimbursement of electricity charges of up to 500 units per month, according to the memorandum.

Enhanced allowance will benefit over 50 senior officials, marking a significant increase in their take-home salary

Last such hike in sumptuary allowance was introduced by the Mamata govt in Nov 2021 amid Covid-19

Every IAS officer will receive ₹10,000 per month towards 'knowledge tools' used for official work



Officers above the rank of secy will also get reimbursement of electricity charges of up to 500 units per month

All retired officers now entitled to 2 attendants, an internet allowance of – ₹5,000 per month

The much-coveted LTC has also received a makeover for Bengal cadre officers. They will now be permitted to travel to Southeast Asian countries, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Dubai, the Maldives and Mauritius once in a block of four years, with the caveat that the fare will not exceed the farthest point in India.

IAS officers retiring at the apex scale, too, have reason to cheer.

A November 6 order stipulates that all such retired officers residing in West Bengal will be entitled to two attendants and an internet allowance of Rs 5,000 per month.

Officers below the rank of secretary and posted in Kolkata will now get a sumptuary allowance of ₹15,000 per month, subject to revision every three years. They will also get reimbursement of house rent of up to ₹60,000 per month, with the ceiling set to increase by 20% every three years, provided the officer is not allotted government accommodation and is not availing House Rent Allowance.

STARTER PACKAGE FOR NEW OFFICERS

Starter package for newly inducted IAS officers – a laptop, desktop and printer, with total expenditure capped at ₹2 lakh

Adding to it, every IAS officer will receive ₹10,000 per month towards "knowledge tools" used for official work, based on self-certification.

Even a newly inducted IAS officer joining the West Bengal cadre will be entitled to a starter package comprising a laptop, desktop and printer, with the total expenditure capped at ₹2 lakh.

Under the 7th Pay Commission, which is currently in force, an entry-level IAS officer is estimated to draw around ₹1.25 lakh per month, including Dearness Allowance and other allowances. At the secretary level, this goes up to nearly ₹3.67 lakh per month.

₹15,000 PER MONTH FOR OFFICERS BELOW SECY RANK

Officers below the rank of secretary and posted in Kolkata will now get a sumptuary allowance of ₹15,000 per month, subject to revision every three years

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AMID MISCONDUCT CHARGES, CM CALLS MLAs TO CHENNAI

Under Fire, Vijay Moves to Rein In MLAs

Dy Speaker accused of assault; MLA faces charge of sending obscene messages to DC

Our Political Bureau

Chennai: Tamil Nadu chief minister and TVK founder C Joseph Vijay has reportedly called an emergency meeting of his party's legislators amid growing scrutiny of the conduct of some MLAs and mounting pressure from the Opposition. The meeting is expected to be held at the TVK headquarters in Chennai on Wednesday and will be chaired by Vijay.

The TVK leadership is likely to issue strict instructions to party functionaries and MLAs on maintaining discipline and public conduct. They are also expected to be told to behave with dignity, address public grievances and refrain from misusing their authority.

The meeting is expected to focus particularly on allegations against TVK MLA and Deputy Speaker M Ravisankar, who has faced criticism from parties following a controversy involving a local resident.

Even the collector is unsafe from a ruling party MLA: AIADMK's Srinivasan

On Monday, the resident, who claimed to be a TVK voter, alleged that he was attacked by Ravisankar after approaching him with a request to address civic issues in his ward.

The alleged victim had shared a video purportedly showing the legislator assaulting him and chasing him away on Diwali night after he raised the issue. However, he retracted his allegations the following morning, claiming that there were no differences between him and the Deputy Speaker.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu's Opposition parties on Tuesday alleged that Kallakurichi MLA C Arul Vignesh had sent obscene text messages to a woman IAS officer serving as the district collector. DMK MP Kanimozhi alleged that the MLA, while in an inebriated state, had also visited the collector's office without the woman officer's consent.

The TVK is conducting an internal inquiry into the matter. However, Vignesh denied the allegations. "I have not done any such thing. They are rumours. It is not true," he said.

DMK president MK Stalin criticised the ruling TVK, saying Tamil Nadu's "law and order is in ICU" and the "administration is in coma". "There have been 17 murders on a single day. And a TVK MLA is accused of sending obscene text messages to a female district collector. Criminals have no fear under the current government and police have no security either. People's representatives from TVK have no control. In total, the 'part-time' chief minister has no responsibility at all," the former CM wrote on X.

AIADMK treasurer Dindigul Srinivasan claimed the legislator "went to the collector's house in an inebriated condition and harassed her. This is shocking". "The collector, who ought to protect the people, seems to have no security from a ruling party MLA. What a shame," Srinivasan said.

AMMK general secretary TTV Dhinakaran alleged that the TVK leadership had turned a blind eye to party functionaries accused of sexually harassing schoolgirls and kidnapping and gang-raping members of their own party.

TN CM Joseph Vijay

Bribing contractors, assaulting a person who came to petition the MLA about a public problem, sexual harassment of the district collector are among the heinous acts committed by TVK MLAs
TTV DHINAKARAN
AMMK general secretary

Tamil Nadu's 'law and order is in ICU' and the 'administration is in coma'. There have been 17 murders on a single day. And a TVK MLA is accused of sending obscene text messages to a female district collector
MK STALIN
DMK Chief

ED Probes Punjab CMO 'PARALLEL POWER CENTRE'

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: A money-laundering probe by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has brought under scrutiny an alleged network of private intermediaries operating around the Punjab Chief Minister's Office (CMO), with investigation material pointing to alleged attempts to influence government transfers, policy decisions, tenders, licencing and land-related approvals, people in the know told ET.

At the centre of the allegations is private individual Nitin Gohal, whom the ED has described as an intermediary between people seeking government favours and Rajbir Singh Ghuman, Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann. **The agency's findings, shared with the Punjab Director General of Police under Section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), formed the basis of a subsequent investigation ordered by the Punjab and Haryana High Court and entrusted to the CBI.**

According to the ED's findings, an examination of electronic devices, WhatsApp conversations and call records allegedly revealed 21 instances of interference in the transfers and postings of government officials between September 2023 and March 2026. These involved officials in several departments, including the police, food and civil supplies, Markfed and the Greater Mohali Area Development Authority, agency sources added.

Another 11 conversations allegedly concerned policy formulation, amendments to departmental rules, tender conditions, licensing, administrative approvals and other government decisions.

The agency also cited conversations that it interpreted as indicative of payments, kickbacks or other benefits in return for official favours.

The allegations also extend to access to confidential government information. Gohal allegedly received and forwarded draft transfer orders and other sensitive documents before their formal release. The ED's material also referred to a confidential presentation on foodgrain policy. In his statement to ED, Gohal allegedly acknowledged receiving and forwarding the presentation, while saying that he had obtained it through his links with government officials.

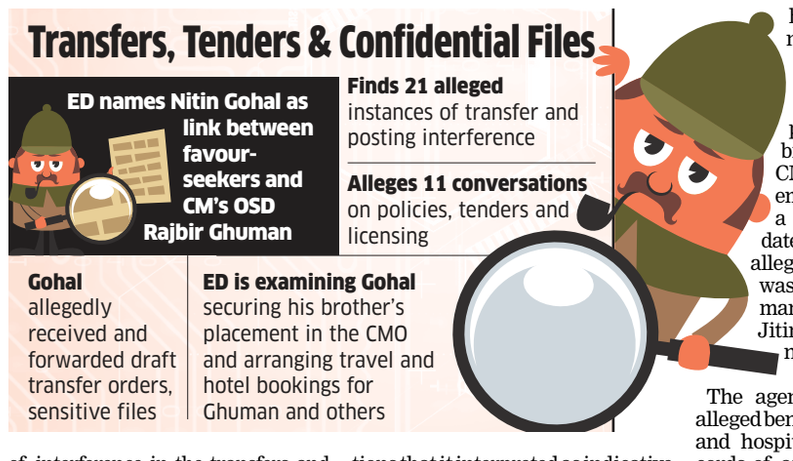
The alleged network is also being examined for its role in facilitating the placement of Gohal's brother, Jitin Gohal, in the CMO as an outsourced employee. The ED has cited a WhatsApp conversation dated January 23, 2026, and alleged that the placement was facilitated through Ghuman and another individual. Jitin, who was a Markfed manager, was allegedly attached to the CMO.

The agency has also examined alleged benefits in the form of travel and hospitality. It referred to records of air tickets and hotel bookings arranged by Nitin Gohal for Ghuman and another political associate. Gohal acknowledged making some bookings but denied that they constituted kickbacks, saying that the individuals concerned had paid directly in several instances, according to the material cited in the court proceedings.

During searches conducted in May 2026 at premises linked to Gohal and others, the ED allegedly recovered cash and electronic records. The agency cited a cash recovery of ₹20.98 lakh from Gohal. The ED's investigation originated from a money-laundering case relating to alleged irregularities in land-use conversion and property transactions.

After the ED shared its findings with the Punjab Police, the state agency did not register an FIR. On October 5, the Punjab and Haryana HC directed the CBI to register a case, observing that the allegations prima facie disclosed cognisable offences and warranted an independent investigation. The CBI subsequently registered an FIR against Ghuman and five others, covering alleged bribery linked to transfers, policy formulation, tenders, licensing and land-related matters. The Supreme Court later declined to stay the CBI FIR while directing that no coercive action be taken against the petitioners and asking the Punjab government to cooperate with the investigation.

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has repeatedly rejected the allegations, describing the ED's action as a political witch hunt and accusing the BJP-led Centre of misusing central agencies to target and defame the Punjab government. The allegations against the individuals concerned remain subject to investigation.



AMID PEACE TALKS IN ABU DHABI

India's Offers 3-Part Plan to De-escalate Ukraine War

Seeks to protect energy infra, grain shipments & maritime trade from attacks

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: While the US has been engaged in bringing Russia and Ukraine on the same table to discuss 'concrete proposals' to end the war, India has put forward a three-part framework for de-escalation and presented it to both Russia and Ukraine.

India's proposal calls for a halt to attacks on energy facilities and critical infrastructure; measures to keep grain and energy shipments moving through Black Sea ports; and an end to strikes on merchant vessels, civilian crew and maritime trade routes. The Indian proposals may not deal with the core demands of the war but deals with the critical question of economic security.

While attacks by Ukraine on Russian energy infrastructure has impacted global energy flows, Kiev has requested New Delhi to use its good offices with Russia enabling grain exports by Ukraine through Black Sea Ports, it has been learnt. Attacks on merchant vessels in Black Sea have taken a toll on Indian seafarers and New Delhi had raised the issue with both Moscow and Kiev, officials here informed.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Monday called Prime Minister Narendra Modi to share his perspective on recent developments regarding the conflict.

Modi, on his part, conveyed India's readiness to contribute to all efforts aimed at a peaceful resolution of the conflict.

FIRST PEACE TALKS IN NINE MONTHS

Russia-Ukraine Talks Very Productive: Rubio in Abu Dhabi

Abu Dhabi: Russian and Ukrainian officials met in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday for their first peace talks since February as US President Donald Trump's envoys launched a new push to end the war in Ukraine. Secretary of State Marco Rubio described the US-brokered meeting as very productive, without giving details. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskiy called the talks "constructive and quite substantive", and said they had included humanitarian and security issues. – Reuters

CM Alleges Mamata Hid Information in Poll Affidavit, Warns of Action

Our Political Bureau

Kolkata: Former chief minister Mamata Banerjee did not disclose a lot of information in her affidavit while filing her nomination in the recent assembly elections, and this is "an offence", Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari alleged on Tuesday.

"Former CM Mamata Banerjee has not disclosed a lot of information. The candidates had raised objections during scrutiny but the returning officer dismissed it. There will be a case against her," Adhikari told reporters on the sidelines of a programme in Nandigram on Tuesday, where he observed Martyr's day.

Reacting sharply, Mamata-AITC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh said, "Whenever Adhikari gives any comment, 9.5 out of 10 of his statements are attacking Mamata and the Trinamool. This just shows the Trinamool and Mamata's strength —that is why all his statements are against Trinamool and attempts were made to break Trinamool."

DELHI POLICE NOTICE TO MAMATA

Meanwhile, Delhi Police has reportedly issued a fresh notice to Banerjee to record her statement as a 'victim' in a 2013 case related to a protest by SFI and CPI(M) supporters during her visit to New Delhi, sources said.

The Delhi Police team is currently in Kolkata and Banerjee's statement is likely to be recorded by the Parliament Street police station, sources said.

The case goes back to an incident in April 2013, when Banerjee visited the former Planning Commission headquarters in Delhi for a meeting. SFI and CPM supporters had raised slogans against her, leading to a scuffle with the members of her delegation.

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I Have lost original GPA Dt.07.02.2001 of Prop No.2/68-A, Nirankari Colony Delhi-09, executed by Daljit Singh S/o Sqn. Ldr. G S Sidhu to Sarabjit Singh Sidhu. Finder please inform to Naveen Kumar S/o Radha Krishan Sardana R/O 2/68-A, Nirankari Colony, Delhi-09 Email. Kukaintl@yahoo.com
I, Mehandi Hasan S/o Jafar Hasan R/o 28, Rajiv Nagar, Khora Colony, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, have lost the original Property Registration Page and WILL Paper, both issued dated 29.01.2002, bearing Document No. 3682, for the above-mentioned property somewhere. Finder Please Contact: 9871621183.
CHANGE OF NAME
I, Bimla Devi , W/o U.k .lal , R/o house no 34 block A , chorosia Estate, phi- 3, Greater Noida ,Gautam Buddha nager, have changed my name from Vimla Devi to Bimla Devi for all future purposes
I, Divya Baghel W/o Rahul Baghel R/o A-29, Sainik Colony, Faridabad hereby declare that the names Pinky, Divya Kumari, and Divya Baghel refer to the same person, henceforth, I should be known by the name Divya Baghel.
I, Kartikey Wadhawan S/o Rajan Kumar Wadhawan R/o WZ-33-A, South Extn,Part-1,gali no.3,Uttam nagar,Delhi-59 have changed my name to Kartikay Wadhawan for all purposes.
I, Basant Mishra S/o Ratneshwar Mishra R/o C-1002, Divyansh Flora, Gr.Noida West, Gaur City-2, Noida, G.B Nagar, UP-201301 have changed my name to Basant Kumar Mishra. Both names belong to one and the same person.
I, Anantha Rajmohan Muthusamy R/o 86-D/1, Third Floor, Krishna Nagar, Gali No.3, Safdarjung Enclave, Delhi-110029, have changed the name of my minor daughter Anantha Anat Sarah Maryam to Anat Sarah Maryam and my name Anantha Rajmohan to Anantha Rajmohan Muthusamy and my wife name Judy Auxcilia to Judy Auxcilia Pushparaj for all future purposes.
I,Vikash S/o Raj Kokil R/o E-97a, Gali No-3 & 6, Om Nagar, Meethapur, Badarpur New Delhi -110044 have changed my name to Vikas Sahani for all purposes
I hitherto known as Sonia W/o Manjeet Singh D/o G S Nandan R/o E-52, 4th Floor, Krishna Park, Khanpur, Devli, Dr. Ambedkar Nagar, South Delhi, Delhi-110080 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Sonia Kaur.
I, Asmita Yadav D/o No 197278K CHEAAR Gautam R/o H.No-35/3, Shakti Nagar Part II, Rewari (HR) have changed my name from Asmita Yadav to Ashmita Yadav for future purpose
IT is for general information that I, Ajay Kumar Baluni S/O H.P. baluni, a23/1, lawrance road, ind area, keshav puram, north west Delhi, ND-35, declare that name of mine and my wife have been wrongly written as AJAY BALUNI and JYOTI in my minor daughter namely BHAVYA BALUNI aged 17 years in her 10th class educational documents. The actual name of mine and my wife are Ajay Kumar Baluni and Jyoti Baluni respectively which may be amended accordingly.
I, Muskan Kumari, Daughter of No.14658609W Hav Rameshwar Singh, R/o- Vill- Jitora, PO-Karahara, Teh- Kirawali, Agra, U.P - 283105, have changed my name from Muskan Kumari to Muskan vide affidavit dated 10/11/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Devendri Sharma, W/o Late Shri Mukesh Kumar, R/o H.No. D-14A, Street No. 3, Bhagat Singh Colony, Ballabgarh, Faridabad, Haryana have changed myold address, Village Akalimpur, District Gurgaon, Haryana, is still mentioned in my PPO. I want to get this address changed. And My Name Devendri is wrongly mentioned in my Discharge Book. My correct name Devendri Sharma and also My DOB 30.07.1970 is wrongly mentioned in my Discharge Book. My correct DOB 12.12.1996 for all future purposes.
I, Rukshi W/o. Mohd Ali R/o. 1/11414-C, First Floor, Street No:-10, Subhash Park Extn. Shahdara, Delhi-110032, declare I have changed my name from Rukshi to Rukshi Ansari for all future purposes.
I, Mohd Mubarik Khan S/o Tahir Hasan R/o House No-928 Gali No-16 Block E-2 Nehru Vihar Delhi-110094 have change my name from Mohammed Mubarik Khan to Mohd Mubarik Khan for all purpose in future.
I Anumita Chakrabarty Alias Aiden Chakrabarty D/o Kallol Chakrabarty Residing at G 375 9th Street Gamma II Greater Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh - 201310 hereby undertake that I Anumita Chakrabarty Alias Aiden Chakrabarty want to Change my name to Aiden Chakrabarty and Gender as Male. I Anumita Chakrabarty Alias Aiden Chakrabarty Henceforth be known as Aiden Chakrabarty S/o Kallol Chakrabarty.
I, Babli, w/o Ravi Kumar , residing at B -1339 Shastri Nagar Delhi - 110052, have changed my name to Babli Gupta for all future purposes.
I, Deepanshu, S/o Manohar Lal Sharma, R/0 J-226 A, Shiv Ram Park, Nangloi, Nilothi, West Delhi, Delhi-110041, have changed my name to Deepanshu Sharma
I, Mustufa S/O Mushtaq ahmed born on 18/12/1997 Residing at D-30 Shri Ram colony rajiv nagar delhi 110094 ,have changed my name to Mohd Mustafa.
I, Rachna Agarwal W/o Naveen Kumar, R/o Cedar-4, 308, Gulmohar Enclave, Rakesh Marg, Nehru Nagar-III, Ghaziabad, UP-201001, have changed my name to Rachna Gupta for all future purposes.
I, Naveen Kumar Agarwal, S/o Prem Chand, R/o Cedar-4, 308, Gulmohar Enclave, Rakesh Marg, Nehru Nagar-III, Ghaziabad, UP-201001, have changed my name to Naveen Kumar for all future purposes.
I, Sudhanshu Pandey, S/o Dinesh Pandey, R/o flat no. 1005, Tower A1, UNIHOMES, Sector-117, Noida, UP, have changed my name to Sudhanshu Kumar Pandey for all future purposes.
I, Deepthy Shieo W/o Shieo Thomas R/o Flat No C2/13, Sahyadri Apartments, Plot No 5, Sector 12, Dwarka, South West Delhi 110075 have changed my name to Deepthy Ambooken for all future purposes
I, Shiva Nand Tiiwari S/o. Ramjee Tiwari R/o. E-2/76, G/F, Kh. No:-71, Pusta-5, Sonia Vihar, Delhi-110094, declare I have changed my name from Shiva Nand Tiiwari to Shivanand Tiwari for all future purposes.
I, Ramvati Devi, Mother of No.14658609W Hav Rameshwar Singh, R/o- Vill- Jitora, PO-Karahara, Teh- Kirawali, Agra, U.P - 283105, have changed my name from Ramvati Devi to Ramvati vide affidavit dated 10/11/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Sunil Kumar Army No JC711095X, Rank-NB SUB S/o Shri Tejpal R/o Village Jawan Teh. Ballabhgarh & Distt. Faridabad Declare that my mother name parsandi is wrongly mentioned in my army record but her correct name is prasandi. please amend accordingly.
I, Anandjeet Singh S/o Late S Ranjit Singh R/o House No 20, Guru Hr Rai Avenue, Amritsar Punjab, spelling of my name has erroneously entered as Anandjit singh in my 10th class certificate, whereas my correct name is Anandjeet Singh.
I, Surekha Sahoo W/o Chuguli Kumar Sahoo R/o House No. 103, Kaveri Block, Anand Ashray Apartment, P-2, Greater Noida, Kasna, Gautam Buddha Nagar, (U.P.)–201310, have changed my name from Surekha Sahoo to Surekha Manjari Sahoo. In the future, I should be known and recognized by the name Surekha Manjari Sahoo.
I, Karandeep S Kainth Alias Karandeep Singh Kainth S/O, Pardev Singh R/o Tower 6, 801, Shapoorji Pallonji Joyville, Sector 102, Gurugram have changed my name to Karandeep Singh Kainth for all purposes
I Jasvinder Kaur W/o Ravinder Pal Singh R/o UC-29 Usha Park Jail Road New Delhi-110018. have changed my name to jaswinder kaur

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Born to Finish

Meet Carlos Prates, UFC's knockout specialist and No. 1 welterweight title contender

Amit Chaudhary

Carlos Prates has little patience for losing. He has even less interest in winning ugly.

It's a philosophy that has made the Brazilian welterweight, known as 'The Nightmare', one of the most feared finishers in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC), and one that he intends to carry into the biggest fight of his career.

On January 30, 2027, the 33-year-old is scheduled to face Ecuador's Michael Morales for the interim welterweight championship at UFC 336.

The bout follows a breakdown in negotiations for an undisputed title fight against reigning champion Islam Makhachev, who indicated that he would not compete in January, preferring to return after Ramadan.

Prates was not particularly pleased with the champion's position. He called Makhachev a "coward", accused him of backing away from the contest and later described him as "lazy and rich as f***" for not wanting to undertake a training camp.

For Prates, however, the prospect of fighting Morales is reason enough to be excited. "No pressure, no pressure," Prates told ET Sport during his India visit last week. "I'm the No. 1 contender. January 30, I'm going to step in the Octagon, I'm going to knock him out, get my belt and then go to Brazil and celebrate carnival with my friends, my family."

Prates' rise to the top of the division has been remarkably swift. After earning a UFC contract with a second-round knockout on Dana White's Contender Series in August 2023, he made his promotional debut in February 2024. He won all four of his fights that year, stopping every opponent via knockout.

His seven UFC victories have all come by knockout or technical knockout, making him one of the promotion's most prolific finishers. At 7-1 in UFC, Prates has become a fighter whose opponents cannot afford to switch off for even a moment.

STREET SMART

Yet the man behind the finishing record is not quite the character his nickname suggests.

Prates grew up in Taubaté, in Brazil's São Paulo state, raised by his mother after his father died when he was one. His mother worked as a teacher, often leaving him with considerable freedom to spend his days outside. Like many children in Brazil, he played football on the streets, where he said he learnt both good and bad things.

Prates route into professional sport was less a carefully mapped ambition than an escape from a conventional working life. "I didn't like to study. I didn't like to work," he said.

At 17, he entered a fight, earned some money and began to see a possibility. Fighting could provide an income without requiring him to spend his days working for someone else. He kept competing, eventually discovering that the sport offered something more compelling than financial independence: a chance to become the best in the world.

"I like to compete, I like to win, I want to be the best in the world. So, if I want to show that I'm the best, I needed to come to UFC, become champ," he said of his reasons to become a UFC fighter.

He said his friends gave him the nickname "The Nightmare". It came from Pesadelo, a character in the Brazilian children's television series *Sítio do Picapau Amarelo*, whom they thought he resembled.

The nickname may have come from a children's television character, but the reputation has been earned in the Octagon, one knockout at a time. And if Prates has his way, his next opponent will become another part of that story.

(Watch UFC on Sony Sports Network)

Man United Set to Sack Carrick: Reports

Michael Carrick is set to be sacked by Manchester United after his side's dismal start to the season, according to reports on Tuesday.

United's hierarchy have been conducting an internal review of the club's miserable form and it is believed that Carrick will shortly be relieved of his duties.

United are in the midst of their worst opening to a campaign in 40 years, leaving them languishing in the Premier League relegation zone after an eight-match winless run.

Although it is said that no final decision has been made, chief executive Omar Berrada and director of football Jason Wilcox are reportedly leaning towards dismissing Carrick.

United owners the Glazer family and influential shareholder Jim Ratcliffe would then decide whether to act on that recommendation.

Carrick was seen arriving at United's Carrington training base on Tuesday, but it appears to be only a matter of time before his turbulent reign comes to an end.

POCH TO BE NEXT MANAGER?

United States men's national team coach Mauricio Pochettino is the top candidate to be the next Manchester United manager, ESPN reported on Monday.

Pochettino, 54, coached Tottenham, Chelsea and Paris Saint-Germain before joining the USMNT in 2024.

In August, the Argentine had his contract extended until 2030 after leading the US to the round of 16 at the World Cup.

Per ESPN, Manchester United's hierarchy also are considering former Newcastle United manager Eddie Howe for the position, as well as former Ipswich Town coach Kieran McKenna and former German national team coach Julian Nagelsmann.

AFP/Reuters

VITALS

Third India-New Zealand ODI Abandoned After Rain

Hamilton: The third ODI between India and New Zealand in Hamilton was abandoned due to rain on Tuesday, with the tourists retaining their 2-0 lead in the five-match series. The outcome ended New Zealand's streak of 11 consecutive home ODI series victories since 2019. Rain delayed the start of the match, which was initially reduced to a 40-over contest at toss. India captain Shubman Gill elected to bowl but play could not start and the match was eventually called off following multiple ground inspections by the umpires. **Reuters**

World Athletics Raises Entry Standards for '28 Olympics

Hamilton: Athletes chasing qualification for the Los Angeles 2028 Olympics will face much tougher entry standards than for the Paris Games, with World Athletics on Tuesday tightening benchmarks across track events while increasing reliance on world rankings. The global governing body said around 40% of athletes would qualify through entry standards and 60% through world rankings, compared with a 50-50 split at the Paris 2024 Olympics. The qualification system includes 23 men's events, 23 women's events and two mixed relays – the 4x100m mixed relay, making its Olympic debut and the 4x400m mixed relay. **Reuters**

Manu, Esha Fail to Grab Olympics Quota

Doha: India settled for the women's 25m pistol team gold after ace shooters Manu Bhaker and Esha Singh failed to deliver in the individual final, squandering another opportunity to secure quota places for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics at the ISSF World Championships on Tuesday. While Esha finished eighth and last, Manu narrowly missed the podium, ending fourth. **PTI**

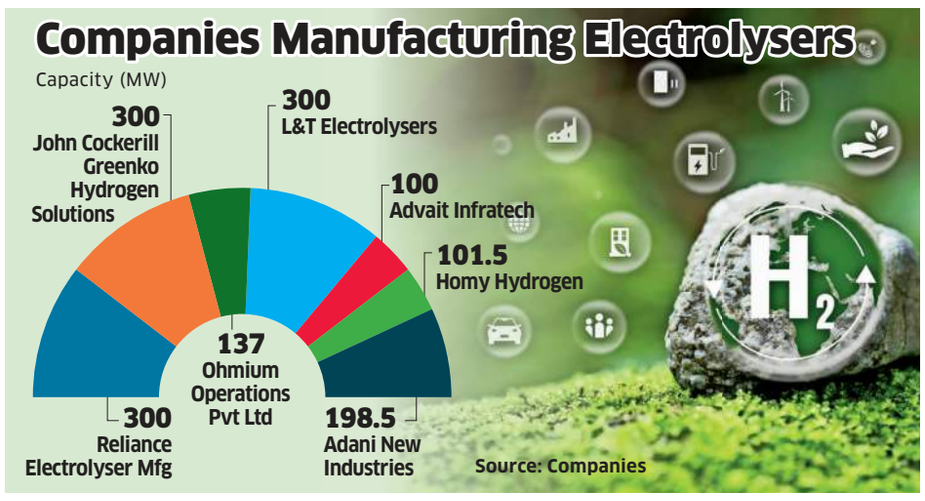
CA Rules Out Reopening 'Sandpapergate' Probe

Cricket Australia chief Todd Greenberg on Tuesday ruled out reopening the investigation into the sandpapergate ball-tampering scandal, saying he did not see "any compelling reason" for a new probe. Opening batsman Usman Khawaja said in his autobiography that the 2018 plot had been common knowledge throughout the team and not limited to a small number of players. Greenberg said he would consider Khawaja's revelations but said there was no need for further action. **AFP**

Green H2 Demand Slump Pushes Back Electrolyser Plant Launches to Aug '27

MNRE agrees to extend deadline, allowing cos to retain eligibility for incentives under PLI scheme

Kalpana Pathak



Mumbai: Lack of demand for green hydrogen is forcing nearly half-a-dozen companies, including Reliance Electrolyser Manufacturing, Adani New Industries, Homi Hydrogen and John Cockerill Greenko Hydrogen Solutions, to defer the commissioning of their electrolyser manufacturing facilities to August 2027 from December 2026.

Industry executives aware of the development said the ministry of new and renewable energy (MNRE) has agreed to extend the timeline allowing these companies to retain their eligibility for incentives under the production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme. RIL, John Cockerill Greenko Hydrogem, Advait Infratech, L&T Electrolyses and Adani New Industries did not respond to email queries. The ministry of new and renewable energy also did not reply to an email query.

"Companies can commission their facilities any time until August 2027. Those which have orders can start the year immediately, while others can wait until they get orders," an industry executive said.

He added that the revised arrangement allows manufacturers to start operations earlier if they have orders, or defer the formal commencement of their PLI incentive period until they secure demand. This is significant because the PLI scheme provides higher incentives in the initial years, and companies risk losing out on benefits if they begin the incentive period without adequate orders.

"This flexibility will help keep the electrolyser manufacturers from incurring operating costs without sufficient production," said an industry executive, adding that several companies have already invested in land, buildings and equipment, while interest payments on loans taken to establish the facilities have either begun or are due.

Industry estimates suggest that setting up an electrolyser manufacturing facility could involve capital expenditure of ₹50 crore to ₹100 crore, depending on land acquisition and other requirements. Manufacturers continue to bear financing costs even if they delay commissioning or production.

However, the relaxation does not provide any immediate financial benefit to companies. Since the PLI scheme is linked to actual production, incentives will accrue only after manufacturers secure orders, produce electrolysers meeting the prescribed domestic value-addition and energy-consumption criteria, and supply and commission them for customer projects.

Although the government has awarded green ammonia projects under its green hydrogen programme, developers are yet to complete financial closure and place orders with electrolyser manufacturers, executives added.

HomiHydrogen told **ET** it has sought an extension of two years for the full commissioning of the manufacturing facility.

"The demand is very slow as compared to the expected demand from the 5 MMTPA green hydrogen production road map. But going ahead we see demand to pick up," the company said in an email response. The company has invested around Rs 100 crore in the technology development, land & building and plant & machinery so far.

Reliance Electrolyser Manufacturing, owned by Reliance Industries, is understood to be targeting May 2027 for readiness of its facility. The company did not respond to an email query.

Maha Gets Transmission Co IPO Proposal; Approval Likely Soon

Shilpa Samant

New Delhi: A proposal to list Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Company (MSETCL) has been submitted to the state government, with an initial public offering (IPO) targeted for FY28, a senior state official said.

Abha Shukla, additional chief secretary of the state's energy department, told **ET** that approval for the proposed share sale could come in two months.

The transmission company has already picked six banks for its plan to list.

MSETCL is looking to participate in tariff-based competitive bidding projects in the state and needs to raise funds for this, Shukla said. The company is targeting ₹7,000-8,000 crore through the share sale.

In 2024, the Centre had advised states to consider listing power-sector entities, beginning with transmission companies, to meet their investment needs.

Maharashtra has acted on this advice and plans to list its distribution company (discom) in the current financial year.

Shukla said the transmission company could list on the bourses after around six months of the listing of the state discom.

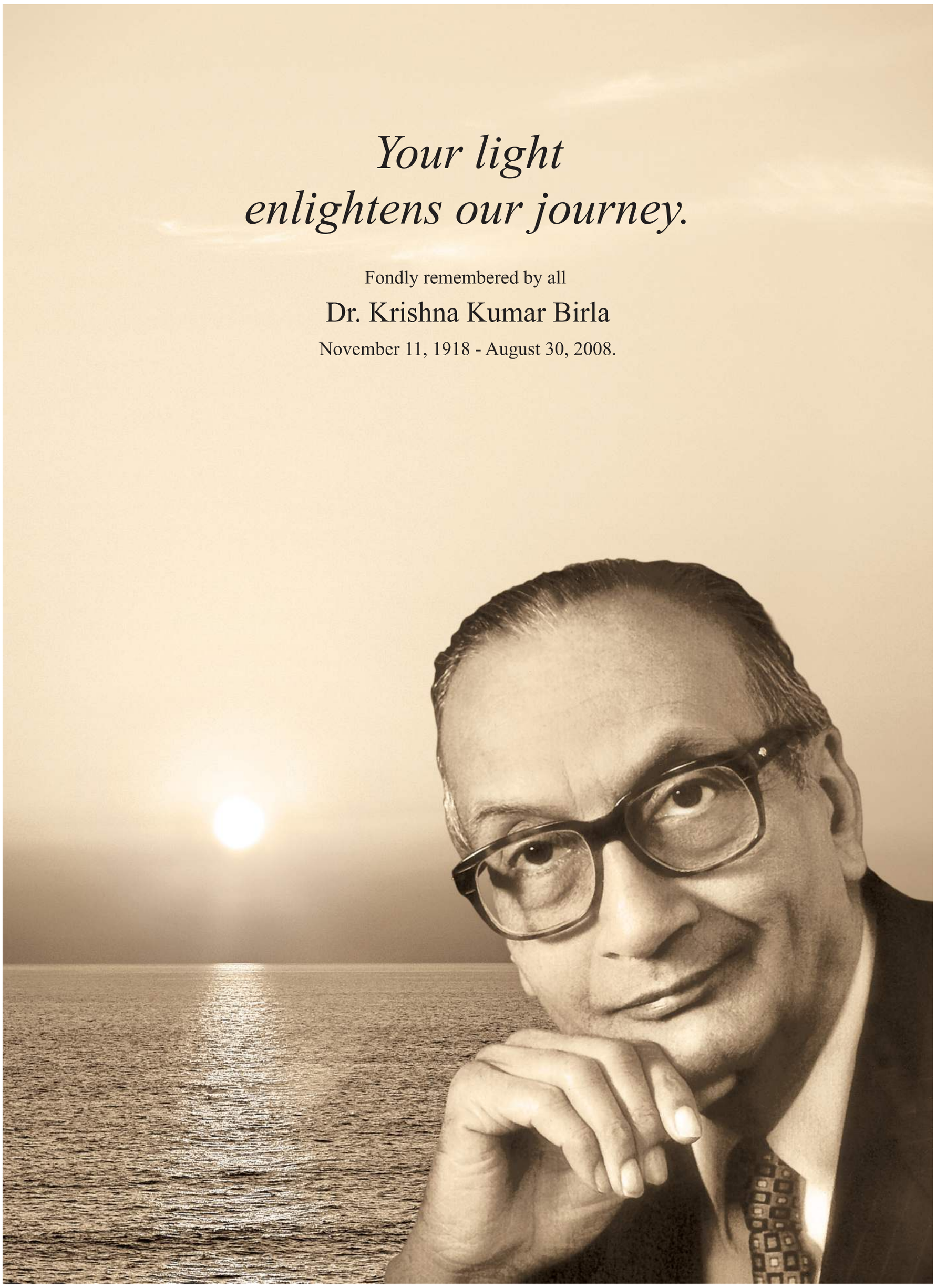
Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd. will file for its IPO in the first week of December, according to its chairman and managing director, Lokesh Chandra. The company expects to raise more than ₹10,000 crore through the listing, Chandra told ET separately. If the discom's IPO comes in February, it will be the first ever in state power utilities. States such as Gujarat and Bihar are also looking to list some of their power utilities soon.

Maharashtra's transmission company, also known as Mahatransco, is primarily engaged in intra-state electricity transmission, planning and coordination, load dispatch, and facilitating open access to its transmission network.

The company owns, operates and maintains 52,807 circuit kilometres of transmission lines and 760 extra-high-voltage substations across Maharashtra, making it one of the largest state transmission utilities in India.

Recently, the Centre also launched phase three of the Green Energy Corridor, aimed at strengthening intra-state transmission networks, with an outlay of ₹54,082 crore.

States are aiming for expansion and upgradation of their transmission lines given the rising demand for power in the next decade.



Huang in Suspense, Chips May Crack

'Jensanity' can lead to tougher export control

Jensen Huang's future at Nvidia is under scrutiny after the mega-chipmaker announced an internal investigation into his relationship with a Chinese businesswoman suspected to have passed intelligence to Beijing. AI, beleaguered by political changes on Capitol Hill and a looming debt crisis, could have done without a corporate espionage scandal that may disrupt flow of advanced semiconductors. Nvidia's most advanced AI processors are restricted under US export controls that effectively ban their direct import into China. Huawei is actively developing its line-up of supercomputing architecture to challenge Nvidia's market dominance. A widening probe into Huang's indiscretion could bring Nvidia's substantial non-AI business in China into the spotlight. Chinese buyers will seek safer alternatives from Huawei that is rapidly closing the tech gap.

Countries like India importing Nvidia's AI chips don't have China's advantage in local manufacturing. The US treats India as a strategic partner and imposes a cap on total processing power of US-designed chips it can purchase in a year. These must be accompanied by end-use and security commitments. The review pathway is streamlined compared to restricted countries. But licensing requirements impose transaction costs in hi-tech trade. These costs could mount if anti-proliferation efforts become more rigorous. Chinese retaliation imposes additional trade costs on third parties like India. China has restricted export of rare earths and key minerals such as gallium, germanium and antimony used in semiconductor manufacturing. Indian industry is particularly dependent on rare earth imports from China, and has no substitutes immediately available.

Huang is a hands-on boss at Nvidia. Although he owns a small amount of the company's stock, replacing him will be difficult. In the new political dispensation, Washington may be forced to take a harder look at its export control regime and make it more watertight. 'Jensanity' offers a good trigger.

This Year's Booker, a Genre-Bender Lesson

Literature has long maintained a peculiar immigration policy. Novels about unhappy marriages, dysfunctional families, middle-class ennui and diasporic dilemmas are waved through as 'literary fiction'. Those featuring aliens, detectives, ghosts and murders are directed towards the less-respectable 'genre fiction' aisle. Never mind that the latter may have more to say about the human condition than the former.

The 2026 Booker Prize, awarded to 81-yr-old British 'science fiction' writer M John Harrison for The End of Everything, delivers a welcome blow to this literary apartheid. Harrison, the first winner to emerge from SF's established ranks, has spent decades challenging the distinction. His dystopian novel, set in a post-catastrophe England populated by mysterious shape-shifting entities, examines contemporary politics, collapsing certainties and humanity's inability to comprehend its predicament. Hardly frivolous stuff. This silo-isation was not always there. Mary Shelley's Frankenstein is simultaneously SF, Gothic horror and philosophical inquiry. Tagore's Khudhito Pashan (The Hungering Stone) is a supernatural tale, imbued in historic fiction exploring the human psyche. The same zanana-isation infects music, cinema, art, even the sciences and tech.

Genres do have their use, sure. They help consumers locate the 'shelves' they are looking for more easily. The danger begins when classification becomes hierarchy, and marketing segues into critical judgement. Harrison's Booker victory should, therefore, be celebrated not so much as science fiction's promotion into literary aristocracy, but more as evidence that the aristocracy has been imaginary and fragile all along. The helpfully-marked shelves can remain. The snobbery should go.

THINK ABOUT IT

Indulging in schadenfreude is all too human, and just-right 'shameful'

Oh, Guilty Pleasures Of 'Harm-Joy'

The Germans may have given the world Beethoven and bureaucracy. But, above all, they have supplied us one of their most useful words: schadenfreude (sha-dun-froy-duh), literally 'harm-joy'. The pleasure derived from another's misfortune is among humanity's least advertised hobbies. Particularly when the unfortunate individual is considerably more fortunate than oneself. Consider Manchester Utd. The legacy club's current downward spiral — hitting a 40-yr low after dropping into relegation zone this week — is not necessarily in United's suffering per se, but in discovering that money, fame and an enormous merchandise operation cannot guarantee competent defending. Of course, there is something shameful in being tickled by someone else's worry warts. But who said humans are paragons of virtue?

Psychologists suggest schadenfreude springs partly from social comparison and perceived justice. The mighty falling reassures ordinary mortals that the universe has not entirely outsourced fairness to PR agencies, and strongmen also have feet of play dough and clay. As we keep saying — out of guilt — there is something unbecoming about celebrating failure. But schadenfreude, properly rationed, is less cruelty than inflation correction. After all, watching giants stumble is one of the few remaining entertainments that will get us neither cancelled nor hurrahed.

Economic advancement can't be judged through a single income figure, other conditions apply

'Creamy Layer' Has Layers

Rajesh Shukla

More than a filling

Does earning a higher income mean a family has overcome generations of disadvantage? Can two households with similar incomes enjoy different opportunities because of their education, occupation and accumulated assets? These questions lie at the heart of India's renewed creamy layer debate. Supreme Court's March 11 judgment — upheld last Friday — emphasised that parental salary alone cannot determine 'creamy layer' status among OBCs without considering occupational and service status criteria.

So, how should India recognise socioeconomic advancement? Tracking economic progress of SC, ST and OBC households between 2004-05 and 2023-24 reveals advancement, but also differences in opportunity and economic outcomes. In 2004-05, average SC household income was only 53% of that among 'Others', the survey's comparison category. ST households stood at 47% and OBC households at 69%. By 2022-23, they had increased to 76%, 72%, and 87%, respectively.

Official consumption data confirm this convergence. Between 2004-05 and 2023-24, SC consumption relative to 'Others' rose from 55% to 69%, ST from 47% to 59%, and OBC from 66% to 83%. The economic distance between communities has narrowed substantially although gaps remain, particularly for SC and ST households.

▶ **Education** In 2004-05, only 3% of SC, 2% of ST, and 5% of OBC households had a graduate or more educated member, compared with 15% among 'Others'. By 2022-23, these proportions had increased to about 9%, 5%, 13%, and 23%, respectively. Educational advancement has been widespread but differences remain. Graduate presence among OBC households has moved closer to 'Others', while SC and ST households continue to lag.

▶ **Occupational change** Proportion of SC households whose principal income source was regular salaried employment increased from about 13% to 20%, ST from 8% to 15%, and OBC from 15% to 21%. Among 'Others', the increase was from 25% to 28%.

Expansion of salaried employment has been faster among disadvantaged communities, but access to such positions remains unequal. Educational attainment and occupational security are related achievements, not interchangeable measures of advancement. Difference becomes clearer when households with comparable characteristics are examined.

After accounting for education, occupation, household size and location, SC household incomes are found to remain about 9% below 'Others', ST and OBC incomes 17% and 4% lower, respectively. These are statistical associations rather than measures of discrimination, but they reveal something important: improvements in educational qualifications and occupational position do not automatically eliminate differences in economic outcomes. Access to opportunity and rewards associated with it must be considered.

Distinction also helps explain how convergence has occurred. Among STs, improvements in educational and occupational composition account for much of the relative income gain. SC households have benefited from both movement into better positions and narrowing income differences within comparable positions. OBC households have experienced substantial gains through both. Their development trajectories differ not only in the extent of advancement but also in the routes through which it has occurred.

What does this mean for identifying 'creamy layer'? Existing central OBC framework recognises that economic advancement cannot be judged through a single income figure. It considers parental occupational status and specified service categories, professional and business circumstances, property, and an income or wealth test.

The commonly cited ₹8 lakh threshold is, therefore, not a universal household salary cutoff. The underlying principle is that sustained socioeconomic advantage involves more than current earnings. Three dimensions that matter are worth examining:

❶ **Education** But educational background of parents, and opportunities available to children can differ even among households with similar qualifications.

❷ **Occupational position** Secure professional and salaried employment provides greater stability and opportunities for advancement.

❸ **Accumulated assets and housing security** Families with similar incomes may possess different capacities to withstand economic shocks, or finance the next generation's education.

A first-gen graduate supporting a family through insecure employment may earn as much as someone from an established professional household. But his or her accumulated economic security can be very different.

Equally, some households within historically disadvantaged communities have achieved substantial and sustained advancement. Recognising both realities is essential to understanding contemporary inequality.

None of these findings establishes where a legal 'creamy layer' boundary should be drawn, or whether the OBC principle should extend to SCs and STs. Nor can observed progress be attributed solely to reservation, since economic growth, urbanisation, educational expansion and public programmes have also shaped opportunities.

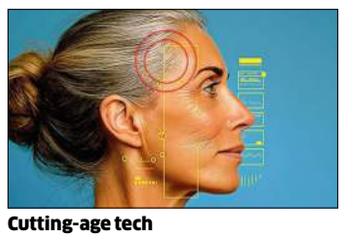
What two decades of evidence establishes is more fundamental. India has experienced substantial convergence between social groups alongside growing economic differentiation within them. The challenge is to distinguish temporary income gains from durable socioeconomic advancement, and improvements in current circumstances from advantages accumulated across generations.

India's reservation debate is often presented as a choice between caste and class. Household evidence suggests a more demanding understanding. Caste continues to shape opportunity, while education, occupation, income and accumulated assets increasingly differentiate households within social groups. A meaningful assessment of advancement must recognise both inherited disadvantage and achieved economic security.

The writer is MD-CEO, People Research on India's Consumer Economy (PRICE)

Temple Tantrum v. Pioneer Spirit

Shivaji Dasgupta



Cutting-age tech

Temple, a new head-worn wellness wearable created by Zomato and Eternal founder Deepinder Goyal, is making news — primarily for its price point. Priced at ₹85,000, Goyal himself has pointed out that it is 'not made for India' but for a global consumer, adding, 'We don't expect any more than 1% of Temples being sold in India.' This flips the old Tata Motors '₹1 lakh Nano car for everyone' model on its head.

But what we're looking at is a rare phenomenon in Indian retail: the pioneer product. The emerging role of AI in healthcare resides in predictive diagnostics. Companies like Molbio Diagnostics are mobilising their machines in remote locations for primary screening, to be escalated to structured healthcare, upon due suspicion. Apps like Ada, Apple Health, mySugr and Qure.ai are effectively doing the same on a one-on-one interactive basis. Never as an alternative to the registered medical practitioner, but as a productive channel for timely and accurate intervention.

'Entropy', the stated tech driving Temple, is designed to be a real-time biomarker, assessing performance of the body during both rest and peak performance. Tracking how hard the body is working across multiple systems, on a scale of 1 to 250. In tandem with 'BrainFlow', designed to monitor relative changes in blood circulation, connected to the brain (cerebral haemodynamics).

Neither has been validated by any meaningful research or recognised authority, and is continuously earning the wrath of influential doctors. Whether it will eventually earn necessary credibility is still doubtful. One can't rule out a destiny for Temple like the Elizabeth Holmes-curated bogus blood-testing startup Theranos.

But to understand Temple's potential, you could compare it to de Havilland Comet, pioneer of the commercial jet age, launched in 1952. A resounding success in its early years, later crippled with a metal fatigue-generating structural fallacy, it fast-forwarded the learning curve for Boeing 707 and its many prolific peers. Temple can end up either way.

Examples of semaglutide and tirzepatide — better known as Ozempic and Mounjaro — may be discussed at large. The GLP-1 market reached a moving annual total (MAT) scale of over ₹2,215 cr by mid-2026, with broader industry forecasts estimating the playground to expand significantly. End of one patent regime led to those drugs being made available for 1/10th the original asking price. Perhaps an encore can be expected for the ₹85,000-apiece Temple, as the pioneer inspires wings in empowered followers.

For successful tech products across genres, 'origin' price points invariably reduce dramatically. Else, their stature premium makes it accessible for every aspirational denomination in society. EMI can always be the great leveller, permitting emerging fellows to avail of BMWs and iPhones with rapid felicity.

What needs to be sorted is the core value proposition. Temple is an 'access' technology, not a solution mechanism. It's useful for detecting, in advance, damages that can impair meaningful longevity. Including mental health, which seems to be an underlying epidemic, across strata.

Instead of viewing this as competition, doctors will be well advised to consider advancement as a revenue accelerator. Early detection of potential illnesses, leading to a steady stream of addressable customers. Over time, significantly reducing customer acquisition cost and considerably enhancing customer lifetime value.

Late detection of terminal and chronic non-communicable diseases is a major issue of concern in India, with over 60% of patients across major critical illnesses diagnosed only after reaching advanced or metastatic stages. Diabetes and heart dysfunction add to this diabolical kitty.

Let not the Temple story be reduced to a petty 'doctor v. AI' debate. Instead, let it be seen as an amplifier — today, for a wealthy 'global' customer base; tomorrow, for a much larger 'local' population. Scalable efficacy is never a pioneer's problem, but that of a scalable successor. At this stage, it's necessary for every stakeholder to right-size both Temple's claims and concerns. Whether it will be boom, gloom or doom, we will know soon enough.

The writer is an autonomous brand consultant

Terminator: Rise of the AI Sceptics

Jay Vinayak Ojha

Did we just have Judgment Day?

As Republican Party reels from the landslide defeat in last week's US midterm elections, the post-mortem results seem clear: It's the war, stupid!

Party officials all the way up to J D Vance acknowledged that the economic distress caused by an ill-considered and badly sold war with Iran turned voters off the ruling party. But Democrat triumph will have impacts not just on US policy in West Asia but also on the country's most important sunrise industry: AI.

Democrats across the country ran, broadly speaking, on an 'anti-AI' platform. The new darling of the party's Left, senator-elect Abdul El-Sayed of Michigan, called for a pause in AI development. Georgia senator-elect Jon Ossoff, standard bearer of the party's centrists, also highlighted in his victory speech a dark vision of a world in which 'the titans of Silicon Valley dig bunkers for themselves and warn that the artificial intelligence they're creating risks human extinction'.

Democrat AI-scepticism is on a collision course with a Trump regime that is still gung-ho on the tech. The Trump regime has focused on the need for the US to 'win the AI race'. Beyond flashy PR moves like rebranding AI as 'super intelligence', it has thrown real weight behind the industry.

Trump has argued that that narrow readings of copyright law cannot be permitted to strangle the industry in its crib, and that the pool of human knowledge should be available to train AI models. Perhaps, most importantly, Trump has used presidential executive powers to attempt to ensure that the AI industry does not become enmeshed in a thicket of overlapping, conflicting state-level laws, and is subject only to a single, federal standard.

Here, we are confronted by an apparent paradox: industry does not seem unanimously enthused by the Trump regime's efforts in this direction. Anthropic, for example, has endorsed, and reportedly even lobbied for, tougher state-level safety standards on AI models.

OpenAI, though less vocally 'doom-er' than Anthropic, has also joined in on calls to 'pace the frontier' of AI development. So far, CEOs have obediently lined up at the Trump regime's gala events celebrating 'super intelligence' and smiled through gritted teeth. But they do not appear fundamentally to agree to the 'let it rip' approach.

David Sacks, VC and one-time Trump AI czar, has not minced his words. He has argued openly that Anthropic is pushing tougher regulations, which only entrenched incumbents have financial and administrative resources to understand and comply with. He has dubbed Anthropic's approach a 'sophisticated regulatory capture strategy based on fear-mongering'. He has also pushed back against the call to 'pace the frontier', essentially arguing that OpenAI and Anthropic are free to develop their product as slowly as they like, but should not invite the government to gum up the works for others.

AI safety-ists, however, now have powerful allies in the new Democrat legislative majority. The party is unlikely to have much love for VCs and other members of the 'tech Right' it sees as having betrayed the values of liberal Silicon Valley. Anthropic and OpenAI may now see light at the end of the tunnel: a post-Trump Washington may now see a return of woke sensibilities, and be more trigger-happy about regulating in response to perceived 'harms'.

Certainly, the populist backlash against data centres isn't in the interests of anybody in the AI industry — incumbents, new entrants, Right or Lefz. But on question of AI safety and regulation, AI incumbents will certainly find open ears in the new Democrat majority.

Milton Friedman once argued that the two biggest enemies of the free market were his fellow intellectuals and the business community: the former think they know best and should dictate on questions of economic planning; the latter don't want competition from new entrants.

So far, the Trump regime has stayed largely true to its conservative credentials in staving off regulatory capture of AI. Indeed, Trump has thumbed his nose at AI-sceptics even on the populist Right. But he has now lost valuable allies for his approach in the legislature. He will now have to face down a legislature dominated by the 'party of intellectuals', and an AI business community no longer without allies in positions of governmental authority.

The writer is senior resident fellow, Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy

THE SPEAKING TREE

Care for Nature

KAMLESH TRIPATHI

Govardhan Puja, also known as Annakut, is celebrated on the 4th day of Deepavali festivities. The festival commemorates Krishn's divine act of lifting the Govardhan Hill on his little finger to protect the people of Braj from the torrential rains sent by Indra, god of rain. Govardhan Puja conveys a timeless message: respect nature, remain humble, and be grateful for resources that sustain life.

It reminds us that true divinity lies not merely in rituals but also in protecting nature and serving all beings. William Wordsworth's poem 'The Tables Turned' celebrates nature as a source of wisdom, moral instruction and spiritual enlightenment. His famous exhortation, 'Come forth into the light of things, Let Nature be your teacher,' encapsulates central philosophy of the poem.

The connection with Govardhan Puja is striking. Krishn teaches the people of Braj that their lives depend upon the hill, forests, rivers and cattle, rather than merely upon elaborate rituals. Similarly, Wordsworth believes that nature offers profound lessons that human beings often fail to recognise.

Both celebrate nature not merely as a physical landscape but as a living source of wisdom and spiritual nourishment. While Krishn protects nature's dependants from Indra's destructive arrogance, Wordsworth urges humanity to approach nature with humility and an open heart.

PEAS IN A PODCAST

The Sound Of Silence

As Delhi-NCR emerges from the Diwali cacophony — the non-stop crackle of firecrackers serves as a noisy reminder that our ears never get a break — this episode of CNN's Chasing Life couldn't feel more timely. Dr Sanjay Gupta sits down with Northwestern neurobiologist Nina Kraus in **The Power of Sound** to explore how our brains make sense of soundscapes around us.

Moving far beyond simple hearing, Kraus explains that processing sound is one of the brain's most demanding tasks. It operates as an active feedback loop shaped by our memories, habits and past experiences.

The episode introduces the concept of a unique 'sonic fingerprint' — even showing what individual brainwaves sound like when processing music — and compares our neural processing to an audio mixing board that balances pitch, rhythm and timbre.

The discussion hits home when contrasting unnecessary urban noise — which acts as a constant, hidden stressor — with intentional sound inputs like music or multi-language learning that strengthen neural connections.

Warm, accessible and practical, Gupta's conversation urges us to actively curate our daily auditory environments and trim out meaningless digital noise.

Using a purely audio medium to unpack the science of sound makes for a refreshing, thought-provoking listen — one that might prompt you to seek out a little extra quiet today.

Chat Room

Small Spokes to Transport Hubs

Apropos the news report, 'India's Three-Wheeler Market Makes a Decisive Electric Turn' (Nov 9), L5 category electric 3-wheelers with higher speed and long-range batteries offered by Mahindra, Bajaj and others cater to the fastest-growing last-mile market. However, e-rickshaws and e-carts, also last-mile connectors, are slow but affordable and with low running cost. They offer short-run passenger and goods movement connectivity with metro stations, bus terminuses and other quick points, providing livelihood to a large number of entry-level operators. With strict legal enforcement, gov policies, improved safety features and more stringent test protocols, e-rickshaw can accelerate and facilitate a major shift of personal vehicle users to the public transport system of metro and buses.

S R Venkatesan
Bengaluru

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India International Tyre Show 2027

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INDIA CYCLE SHOW 2027 International Bicycle & E-Bike Exhibition

nasscom mobility tech pavilion | THE ROAD AHEAD

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COMPETITION INTENSIFIES

Vedant Fashions' Same-Store Sales Drop 5.8% in Q2

Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: India's organised ethnic wear market has become more competitive just as Vedant Fashions, the maker of Manyavar and Mohey, tries to revive growth after several years of muted performance. The company reported a 5.8% decline in same-store sales in the September quarter. Customer sales inched up 0.6% year-on-year while revenue from operations increased 2.4% to ₹269 crore and net profit was flat at ₹56 crore.

Chief revenue officer Vedant Modi attributed much of the quarter's weakness to the shift in the festive calendar, with Navratri moving from September last year to October this year. "The best 10 days were replaced by almost the worst 10 days in our business from a quarter perspective," he said on an earnings call last week.

Vedant Modi acknowledged the urgent need to attract newer consumers and make them buy more

He acknowledged the urgent need to attract newer consumers and make them buy more. "The only thing that we need to do slightly better is newer customers making more buys. If that part of the business is cracked, then we get back to a very good level of growth," he added.

The slowdown, however, predates the calendar shift. Vedant Fashions' revenue grew at a compound annual rate of only about 2.7% between 2022-23 and 2025-26, while its market capitalisation has fallen about 49% since listing, to ₹11,597 crore this month, erasing about ₹11,119 crore in market value.

Third Eyesight founder Devangshu Dutta, said demand moderation had affected the wider market but company-specific expansion decisions also mattered. "There are cases where brands have overextended and opened stores that are not going to be sustainable. If you over-expand, there has to be a correction. Sometimes brands overreach to show momentum in the market," he said.

WIDESPREAD RELEASE: 9,000 SCREENS IN INDIA, 50,000 WORLDWIDE

Ramayana Builds a Stronger Domestic Bridge Amid Global Push

India contributed nearly 60% of the film's ₹664-crore global haul in six days, underscoring strong domestic demand

Rajesh N Naidu

Mumbai: Despite a reported overseas release across nearly 50,000 screens — more than four times its domestic footprint — *Ramayana: Part 1* has drawn close to 60% of its worldwide box-office collections from India in its first six days, with ₹403.9 crore coming from the home market against ₹260 crore overseas, underscoring the enduring pull of domestic audiences even as the film makes an ambitious global play.

The film has been released across nearly 9,000 screens in India, with its overseas rollout expected to cover around 50,000 screens.

Over the past two days, the film, positioned as a global product, has also benefited from the festive mood in India and premium ticket prices, which audiences appear willing to pay for its visual spectacle.

But trade analysts say the film has yet to make a comparable impression on western audiences.

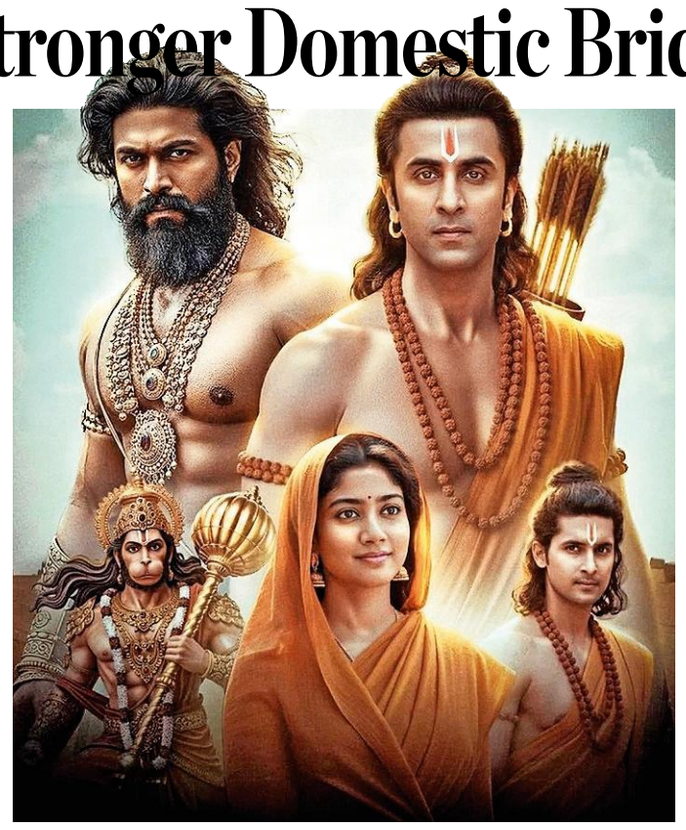
"The claim that *Ramayana: Part 1* would appeal to western audiences has not lived up to expectations," said movie trade analyst Girish Wankhede. "If western audiences had embraced it, it would have topped the global box office, given its potential," he added.

More than a year ago, in an interview with a foreign publication, the film's producer, Namit Malhotra, had said: "In my mind, if people in the West don't like it, I consider that a failure."

Experts in in-film brand merchandising and marketing point to a lack of cultural relatability as a key reason for the film's limited connect with western audiences.

Viewers unfamiliar with the epic, they say, may have missed some of its cultural context and nuances.

"Sufficient investments have been made in promoting the film in the West. But somehow, it seems the western audience has not connected with its storytelling," said Navin Shah, joint managing director of EMC Solutions Worldwide, a company specialising in branded entertainment.



Day-wise collections

In ₹ crore

Day	India Net	Overseas
Day 1	64.8	51.2
Day 2	48	46
Day 3	69.8	71.7
Day 4	56.1	56
Day 5	107.5	35
Day 6	57.6*	NU*

Source: Sacnilk, *till 5 pm November 10
Not Updated on the site

Film scholars see a deeper challenge in the way the story and its characters have been presented.

They argue that the film lacks the complexities and nuances that define its central characters, and that a largely factual, linear and simplified treatment may have come at the cost of emotional depth.

"In an epic narrative, you must clearly define who is the hero and who is the anti-hero. The film is more invested in Ravana than in Ram. The melodrama needed to build the complexities of Ram is missing," said Dr Piyush Roy, dean of the School of Film, Media & Creative Arts at RV University, Bengaluru.

The absence of extended emotional build-ups around pivotal moments, Ram's departure from Ayodhya, Sita's abduction and the reunion of Ram and Bharat, may also have blunted the film's emotional impact, scholars said.

"The film does not have the melodramatic moments that would bring out the complexity of its key characters. The approach that a film must be made simple to appeal to a global audience is problematic. Emotions work everywhere. The West has many stories built around complex characters. *The Odyssey* is a prime example. Even mainstream spectacle films are exploring the backstories of familiar characters such as Spider-Man," Roy said.

The film has also faced competition from *Godzilla Minus Zero*, which trade analysts say has drawn western audiences on the strength of an established franchise and a loyal following.

PTI

Tigers on the Prowl in Bhopal

Over 60 artists from Kerala are participating in the traditional Pulikali (Tiger Dance) road show in Bhopal as part of the third edition of Kerala Fest 2026. The festival celebrates the shared foundation day of Kerala and Madhya Pradesh, which falls on November 1.

Honda to Build $3b Auto Plant in Ohio, Create 2,000 Jobs

Plant will be able to produce 240,000 vehicles annually, production at new facility slated to begin in 2029

Reuters

Washington: Japanese automaker Honda Motor will build a new $3 billion auto plant in Ohio to make hybrid vehicles, creating 2,000 jobs, it said on Monday.

The company said the plant will be able to produce 240,000 vehicles annually and begin production in 2029. It will increase its US auto production capacity to 1.3 million vehicles annually, and North American capacity to 1.9 million.

Honda is also making a C$867 million ($613.6 million) commitment to its Canadian operations, including a C$166 million investment in its Alliston, Ontario, operations, maintaining its 4,000-strong Canadian workforce.

The Canadian government said it is investing C$313 million in the Alliston project.

Honda plans another $338 million investment in Ohio, and unspecified new investments in Georgia and Alabama.

The company announced plans in May to add 15 new Honda and Acura hybrid models worldwide by 2030. It also announced it would scrap electric vehicle sales goals and indefinitely suspended an $11 billion Canada EV project as part of a $9 billion EV writedown.

Honda said it will invest in Alabama to build a new V6 hybrid engine and retool its Ohio engine plant to build a new four-cylinder engine. It will also retool transmission plants in Ohio and Georgia, and plans to reintroduce engine production in Ontario.

A number of foreign automakers have announced major new investments as they face tariffs imposed by President Donald Trump's administration.

Last month, Volkswagen luxury unit Audi said it would build a $4 billion assembly plant near Macon, Georgia to open in the early 2030s that would produce 200,000 SUVs annually and employ 4,500 workers.

Reuters reported last month that Trump's administration had promised tariff relief to Audi to help secure the plant's future. US officials told Audi executives the government plans to offer broad relief from tariffs for automakers making significant investments in US production.

JLR Sees India as Key Growth Mkt, to Launch EV in 2027

Plans to bring Range Rover Electric and Range Rover Sport Electric as it looks to tap demand in premium segment

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) sees India as a key growth market and plans to introduce its first electric vehicles here in 2027, including the Range Rover Electric and Range Rover Sport Electric, as the luxury automaker looks to tap emerging opportunities in the premium EV segment, its India Managing Director and CEO, Rajan Amba, said.

Amba said the company will also introduce the new Jaguar GT next year, with the product launches spread across different periods.

"Electric is the way forward," he said, adding that the timing was appropriate for the company to enter the Indian electric vehicle market.

JLR India, which does not have an electric vehicle in its portfolio, is encouraged by the growth witnessed in the EV market over the past year across both premium and more accessible segments.

The luxury automaker plans to import the electric models to test their market response initially.

"We've seen brands in the more accessible segments also gain, and I think that we should also see a lot of benefit from it," Amba said.

He, however, said it was too early to draw conclusions about the potential response to JLR's electric offerings in India, given that the company would be entering the segment for the first time.

Amba said the pace of electric vehicle adoption varied across countries and consumer groups, with charging infrastructure and resale value remaining important considerations for buyers.

"There's a lot of infrastructure work to be done. There's a lot of peace of mind to be given to customers in terms of charging infrastructure, in terms of resale values, etc., but all of that has been improving, infrastructure-wise, resale value-wise," he said.

He noted that the foundational elements of the Indian EV market were getting stronger, aided by improvements in infrastructure and initiatives by the Centre and state governments, including incentives for electric cars.

Zara Owner Backs New Fund to Cut Supply Chain Emissions

Bloomberg

Inditex SA is backing a fund set up to grant low-cost loans to suppliers that invest in energy efficiency, as the fashion industry faces pressure to cut its carbon footprint.

The textile industry accounts for as much as 8% of global greenhouse gas emissions, as per the UN

In a private-public partnership that chief executive officer Óscar García Maceiras says is the first of its kind, the world's biggest fashion retailer has committed $50 million to the fund, which is led by the International Finance Corporation, the World Bank's private-sector arm. IFC plans to raise $400 million to help small companies transition to net-zero business models.

As much as 8% of global greenhouse gas emissions come from the textile industry, according to United Nations estimates. At the same time, many suppliers are located in developing countries that are particularly vulnerable to weather extremes associated with rising temperatures. Suppliers in such markets need better access to funds to pay for the better machinery and cheaper, renewable energy that they need to adapt.

Emissions are "connected with all of the processes" contained within the fashion industry's supply chain, García Maceiras said in an interview.

Uni-President Eyes Jardine's KFC, Pizza Hut Ops in Asia

Hong Kong: Taiwanese food group Uni-President Enterprises is in advanced talks to buy Jardine Matheson's restaurant business that runs KFC and Pizza Hut chains in several Asian markets, two people with knowledge of the matter said.

The deal could value Jardine Restaurant Group at about $400 million, one of the people said.

An agreement could be reached before year end, although the terms are not finalised and uncertainty remains, they said, declining to be named as the information was confidential.

Reuters reported in May that Carlyle Group and Yum China were also among parties that had expressed interest in the business.

A Jardine Matheson spokesperson declined to comment.

JRG Communications referred Reuters' questions to Jardine Matheson, its parent company, saying the inquiries related to Jardine Matheson.

Uni-President did not respond to a Reuters request for comment. —**Reuters**

ANALYSIS OF 125+ CLINICAL TRIALS

US FDA Adds Eye-Risk Warning for Ozempic, Other GLP-1 Drugs

Washington: Popular weight-loss drugs including Ozempic and Wegovy will carry a new warning about a possible rare side effect that can sometimes lead to permanent vision loss, US health regulators announced Monday.

The Food and Drug Administration said the risk will be added to the labelling of all GLP-1 drugs, the blockbuster medications used to treat obesity, diabetes and several other medical conditions. The class includes a dozen injectable or pill-based drugs, including widely used brands like Zepbound and Mounjaro.

The eye condition, known as non-arteritic anterior ischemic optic neuropathy, can cause significant vision loss. The problem, which has been reported with all GLP-1 drugs, occurs due to decreased blood flow to the optic nerve, although the underlying cause isn't understood, the FDA said.

FDA scientists began looking into the problem after the publication of a 2024 medical paper tying the condition to certain patients taking semaglutide, the active drug in Novo Nordisk's Ozempic.

An FDA analysis of more than 125 clinical trials found that the problem occurred in roughly 6 of every 100,000 patients who took a GLP-1 for at least one year. The comparable rate for people taking a placebo or other types of glucose-lowering medications was less than 4 per 100,000, the FDA said.

Condition linked to reduced blood flow to the optic nerve was seen in about 6 per 100,000 patients taking GLP-1 drugs for a year or more

The agency also found reports of the problem in its electronic tracking system for drug injuries and side effects.

Symptoms of the problem include blurred vision, blind spots, distorted colours and other visual disturbances, according to the FDA. Patients experiencing such problems should contact a health care professional immediately, the agency said. **AP**

Botswana to Raise Stake in De Beers to 30%

AP

Gaborone, Botswana: Botswana's president said Monday that the diamond-rich southern African country will double its stake in De Beers to 30% under a proposed deal by a consortium of investors to buy Anglo American's shares in the company.

President Duma Boko said in a speech in parliament that the move would make Botswana the largest single shareholder in De Beers, the world's leading diamond company. Boko said Botswana endorsed the Global Diamond Consortium of investors as the proposed buyer of De Beers.

Mining giant Anglo American put its 85% stake in De Beers up for sale in 2024 as part of a broader restructuring focused on minerals expected to boom from the transition to green energy and a downturn in the diamond market. As De Beers' other shareholder, Botswana's backing of the Global Diamond Consortium is key for the deal to proceed.

The purchase by the consortium, which is led by former De Beers CEO Gareth Penny, has not been finalised.

Move Over Superman, Latcham's Here

James Gunn & Peter Safran to step down as co-CEOs of DC Studios; Marvel veteran to take over

AP

New York: Superman, Batman and the rest of the DC heroes are getting a new boss, yet again.

Skydance Motion Picture Group announced Monday that James Gunn and Peter Safran are stepping down as co-chief executives after four years leading DC Studios. Although their first film leading the superhero factory, *Superman*, reached theatres only last year, their DC run has come to an abrupt end.

Gunn and Safran initially survived Skydance's acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery. The studio's merger with Paramount Pictures was finalised just as DC's *Clayface* was released.

However, it turns out Gunn and Safran aren't surviving the merger. Instead, Skydance chairman and chief executive David Ellison is turning to Jeremy Latcham, a veteran of Marvel Studios, to steer DC.

"James and Peter launched a new era for DC Studios and led it through a period of real transformation, resetting the foundation and building a slate we're incredibly proud of," Ellison said in a statement. "We're grateful for their passion, contributions and commitment to this legendary brand."

Latcham was a leading executive for Marvel, including the first wave of the Marvel Cinematic Universe with *Iron Man* and *The Avengers*. He also worked with Gunn and Safran on their *Guardians of the Galaxy*. The changeover will take effect December 1. But a long pipeline of projects already in production ensures that Gunn and Safran's fingerprints will be on DC Studios for a while to come. Gunn is currently in postproduction on the *Superman* follow-up, *Man of Tomorrow*. Other upcoming releases include the series *The People v. Gorilla Grodd* and *The Batman: Part II*.

Peter Safran (left) and James Gunn. Getty images

The leadership change takes effect Dec 1, with Latcham assuming the roles of president and chief creative officer

But the decade's worth of planning that Gunn and Safran instituted will no longer come to fruition. Their reign has been characterised by more idiosyncratic comic book adaptations and genre gambles, like *Clayface*, which fused superhero with horror. (It's grossed $109 million so far.) Earlier this year, *Supergirl* flopped, a major setback in just their second release.

Latcham takes on the roles of president and chief creative officer of DC Studios. He will report to Dana Goldberg and Josh Greenstein, co-chairs of Skydance Motion Picture Group. "Jeremy brings a deep reverence for DC and its passionate fanbase, recognising that they are the very foundation of this storied, multigenerational brand," Goldberg and Greenstein said.

Gunn's biggest success leading DC was *Superman*, which struck a decidedly different and more comedic tone than the previous treatments of the iconic hero in Zack Snyder's *Man of Steel*. But it also didn't reach the box-office heights of the biggest superhero hits, grossing $618.7 million worldwide.

From the start, Gunn, a prodigious filmmaker, was an unusual choice for such a prominent corporate leadership role. In exiting DC, he seemed eager to concentrate again on writing and directing.

"We're excited to return to what drew us to this job in the first place, which is telling the stories we love, including the next chapter of Clark and Lex's journey in *Man of Tomorrow*," Gunn and Safran said in a statement.

Latcham had been out of the superhero business. In 2017, he departed Marvel to set up Latcham Pictures, producing films including *Dungeons & Dragons: Honor Among Thieves* and *Bad Times at the El Royale*. "I've had the privilege to help bring some of the most celebrated superhero stories to life on the big screen, and I'm excited and honoured for the opportunity to now lead DC Studios into its next era," Latcham said.

Air India Shortlists Ex-SIA Executive for CFO Role

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Air India has shortlisted Balagopal Kunduvara, a former senior executive at Singapore Airlines and former finance chief of Garuda Indonesia, for the position of chief financial officer (CFO), as the Tata Group-owned carrier seeks to strengthen its financial management amid mounting losses and an ongoing cost-reduction exercise.

Kunduvara, who spent more than two decades at Singapore Airlines, has emerged as a frontrunner for the position, according to people familiar with the development. He recently left his position as CFO of Garuda Indonesia, where he had served for a little over a year.

His potential appointment comes at a critical juncture for Air India, which is attempting to rein in costs and return to profitability after reporting losses of more than Rs 22,000 crore in the last financial year. The airline's new chief executive, Tewolde Gebremariam, has identified cost reduction and improving operational efficiency as key priorities in the carrier's turnaround strategy.

Air India has set up a dedicated cross-functional team to identify savings across its operations and tightened expenditure approval processes. The airline is also looking to integrate key functions between Air India and its low-cost subsidiary, Air India Express, to improve efficiencies and eliminate duplication.

Kunduvara's experience at Singapore Airlines, one of Air India's shareholders, could be particularly relevant as the Indian carrier attempts to improve financial discipline while continuing with its ambitious fleet expansion and transformation programme. Singapore Airlines holds a stake in Air India alongside the Tata Group.

The airline is also facing pressure from elevated aviation turbine fuel prices and geopolitical disruptions, including restrictions on the use of Pakistani airspace, which have increased flying times and operating costs on several westbound routes.

बिहार सरकार

इस छठ पर आयें बिहार, अपनों के संग मनाएँ त्योहार

इस छठ महापर्व में अपने घर, अपने गांव और अपनी मिट्टी की ओर आयें
और अपनों के साथ अपनी संस्कृति का पर्व मनाएं

बिहार है तैयार

छठ महापर्व
की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएँ

सम्राट चौधरी
मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

सूचना एवं जन-सम्पर्क विभाग, बिहार

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Frontier models, with lots of test time compute, are becoming the engine of scientific discovery

Tech Buzz

AI Co Anthropic Unveils 2 New Claude Models

NEW DELHI: AI giant Anthropic has launched two upgraded models—Claude Fable 5.2 and Claude Mythos 5.2—to advance advanced coding, mathematics, cybersecurity, robotics and scientific research, with capabilities designed to handle complex technical tasks autonomously for extended periods. Anthropic said Claude Fable and Claude Mythos are based on the same underlying model. "Fable has strong cybersecurity and biology safeguards to guard against misuse, which allows us to make it available to all users. Organisations pursuing beneficial applications in cybersecurity or biomedical research can apply for access to Mythos through our expanded Life Sciences and Cyber Verification Programs," the statement said. Fable 5.2 is designed for general users, including availability through cloud platforms. Mythos 5.2 offers access to advanced capabilities involving vulnerability discovery and sensitive scientific research. – **Agencies**

$200b
Estimated AI software revenue growth in 2026, double the 2024 level – Omdia

Meta Expands AI Age Checks for Insta Teens

WASHINGTON: Meta Platforms has said that it would expand its AI age-estimation tech globally to move millions more teens on Instagram into Teen Account protections, even if they have given birth dates showing they are adults, as the company faces lawsuits alleging its platforms harm young users. Teen Accounts, available on Instagram, Facebook and Messenger, include built-in protections that automatically limit who can contact teens, the content they see and their time on the apps. Parents in the US will begin receiving Instagram notifications this month explaining how teens are placed in age-appropriate protections, Meta said. In Australia, Meta has begun using Apple's age-range signal as an additional method to help determine users' ages. – **Reuters**

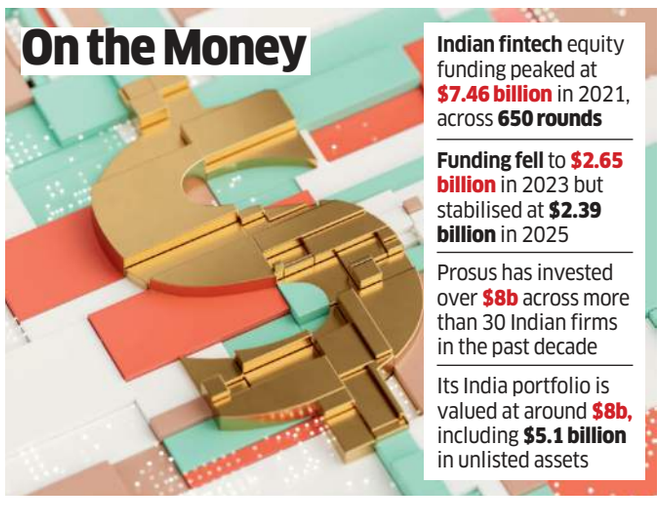
Jargon Buster

Token

A token is a basic unit of text that an LLM uses to understand and generate language. A token may be an entire word or parts of a word

Tighter Risk Filters Guide Prosus' New India Fintech Push

India chief emphasises high selectivity, adds that passing on deals 'is a feature, not a bug'



Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: Prosus, which has invested $100 million in Sachin Bansal-founded Navi, around $80 million in supply-chain financing platform Mintifi and $100 million in Vastu Housing Finance over the past two years, plans to step up its fintech investments in India, a senior executive at the firm told ET.

The Amsterdam-listed technology investor is also close to investing in artificial intelligence-led credit management startup Oolka, people familiar with the matter said. Prosus evaluated credit-on-Unified Payments Interface (UPI) startup Kiwi in October and savings platform Jar in 2025 before deciding not to invest. Prosus declined to comment on specific deals.

The investor is scouting for financial services companies where technology can either bring underserved customers into the formal financial system or improve underwriting, servicing and collection costs in lending.

"You will see us over-indexing on financial services," Ashutosh Sharma, head of Prosus India, told ET. He said the recent investments were a part of a shift that has gathered pace over the past two to three years. ET exclusively reported the Navi deal on June 9 and first reported the discussions with Oolka on October 7. Prosus has also backed small-business lender GrowXCD.

The move marks a shift for an India portfolio built largely around consumer internet companies, including Swiggy, Meesho, Urban Company and PharmEasy, followed by investments in businesses such as Rapido and Ixigo. For much of that period, PayU was Prosus' main financial services exposure in India.

FILLING THE FINTECH GAP

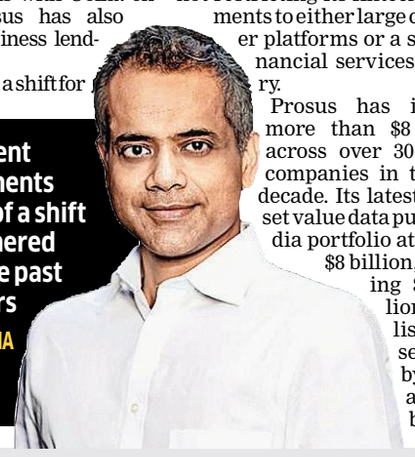
Equity funding into Indian fintech companies peaked at $7.46 billion across 650 rounds in 2021 before declining to $4.42 billion in 2022 and $2.65 billion in 2023, according to Tracxn. It has since remained relatively steady at $2.2 billion in 2024 and $2.39 billion in 2025, with $2.27 billion invested across 172 rounds so far this year.

PayU gave Prosus exposure to payments, business credit and financial services infrastructure, while the Navi investment added a broader consumer-facing business spanning UPI payments, lending, mutual funds and insurance.

"There was a gap in B2C (business-to-consumer). So I think that's what we're trying to fill with Navi," Sharma said.

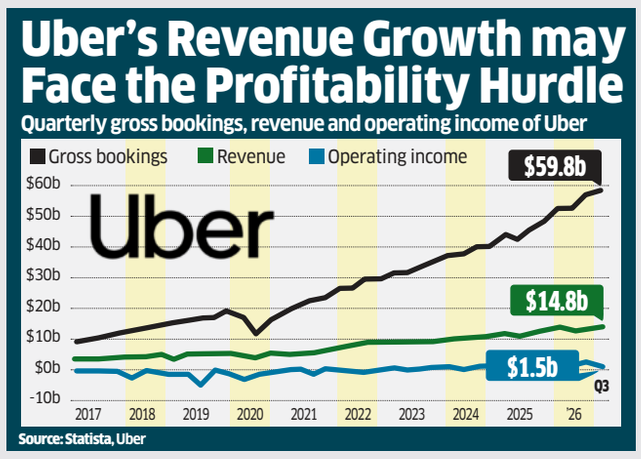
Vastu gives Prosus exposure to secured housing finance, while Mintifi lends to distributors and dealers within corporate supply chains. The mix shows Prosus is not restricting its fintech investments to either large consumer platforms or a single financial services category.

Prosus has invested more than $8 billion across over 30 Indian companies in the past decade. Its latest net asset value data puts its India portfolio at around $8 billion, including $5.1 billion of unlisted assets led by PayU at $3.6 billion.



The recent investments were a part of a shift that has gathered pace over the past two to 3 years
ASHUTOSH SHARMA
Head, Prosus India

Tech Trotter Meanwhile in tech...



UK Banks Cut AI Exposure Amid Correction Fears

LONDON: UK banks have begun trimming exposure to artificial intelligence as alarm mounts about a brutal correction in the sector, according to the Bank of England's top supervisor. In her first interview since taking over the Prudential Regulation Authority in July, Katharine Braddick said the BOE's extensive interrogation of banks' AI exposure hasn't shown that lenders would be an "amplifier" of any AI shock. Still, the central bank isn't being complacent. The BOE is not currently planning to use capital rules to encourage lower exposures, she said. — **Bloomberg**

Quick Commerce Delivers Huge Festive Triumph for D2C Brands

Considered buying & premium gifting trends offset broader wallet worries this holiday season

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Direct-to-consumer (D2C) brands across fashion, beauty and personal care (BPC), healthy snacks, gifting and puja essentials saw strong sales growth this festive season, with several doubling their sales from a year earlier, even as shoppers grew more cautious about what they bought, founders told ET.

Beauty brand Pilgrim and healthy snacks brand Open Secret both doubled their sales year-on-year (YoY) during the festive period, driven largely by purchases on quick commerce platforms.

"Quick commerce has accounted for 65% of our overall sales this year as consumers are moving to rapid delivery options for shopping from ecommerce," said Ahana Gautam, founder of Open Secret. "We see the shopping spike of about 5x on the festival day and then a day or two after that also there is demand."

Women's ethnic wear brand Suta saw festive sales rise about 15% over last year. "While we think our growth has been strong, we felt consumers have been cautious of their buying decisions. Instead of opting for trendy options, many of our consumers opted for more practical stock-keeping units (SKUs)," said founder Sujata Biswas.

Lifestyle brand DailyObjects, which reported 48% year-on-year sales growth so far this festive season, saw a similar shift in buying behaviour. "Purchases are becoming more considered, with customers showing a preference for higher-value products while buying slightly fewer items per order. We have also seen sales become more concentrated around promotional periods," said founder Pankaj Garg.

Industry experts attributed this caution to uncertainty in the global economy arising from the geopolitical situation, as well as to layoffs. Its wider effect was visible in purchases of mobile phones and laptops, which fell more than expected this year.

Analysts said muted demand for electronics is likely to pull down the overall gross merchandise value (GMV) of goods sold on online platforms during the festive period. GMV is the total value of goods sold before discounts and returns are deducted.

ET reported on October 19 that online delivery dispatches during the first 10 days of Amazon's Great Indian Festival and Flipkart's Big Billion Days ran 10-12% below the year-ago period.

Ecommerce marketplaces and online retailers were expected to sell a record ₹1.50-1.55 lakh crore worth of goods during this year's festive sale events, up 25-29% from around ₹1.20 lakh crore in 2025, according to market research firm Datum Intelligence, ET reported earlier.

GIFTING DRIVES QCOMM RUSH

After a slow start to ecommerce festive sales in October, quick commerce saw a shopping rush around micro-occasions, as consumers turned to rapid delivery for gifting.

Perfume brand Secret Alchemist, cofounded by actor Samantha Ruth Prabhu, reported 7x growth this festive season. "This year, almost more than 65% of our sales came from versions of gift boxes, including build-your-own-box schemes that we had," said Secret Alchemist's cofounder Akash Valia, adding that consumers opted for premium products.

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Lenskart, Meesho Shine Bright in SoftBank's Listed Global Portfolio

Lenskart, Meesho deliver nearly $400m gains for SoftBank Vision funds

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Japanese technology investor SoftBank's Vision Funds saw gains of nearly $400 million from its investments in Lenskart and Meesho during the September quarter, as the two Indian startups emerged among the strongest performers in its listed portfolio globally.

Its Lenskart investment saw returns of $273 million during the quarter, the highest among Vision Funds' listed investments, while Meesho gained $121 million, according to SoftBank's earnings presentation released on Tuesday. The gains come as SoftBank continues to monetise its Indian investments, having sold shares worth more than ₹9,300 crore in Lenskart and Meesho since June.

"Investment monetisation is actually going smoothly. Steady progress has been made," SoftBank chief financial officer Yoshimitsu Goto said during the post-earnings call, adding that cumulative sales of Lenskart shares totalled about $1.5 billion. ET reported in June that SoftBank had clocked nearly sevenfold returns from a ₹2,873 crore stake sale in Lenskart. It subsequently sold shares worth ₹2,888 crore in August, taking its aggregate returns to 5.7x. Last week, the investor sold another ₹1,896 crore worth of shares, reducing its holding to 5.71%.

Separately, SoftBank sold Meesho shares worth ₹1,650 crore in September, generating about threefold returns on its investment, ET reported.

SoftBank valued its remaining holdings in Lenskart and Meesho at approximately $900 million and $800 million, respectively, as of September 30. Its Lenskart investment has generated 6.1x returns, including realised proceeds and the value of its remaining stake. The performance marks a recovery from the January-March quarter, when SoftBank's listed Indian portfolio recorded more than $600 million in mark-to-market losses, led by Swiggy, Ola Electric, Meesho, Delhivery and FirstCry, ET reported in May.

SoftBank Books $7b Loss on US Data Centre Hit

TOKYO: SoftBank Group, the Japanese investment giant with big bets on AI, said on Tuesday it had swung to a second-quarter net loss of $7 billion, hit hard by hefty buildout costs for data centres in the US and increases in financing payments. The pain inflicted this quarter by a subsidiary's advance payments for power generation equipment could, however, be offset by rebates for future purchases. SoftBank's borrowing may be of greater concern, with financing costs more than doubling during July-September. The group raised $56.5 billion during the period — its highest ever quarterly total — as founder Masayoshi Son continues to pursue aggressive investment in AI. — **Reuters**

Tata Electronics Told to File ATR After Gas Leak Deaths

Three workers die of toxic gas inhalation while performing maintenance

Our Bureau

Chennai: Apple supplier Tata Electronics has been directed to review the safety performance of agencies maintaining the effluent treatment plant (ETP) at its Krishnagiri facility after three contract workers died during maintenance work.

"The company has also been directed to submit a detailed action taken report (ATR) covering the circumstances leading to the accident, lapses identified, corrective measures undertaken and a clear preventive action plan to ensure that such incidents do not recur," Krishnagiri district collector C Dinesh Kumar told ET on Tuesday.

The district administration is closely monitoring the situation and would ensure that the "necessary safety measures" are implemented before the ETP resumes operations, he added.

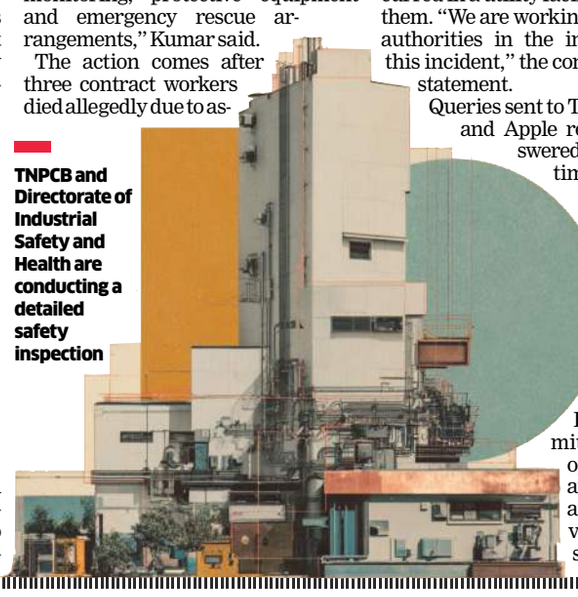
Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB) and Directorate of Industrial Safety and Health (DISH) are also conducting a detailed safety inspection. "The inspection will particularly examine the safety procedures followed during maintenance activities, including confined-space entry, gas monitoring, protective equipment and emergency rescue arrangements," Kumar said.

The action comes after three contract workers died allegedly due to asphyxiation at the plant on Monday evening.

Industrial water management firm Nalco Water said the incident occurred in a utility facility operated by them. "We are working with the local authorities in the investigation of this incident," the company said in a statement.

Queries sent to Tata Electronics and Apple remained unanswered until press time on Tuesday.

Kumar said there is no proposal to shut down the entire Tata Electronics plant at present. However, he said, the ETP will be permitted to resume operations only after concerned authorities provide the necessary clearance.



TNPCB and Directorate of Industrial Safety and Health are conducting a detailed safety inspection

Globe Trotter

China Touts Tech, AI Cred at World Web Summit

BEIJING: China is flexing its tech muscles at the global Web Summit in Lisbon from Tuesday, showcasing dancing robots and low-cost AI models as Beijing weathers claims that it spied on the AI chip powerhouse Nvidia. "Increasingly, the superstars of the future are not coming from California. They're coming from China," Web Summit founder Paddy Cosgrave told the opening ceremony on Monday. – **Agencies**

Moonshot Rents Nvidia's Top AI Chips in China

SHANGHAI: Moonshot AI accessed a trove of Nvidia's most advanced chips this summer, as per documents filed with Beijing regulators, highlighting the Chinese artificial intelligence champion's reliance on American hardware despite US export restrictions. The firm signed a contract in August to rent 32 Super Micro Computer servers equipped with Nvidia's B300 GPUs . – **Bloomberg**

Apple Intelligence Registered in China for iPads, Macs Use

BEIJING: The cyberspace regulator in China's Shanghai said on Monday Apple's generative AI service, Apple Intelligence, has been registered for use on tablets and laptops in China. China requires companies to register large language models and generative AI services with regulators before making them available to the public. The firm received China's approval to roll out Apple Intelligence on iPhones in July. – **Reuters**

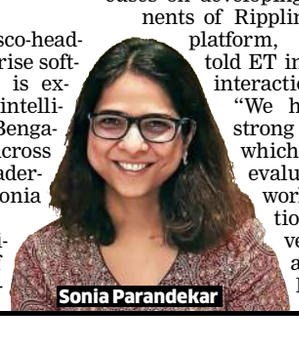
HR Firm Rippling Ups India AI Hiring to Anchor Enterprise Push

Eyes engineers to scale evaluation frameworks & sandboxing infra

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: San Francisco-headquartered HR and enterprise software company Rippling is expanding its artificial intelligence (AI) laboratory in Bengaluru, stepping up hiring across senior engineering and leadership roles, its India head Sonia Parandekar said.

The firm is hiring principal engineers, senior staff engineers and senior directors among others as the lab focuses on developing core components of Rippling's global AI platform, Parandekar told ET in an exclusive interaction.


Sonia Parandekar

"We have a really strong team here which is driving evaluation frameworks and evaluation-driven development across all of Rippling," she said. "A lot of the infrastructure scaling and sandboxing work is also happening from here."

India is Rippling's largest office outside San Francisco, with about 2,000 employees, including more than 500 engineers. Other employees are spread across customer support, operations, implementation and sales. The company launched a dedicated AI Lab at its campus in Bengaluru in September.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO
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Google's New AI Silicon is Wired for the Age of Agent Revolution

New TPU 8tx & 8i Max directly target regulated enterprise sectors

Bloomberg

New York: Alphabet's Google is rolling out a broader array of artificial intelligence chips, aiming to capitalize on its rapid ascent as a challenger to Nvidia in a market worth hundreds of billions of dollars.

The company is introducing two new variations of its tensor processing units, or TPUs, custom-made semiconductors that help develop and run AI software. The latest chips will address the need for confidential computing and help models access a wider range of information when handling queries. They're meant to serve an industry that's shifting toward the use of AI agents and confronting security challenges. Alphabet shares gained 4.1% to $296.33 in New York trading on Monday.

The rollout marks an acceleration in product development for Google's chip unit. The business once released a new AI processor every two years. This year, it put out two at the same time. The latest offerings will add additional varieties of those chips. The announcement comes at a weak moment for Nvidia, which is embroiled in a crisis over CEO Jensen Huang acknowledging an affair with an alleged Chinese spy.

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AROUND THE WORLD

Trump Says War Effectively Over; Oil Tanks

BOND YIELDS SURGE

Gold Declines Over 2% as US Inflation Fuels Rate Hike Bets

Gold prices fell more than 2% on Tuesday after hotter-than-expected US inflation data lifted the dollar and Treasury yields, while reinforcing expectations of a more hawkish Federal Reserve stance.

Spot gold was down 2.1% at $4,051.50 per ounce by 9:27 a.m. ET (1427 GMT). US gold futures for December delivery fell 1.34% to $4,059.30 per ounce.

"Both the overall number CPI and the core CPI came in a shade above estimates. All in all, it wasn't as great as the markets were hoping for," said Edward Meir, an analyst at Marex.

The Consumer Price Index rose 0.4% last month after advancing 0.6% in September, the Labor Department's Bureau of Labor Statistics said. Economists polled by Reuters had forecast a 0.3% month-on-month rise.

Expectations of a 50-basis-point Fed rate hike in December began to build after the inflation data and comments by Fed Governor Christopher Waller, who said he would support more aggressive action if the CPI report came in too hot.

The probability of a 25-basis-point rate cut was fully priced in, while the possibility of a 50-basis-point hike rose to around 13.6%, from zero before the data, according to CME's FedWatch Tool.

The US dollar index, which measures the greenback against a basket of major currencies, rose, while Treasury yields climbed.

A stronger dollar makes gold more expensive for holders of other currencies, while higher Treasury yields increase the opportunity cost of holding non-yielding bullion, reducing its appeal to investors.

The Monetary Authority of Singapore said on Tuesday it would launch a vaulting service to hold bullion for foreign central banks and lower taxes for some companies in the gold market as it seeks to capture a larger share of the precious metals trade. Spot silver fell 2.9% to $51.86 per ounce, while palladium was down 1% at $1,031.20. **Reuters**

Cochin Shipyard Net Profit Falls 50% to ₹54 crore in Q2

New Delhi: Cochin Shipyard Ltd on Tuesday reported a 50% decline in consolidated net profit to Rs 53.77 crore for the quarter ended September, compared with Rs 107.52 crore in the year-ago period, according to a regulatory filing.

Total income rose to Rs 1,331.81 crore in the September quarter of FY27 from Rs 1,245.88 crore a year earlier.

Total expenses increased to Rs 1,256.71 crore from Rs 1,095.97 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous financial year.

The company's board also approved an interim dividend of Rs 3 per equity share of Rs 5 each, representing a 60% payout, for FY27. **PTI**

AI'S BIG MARKET SPLASH

Anthropic Targets $90 Billion IPO at $1.4 Trillion Valuation

New York: Anthropic PBC is seeking a fully diluted valuation of about $1.4 trillion in its initial public offering, in a bid to make history as the first frontier artificial intelligence lab to go public.

The Claude chatbot maker and its co-founders are seeking to raise as much as $90.4 billion in the IPO and a private placement. The base offering would raise up to $64.4 billion, with shares marketed for $70 to $78 each, according to a filing on Tuesday with the US Securities and Exchange Commission. Anthropic is offering 801.4 million shares, while backers are selling 23.6 million shares.

The figure also includes a private placement set to raise $26 billion in aggregate, to Advanced Micro Devices Inc., Broadcom Inc., Alphabet Inc.'s Google, Micron Technology Inc., Microsoft Corp., Nvidia Corp. and Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co., the filing shows.

At the top of the price range, Anthropic would have a market value of about $1 trillion, based on the shares outstanding listed in the filing. Accounting for employee stock options, restricted shares and stock reserved for the company's charitable donation matching program, Anthropic would have a fully diluted value of about $1.4 trillion.

Anthropic's ambitious target, including the private placement, would hit roughly $100 billion when including a so-called over-allotment option or greenshoe, Bloomberg News calculations show. That would top SpaceX's $75 billion base offering, or the $86.2 billion it raised with the greenshoe.

The goal defies jitters from a sharp selloff in AI-related stocks last week, driven by expectations that politicians promising tougher regulation of data centers and related infrastructure will drive up costs and limit development of the technology.

Investors are under pressure to decide whether valuations in AI reflect a plausible trajectory for a technology that many expect to transform the economy and society as a whole, or overconfidence in an investment theme that hasn't yet proven its staying power.

The widespread adoption of Claude Code and rival tools by software developers point to the potential transformation of a wide range of professional activity, from discovering new miracle drugs to navigating complex legal and accounting rules to running a factory. Already, more than 90% of contributions to Anthropic's code base were written by Claude, the filing shows.

Anthropic has introduced so-called vertical solutions in these areas, with particular emphasis on healthcare and life sciences. It counts Novartis AG Chief Executive Officer Vas Narasimhan as one of its board members. The company's seven co-founders, including CEO Dario Amodei, are offering 3.38 million shares each in the IPO, the filing shows. The IPO is set to price on Wednesday, Nov. 18 and trade the following day, according to terms of the deal reviewed Bloomberg.

Sales are surging. The company reported a revenue run rate of $81 billion as of Oct. 31, up $10 billion from the end of September, the filing shows. Anthropic had a $65 billion run rate figure at the end of July, Bloomberg News reported. **Bloomberg**

Key milestones

May 2021: Founded by siblings Dario and Daniela Amodei, Anthropic raises $124 million in its Series A round.

April 2022: Raises $580 million in a Series B funding round.

Mar 2023: Launches Claude, its large language model competing with OpenAI.

May-Oct: Raises $450 million, followed by investment commitments of up to $6 billion from Google and Amazon.

Mar 2024: Unveils Claude 3, claiming its top model, Opus, outperforms rival models from OpenAI and Google on several benchmarks.

Aug-Nov: Faces a copyright lawsuit by authors over Claude's training data. Amazon commits another $4 billion.

From AI Startup to Mega IPO

Mar 2025: Raises $3.5 billion at a $61.5 billion valuation.

Sep: Raises $13 billion at a $183 billion valuation and unveils Claude 4.5.

Feb-Mar 2026: Raises $30 billion at a $380 billion valuation. Faces a US government backlash over restrictions on military use of its AI and sues to block a proposed national security blacklist designation.

Apr 2026: Unveils Mythos, its most advanced AI model, focused on defensive cybersecurity.

May-Jun: Raises $65 billion at a $965 billion valuation and confidentially files for a US IPO.

Jul-Aug: Wins court approval for a $1.5 billion authors' copyright settlement. Faces a separate lawsuit from music publisher Round Hill Music. Annual revenue run rate tops $65 billion

Oct: Investors reassess Anthropic's IPO valuation following financial disclosures. The company confirms plans for a major public listing.

Nov: Launches its IPO roadshow, seeking to raise up to $64.4 billion at a fully diluted valuation of about $1.4 trillion.

STRATEGIC INVESTMENT

Blackstone to Buy 16% in IIFL Fin for ₹5,000cr

Promoters & Anchorage Capital join ₹6,414 crore equity raise to strengthen lender's balance sheet

Our Bureau

Kolkata: IIFL Finance's board announced on Tuesday that Blackstone, the world's largest alternative asset manager, will infuse $535 million (about ₹5,000 crore) in Indian currency as primary equity into the company for a fully diluted stake of about 16%

This is part of a total equity raising of ₹6,414 crore by the Nirmal Jain-promoted non-banking financial company. Jain and co-promoter R Venkataraman will invest ₹1,264 crore through warrants. Anchorage Capital, promoted by Mumbai-based investor Rohit Kothari, will join the deal with an investment of ₹150 crore.

IIFL Finance and its promoters signed a definitive agreement with Blackstone and Anchorage Capital on Tuesday.

"This partnership is about more than capital. Blackstone brings deep experience in building market-leading businesses in India, strong governance discipline, and a global perspective," Jain said. "The investment strengthens our balance sheet and gives us the headroom to scale our franchises, invest further in technology, and deepen our co-lending partnerships with banks, while staying disciplined on risk and capital."

ET reported on Tuesday that Blackstone would invest ₹5,000 crore in IIFL Finance, while Anchorage Capital and the promoters would also join in this investment round.

The deal was concluded after months of intense deliberations. Initially, Blackstone began discussions with Fairfax, which was looking to exit its 13% holding in IIFL Finance. American private equity firm Advent International Corp and Singapore's Temasek Holdings had also shown interest at that stage. Later, the talks evolved around primary equity infusion instead of a stake buy from Fairfax, according to people aware of the matter. Advent International Corp remained in the fray till the last stage, they said.

The investment will raise the lender's capital adequacy ratio to about 30% from 17% and support the next phase of growth across its secured lending businesses. This could improve the company's credit ratings and subsequently lower its borrowing costs.

Blackstone will invest through a preferential allotment of compulsorily convertible preference shares, which will convert into equity shares at ₹602 per share within 18 months of allotment.

IIFL Finance shares closed at Rs 627.05 apiece on BSE, up about 36% over the past six months.

The company will hold an extraordinary general meeting on December 4 to seek shareholders' approval for the transaction, along with the redesignation of R Venkataraman from joint managing director to non-executive non-independent director.

Studded Jewellery & Premium Watches to Drive Titan Growth

Jewellery segment leads growth as watches, eyewear & engineering businesses strengthen earnings outlook

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Titan Company reported strong revenue and profit growth in the September quarter, supported by buoyancy in studded jewellery despite flat buyer growth. The watches-to-jewellery-to-eyewear company expects buyer growth to improve as gold prices stabilise, aided by a prolonged wedding season. Lower-carat and lightweight jewellery offerings are also helping attract value-conscious consumers.

Strong traction in studded jewellery, which now accounts for 35% of sales, continued expansion of Tanishq and CaratLane, premiumisation in watches, improving profitability in eyewear and rapid growth in Titan Engineering & Automation (TEAL) are expected to drive future earnings. Titan shares rose 3.6% over three trading sessions following the quarterly results announced on Thursday.

Consumer gold purchases were impacted during the quarter by elevated and volatile gold prices. While stable gold prices are necessary to bring customers back to stores, affordable jewellery formats such as 18K, 14K and lightweight collections should help widen Titan's customer base and improve volumes over time.

Studded jewellery remains one of the company's strongest growth drivers. The category grew 32% year-on-year during the quarter, compared with 16% growth a year ago, aided by design-led collections and diamond-focused campaigns. The segment also has significant headroom for further penetration.

Beyond jewellery, Titan's watches division witnessed strong demand for premium analogue watches and products in the Rs 25,000-Rs 1 lakh segment, helping the business deliver stronger revenue and margin expansion. According to the management, festive demand trends remained healthy after the September quarter.

TEAL, the company's precision engineering business, has been benefiting from opportunities in aerospace, electronics, semiconductors and new-energy applications, delivering strong revenue growth and margin expansion. The segment's growing scale is expected to diversify Titan's earnings profile beyond its jewellery business.

Motilal Oswal Financial Services remains positive on jewellery industry growth and expects Titan to gain market share through initiatives such as its exchange programme. The brokerage believes rising formalisation of the jewellery business and stable gold prices could further improve growth visibility and margins. It has maintained a 'Buy' rating on the stock with a target price of Rs 5,700.

Prabhudas Lilladher, on the other hand, has downgraded the stock to 'Accumulate' and cut its target price by 1% to Rs 5,330, citing rich valuations following the recent rally. However, it remains confident about the company's medium-term earnings growth trajectory.

Earnings Review

Higher Input Costs Drag MRF Q2 Net Profit Down 23%

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: Tyre maker MRF Ltd on Tuesday reported a 22.8% decline in net profit to Rs 417.19 crore for the July-September quarter, as higher raw material costs offset double-digit revenue growth. The Chennai-based company had posted a consolidated net profit of Rs 540.13 crore in the year-ago period, according to an exchange filing.

Revenue from operations rose 17.4% to Rs 8,660.19 crore from Rs 7,378.72 crore a year earlier.

"The company delivered strong double-digit sales growth in the second quarter. We were able to capitalise on sustained demand for the company's products from both OE and replacement segments," MRF said in a press release.

Total expenses increased 21.8% to Rs 8,269.77 crore in the September quarter from Rs 6,788.55 crore a year earlier. The cost of materials rose 43.2% to Rs 6,552.57 crore from Rs 4,577.49 crore.

The sharp rise in raw material prices amid global uncertainties adversely affected profitability during the quarter. Price increases and cost-saving measures helped mitigate the pressure, MRF said.

The company expects continued disruptions and volatility in commodity markets, with raw material and logistics costs likely to remain elevated. "We will continue to take measured steps to address these challenges," it added. Meanwhile, the company's board declared an interim dividend of Rs 3 per share. MRF has fixed November 17 as the record date, with payment scheduled on or after December 1.

FRAUDULENT TRANSACTION

NCLT Flags Fraud in HDIL Property Sale

Orders ₹2.38 crore recovery from former promoters and buyer over undervalued deal

Kailash Babar & Maulik Vyas

Mumbai: The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has held that a 2019 property transaction involving former promoters of Housing Development and Infrastructure Ltd (HDIL) and a private buyer was undervalued and fraudulent, citing discrepancies in the sale consideration, lack of evidence of payment and inconsistencies in documents submitted to establish ownership.

The order relates to a commercial office premises in Dheeraj Pali Arcade Building on Pali Road, Bandra West, which was transferred to the buyer through a registered sale agreement dated July 4, 2019. The transaction involved former HDIL directors Rakesh Kumar Wadhawan and Sarang Rakesh Wadhawan.

The tribunal examined the timing of the transaction, which was registered on the same day that the insolvency petition filed by Bank of India against HDIL was reserved for orders. The case highlights the scrutiny that property transfers by real estate developers shortly before insolvency proceedings can attract from resolution professionals and creditors.

HDIL's resolution professional challenged the transaction, arguing that the sale consideration of Rs 49.94 lakh was substantially below the property's ready reckoner value of Rs 2.38 crore. He also pointed out that there was no corresponding entry in the company's books of accounts to establish receipt of the money.

The buyer contended that the premises had been allotted to her in April 2004 and that her father had paid the entire consideration in cash during 2004-05. She argued that the 2019 registration merely formalised an earlier transaction, which had been delayed because the premises were in the possession of Punjab and Maharashtra Co-operative Bank.

The tribunal, however, found inconsistencies in the documents submitted to support the claim. It noted that the allotment letter bore the signature of Sarang Wadhawan, who was appointed a director of HDIL only in March 2005, although the document was dated April 2004. The company's registered office address mentioned in the letter also came into effect only in March 2006, it observed.

The NCLT further noted that the allotment letter recorded receipt of only Rs 9.90 lakh, while the sale agreement and accompanying receipt contained inconsistencies regarding the consideration and its payment.

The order concerns a commercial office in Dheeraj Pali Arcade, Bandra West, sold through a registered agreement on July 4, 2019

Allowing an application filed by resolution professional Abhay Narayan Manudhane under Sections 45 and 66 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, the tribunal directed the buyer and the two former directors to jointly contribute Rs 2.38 crore to HDIL's assets within 60 days. Failure to comply would render the sale void and require the premises to be handed over to the resolution professional, it said.

The ruling highlights how property transactions undertaken during periods of financial distress can be challenged on grounds of undervaluation, absence of verifiable payment trails and inadequate documentation, even when buyers claim that the underlying allotment dates back several years.

Betting Big on Connected Devices

▸▸ From Page 1

Analysts said the company's expansion into white goods is a strategic effort to diversify its revenue base, extend its connected device ecosystem and build a stronger presence across India's consumer technology market.

"Entering categories such as air conditioners, refrigerators and washing machines is a logical extension of Xiaomi's global IoT (Internet of Things) and ecosystem strategy, enabling the company to capture a larger share of household spending across both value-for-money and premium segments," said Prabhu Ram, vice president of the industry research group at Cyber Media Research. "Local manufacturing partnerships will be critical to achieving scale, deepening localisation and improving cost competitiveness."

He said that over the years, the company has built a broad local manufacturing footprint across smartphones and consumer electronics, working with partners such as Dixon Technologies, DBG Technology and BYD Electronic for smartphones, alongside Optiemus Electronics for its broader electronics portfolio.

Neil Shah, co-founder and vice president of research at Counterpoint Research, also said that with smartphone growth plateauing and margins squeezed due to "chipflation", white goods are the logical next battlefield for Xiaomi to diversify and monetise its connected ecosystem under its 'Human x Car x Home' strategy.

"Xiaomi was one of the first and earliest brands to almost 100% localise their smartphone manufacturing in India by partnering with multiple EMS (electronics manufacturing services) firms, from Foxconn to DBG," Shah said. "Xiaomi is taking a leaf out of the same playbook and looking to build a robust white goods manufacturing ecosystem. But appliances aren't phones—they're bulky, freight-heavy and require deep localised sheet metal and tooling alongside electronics."

He added that with restrictions on foreign direct investment, building greenfield plants made no sense; hence, partnering with local EMS firms was the only viable and logical option to cost-effectively scale up the business.

"We can expect a split approach similar to smartphones, expanding the existing Dixon relationship for washing machines and refrigerators where shared trust already exists, while tapping specialists like Amber or PG Electroplast for smart air conditioners. Epack Durable could also be a good option for smaller smart appliances," Shah said.

Cyber Media Research's Ram, however, pointed out that while Xiaomi's expanding offline retail presence provides an edge for its white goods business, converting that reach into market success will require sustained investment in distribution, product reliability, consumer trust and after-sales service, areas where established appliance players currently hold significant advantages.

The aggressive portfolio expansion aligns with India's growing consumer demand for connected, energy-efficient smart home ecosystems. In 2025, Xiaomi's IoT and lifestyle products segment generated more than $17 billion, reflecting an 18.3% year-over-year growth. Mijia's financial contributions are fully integrated into the company's IoT and lifestyle products division, which contributes 25-28% of Xiaomi's total corporate revenue.

While smartphones and personal technology remain at the core of Xiaomi's business, the home category is important for its next phase of growth in India. Its presence in the televisions and connected devices segments has given it a strong foundation to build on, as it looks to address a wider range of technology needs within Indian households.

In June, Xiaomi shared its plans to enter the large appliances category in India. While there are no specific details on the categories or timelines, the company made another step in this direction with the introduction of Mijia in the country. The first products under Mijia were air purifiers, and the move was viewed as part of the company's effort to strengthen the home segment in India, which is one of Xiaomi's most important markets globally and also serves as its regional headquarters for South Asia.

Bajaj Finance Allots ₹5,800-cr Warrants to Bajaj Finserv

New Delhi: NBFC Bajaj Finance on Tuesday allotted 5.74 crore warrants to its promoter, Bajaj Finserv, on a preferential basis for an aggregate consideration of Rs 5,799.9 crore.

The company's special committee of directors approved the issue of 5,74,25,740 warrants at Rs 1,010 apiece, in accordance with Chapter V of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) regulations, Bajaj Finance said in a regulatory filing.

Each warrant is convertible into an equivalent number of equity shares, which will rank pari passu with the company's existing fully paid-up equity shares, it said.

A minimum of 25% of the consideration is payable on the date of allotment, while the remaining 75% will be payable upon allotment of equity shares following the exercise of the warrants, in accordance with SEBI's ICDR Regulations. **PTI**

National Framework to Expedite Skilling Centre Approvals Launched

Empanelment will be valid for three years, extendable by two years based on performance

Yogima Seth

New Delhi: The skill development and entrepreneurship ministry has launched a national empanelment framework to streamline the setting up of centres of excellence, with provisions for a green channel for established centres. The move is aimed at fast-tracking approvals for such facilities while ensuring that only credible and outcome-oriented institutions receive government recognition.

Under the new framework, centres will be judged on common as well as sector-specific requirements relating to infrastructure, trainers and assessors, assessment capability, industry linkages, governance and performance, said a senior government official.

The empanelment will be valid for a three-year period and can be extended by two years if the centre meets its training goals. The application process is now nomination-based. Institutes applying to become centres of excellence will be assessed at three levels: desk-level scrutiny, physical verification of the centre and final approval from the executive committee.

However, under the green channel mechanism, eligible institutions need to submit only basic information, including the training centre's name, operating entity, address, contact details, sectors of specialisation and seating capacity. Such institutions, although nominated, will not have to undergo the regular evaluation process and will instead be fast-tracked for immediate evaluation.

The green channel is applicable to the existing Institutes of National Importance, ITIs upgraded under PM-SETU and Skilling Centres of Excellence operated or empanelled by central ministries or departments and state governments. The centres of excellence will also support measurable post-training outcomes, mentorship, career coaching, credible assessment and continued tracking of candidates, the official added.

Under the existing framework, which has been in force since 2021, the centres of excellence were specialised institutions imparting skills training related to the schemes concerned, while the new framework makes empanelment scheme-agnostic. According to the official, a key change is that empanelment is separate from scheme-specific target allocation, and empanelment itself does not guarantee the allocation of training targets, which will continue to be governed by the respective scheme guidelines.

New framework is expected to create a stable pool of credible, and industry-aligned training institutions

The government expects the new framework to create a stable pool of credible, permanent and industry-aligned training institutions that can be leveraged across skilling programmes, enable better utilisation of existing infrastructure and institutional capacity, improve the quality and consistency of training and assessment, and strengthen post-training outcomes.

Global Credit Conditions to Weaken Next Year: Moody's

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Moody's Ratings said on Tuesday that it expects global credit conditions to weaken in 2027 as higher financing costs and elevated energy prices create pockets of pressure, though major economies will continue to expand.

The US-based credit rating agency said in a report that costlier credit, artificial intelligence (AI)-led transformation, political intervention and security premiums will drive credit risks and opportunities across sectors and regions. "Government intervention through tariffs, regulation, export controls and strategic investment will play a growing role in credit outcomes," it said, adding that these will continue to influence trade, capital allocation and competition in 2027.

According to the report, higher refinancing costs will put greater pressure on highly leveraged issuers and borrowers with significant near-term maturities. "However, banks and life insurers are the exception, as higher rates support their earnings," it said.

The report further said that rising spending on energy security, critical minerals, defence and climate resilience will create opportunities for some sectors while increasing costs for others. Commenting on investments in AI, the report said AI investment will remain massive, but investors will increasingly focus on whether revenues and productivity gains justify the scale of spending.

"Business model disruption will become more visible with some companies gaining from stronger demand and productivity, while others facing more competition and weaker pricing power," it said. Moody's Ratings said that the expansion of AI infrastructure beyond the US is supporting investment and growth in parts of Asia-Pacific, although benefits will be uneven. "The region is also central to global semiconductor and critical-mineral supply chains, making technology restrictions, export controls and supply-chain security increasingly important credit considerations," it added.

Chartistry

WORLD ECONOMY

The Price of Prices

THE HIGHLIGHT

The Iran war has rapidly raised living costs everywhere. Italy and France, which have seen protests, are among the worst hit; the US, where elections saw Trump diminished, isn't far behind.

INDIA'S CASE

India's inflation jump is the biggest among G20 nations, but that's because it **had unusually low inflation earlier**. It crossed its 4% target only in June.

War's Inflation Impact in G20 Economies

Average inflation rate, %

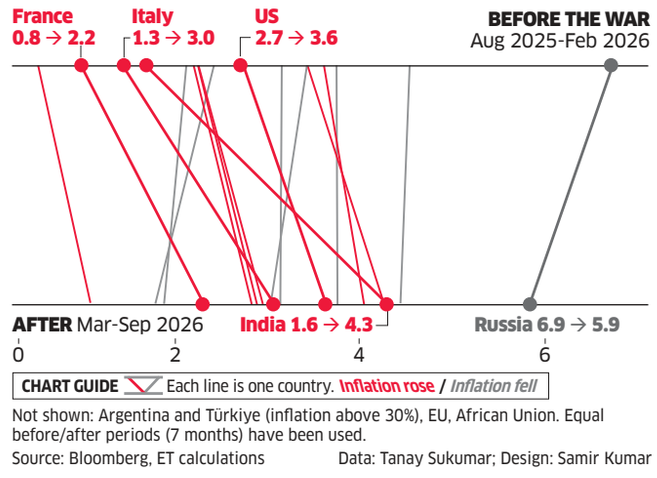

CHART GUIDE Each line is one country. Inflation rose / *Inflation fell*

Not shown: Argentina and Türkiye (inflation above 30%), EU, African Union. Equal before/after periods (7 months) have been used.

Source: Bloomberg, ET calculations Data: Tanay Sukumar; Design: Samir Kumar

Trump's Midterm Poll Setback Won't Derail India-US Trade Talks: Official

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India and the US are continuing negotiations on the first tranche of their proposed bilateral trade agreement, with a US team visiting New Delhi earlier this month for technical discussions on customs and trade facilitation, a government official said on Tuesday.

"On November 2-3, a two-member track team on customs and trade facilitation was in New Delhi to take forward the technical part of the negotiations," the official said, adding that the two sides are in regular touch on the trade pact. The official said technical discussions on the proposed pact were expected to continue despite President Donald Trump's Republican Party losing majority in both the Senate and the House of Representatives in the US midterm elections.

The results, as per another official, will not have an impact on trade pact talks. The outcome of the elections has raised some questions over the Trump administration's ability to push its trade agenda even as the president retains his executive powers.

Earlier this year, India and the US announced the finalisation of a framework for the first phase of the proposed Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) that saw the Trump administration scrap a 25% penalty on New Delhi for buying Russian energy and lower the baseline reciprocal tariff on India to 18%. On February 20, however, the US Supreme Court invalidated Trump's reciprocal tariffs under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act.

Washington has since levied an additional 10% duty on Indian goods under Section 301 probe on alleged forced labour concerns. The duty, also imposed on 16 other countries, is lower than the 12.5% tariff the US proposed in June as part of a broader probe under Section 301 of its Trade Act. The US is separately probing New Delhi's alleged excess capacity under Section 301.

New Delhi is seeking lower tariffs for its goods in the US market than its competitor nations such as Bangladesh, Vietnam and Cambodia.

India Poised to Achieve $1 tn Exports Target, says Goyal

New Delhi: India is on track to achieve its $1 trillion exports target for the current fiscal year, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Tuesday, calling the target "sacrosanct".

The country has already exported goods and services worth $480 billion in the first half of the year, he said. "So, 48% we have achieved...we are well on track to achieve the target...the target is sacrosanct...we have to achieve that," Goyal said at the curtain-raiser event at the Bharat Mobility Global Expo 2027. "The October numbers are surprising, and there will be no looking back after that."

European carmakers that will gain access to the Indian market next year under the India-EU free trade agreement may soon set up manufacturing units in the country, Goyal said. Highlighting that manufacturers sold a million cars during Navratri and around 70,000 during Dhanteras, the minister said the Indian market brings in scale for the world to manufacture in the country at competitive prices.

To highlight the achievements of Indian industry, Goyal noted that Maruti Suzuki is exporting electric vehicles (EVs) to 50 countries from India. Goyal suggested that the automobile industry should also focus on global markets and boost exports. The minister said he expects at least 25,000 international visitors in this year's mobility expo.

Unemployment Falls to 5.1% in Q2 as Labour Participation Rises

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India's unemployment rate declined to 5.1% in July-September 2026 from 5.4% in the previous quarter, as rural unemployment fell to 4.3% from 4.8% in April–June and 4.4% a year ago, official data released on Tuesday showed.

According to the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), the share of people aged 15 years and above who were either employed or seeking employment, termed the Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR), rose to 55.5% from 54.6% in the previous quarter. The share of women who were employed rose to 32.8% from 31.3%.

"The improvement was driven by an increase in LFPR in both rural and urban areas. In rural areas, LFPR for persons aged 15 years and above rose to 58.1% in the current quarter from 56.9% in the previous quarter," the ministry of statistics & programme implementation said in a statement. Urban LFPR increased marginally to 50.4% from 50.2%.

The overall female LFPR increased to 34.7% from 33.2% in the previous quarter. Among males, urban LFPR edged up to 77.3% from 77% in April-June 2026. The PLFS methodology was revised in January 2025 to provide monthly and quarterly estimates of labour force indicators for both rural and urban India. At the all-India level, the quarterly estimates are based on information collected from 555,000 people. The urban unemployment rate rose to 6.8% from 6.7% in the previous quarter. The share of workers in rural areas engaged in self-employment rose to 62.7% in the second quarter of FY27 from 61.4% in the trailing quarter, according to the PLFS.

In both rural and urban areas, the share of workers engaged in casual labour declined: to 21.7% from 22.5% in rural areas and to 10.7% from 11.1% in urban areas.

SECTORAL DISTRIBUTION

"The sectoral distribution of employment continued to reflect the distinct rural-urban employment patterns, with the rural workforce predominantly engaged in agriculture and the urban workforce concentrated in the tertiary sector," the ministry said.

In rural areas, the share of workers engaged in agriculture increased to 56.7% in July-September FY27 from 52.9% in the first quarter of the fiscal.

LABOUR JUMP

The overall female LFPR increased to 34.7%. Among males, the urban LFPR saw a marginal increase

The share of workers engaged in the secondary sector, including mining and quarrying, fell to 21.9% from 24.4% in the previous quarter. The share employed in the tertiary sector stood at 21.4% compared with 22.7% in the previous quarter.

Compared with July-September 2025, the share of rural workers engaged in the secondary sector, including mining and quarrying, increased to 21.9% from 21%. The share employed in the tertiary sector remained broadly stable.

In urban areas, the share of workers engaged in the secondary and tertiary sectors remained broadly stable, according to the statement. The overall Worker Population Ratio for persons aged 15 years and above increased to 52.7% in the quarter ended September 30 from 51.7% in the previous quarter.

Fresh Applications Invited Under PLI for Medical Gear

Teena Thacker

New Delhi: The government has extended the ₹2,700-crore production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme for domestic manufacturing of medical devices till 2035-36 and invited fresh applications, easing eligibility and investment conditions to attract manufacturers and strengthen local production of high-end medical technologies.

Under the revised guidelines, the minimum sales threshold for claiming incentives has been discontinued and the minimum investment requirement reduced.

Applicants can submit multiple applications across one or more of the four target segments, while the application window will remain open for an extended period.

The online application portal is expected to become operational within the next 10 days, the Department of Pharmaceuticals said on Tuesday. Launched in 2020-21, the scheme has facilitated domestic manufacturing of more than 60 high-end medical devices and components, with production valued at over ₹16,000 crore. This includes CT scanners and dialysers.

'Mobilising $1.3 tn Annually by 2035 to Require Overhaul of Climate Fin System'

Urmi Goswami

Antalya: Mobilising $1.3 trillion annually in climate finance for developing countries by 2035 is achievable, but will require a fundamental overhaul of the global climate finance system, according to a report prepared by Brazil's COP30 presidency.

"The goal is within reach, but business as usual will not get us there," Ana Toni, chief executive of COP30, said at the UN Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Antalya. If countries continue with their current policies, financial flows will only reach about $460 billion a year – a shortfall of $840 billion, according to the report, Implementing the Baku to Belém Roadmap to 1.3T.

However, overhauling current approaches to deliver a combination of public and private funding, along with targeted tax increases, can unlock between $1.27 trillion and $1.41 trillion a year by 2035, it said. Climate finance is not growing at the necessary pace, and official development assistance has been shrinking, the report said.

Public finance continues to be a core and critical pillar. "We need to put public finance back on the ascending trajectory," said Luis de Andrade Filho, COP30 presidency's climate finance coordinator. The report suggests many policy interventions to that end and estimates how much could be generated from each source.

As per the report, $882 billion a year can be generated from private investments, $351–384 billion from public sources, and $40–144 billion from carbon markets. Innovative sources of finance could generate 68–129 billion annually,it said.These include taxes on the ultrawealthy (35–45 billion), corporate taxes (23–26 billion), financial transaction taxes (2.4–$16 billion), shipping levies (up to $6 billion) and smaller amounts from taxes on air travel, digital services and fossil fuels.

Implementing these measures would be politically challenging, but is necessary to close the financing gap, the report said. This is the final output from the COP30 Brazilian presidency. Earlier, it released two roadmaps – on transitioning away from fossil fuels and on halting deforestation. The finance report is a critical companion to enable developing countries to implement the roadmaps. It is in keeping with COP30 president André Corrêa do Lago's approach that "the climate agenda is a development agenda" and that "the transition cannot create or deepen inequalities."

At the end of contentious negotiations in Baku, developing countries were disappointed with the $300 billion a year that developed countries would be obligated to provide to developing countries. That sum reflects a fraction of their needs. However, developed countries were unwilling to commit a higher sum, citing competing demands, domestic political compulsions and shrinking budgets. Hence, besides the $300 billion commitment, another "at least $1.3 trillion" was set as an additional target that would be drawn "from all private and public sources," including South-South flows.

COP31: Limiting 1.5°C Overshoot, Speeding up Electrification Emerge as Top Priorities

Urmi Goswami

Antalya: Limiting the period when global temperature overshoots the 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels threshold and accelerating electrification are emerging as key priorities at COP31, with the Turkiye-Australia leadership keen to see these issues reflected in the conference's negotiated cover decision.

"Even temporarily overshooting the 1.5C will cause irreversible damage. We cannot abandon the effort to minimise overshoot," said Murat Kurum, president of COP31 and Turkiye's environment and climate change minister. The Türkiye-Australia leadership is also keen that the cover decision and the outcome of COP31 demonstrate that multilateralism is not only alive but also delivering.

"It is up to this meeting to show that, collectively and by consensus, countries can rise to the occasion," COP president of negotiations Chris Bowen said. He noted that the climate conference is taking place at "a moment of consequence." Despite differences in approaches on dealing with the likelihood of exceeding the 1.5C guardrail and on joining in the Electrification Pledge under the COP31 Action Agenda, countries at the conference are committed to multilateralism.

However, reflecting these key ideas in the political decision will be contentious. It remains to be seen in what shape and form these issues are reflected in the final negotiated cover decision. The cover decision is a negotiated presidency-led text and can include issues, as it has done in the past, that are not part of the formal agenda.

Australia, as COP31 president of negotiations, will oversee the drafting and negotiation of the text, while Türkiye, as host-country president, will be responsible for steering it towards adoption by all parties. Consultations on the cover decision began on Tuesday evening, with the presidency calling for inputs and views from countries and negotiating groups.

In the first round of the exercise, countries and negotiating groups have been asked to share their view on three broad questions. They have been asked to identify recent progress and developments that the decision could recognise as an effort to strengthen confidence in collective climate efforts. The second deals with impact, challenges and opportunities before countries and the world. The final question calls on respondents to identify ways in which countries can work together to accelerate implementation by advancing concrete solutions, means of implementation and international cooperation.

The Turkiye-Australia team plans to produce an elements text that collates all these suggestions. A draft decision text will likely be present early next week. The issues that countries raised at Tuesday's meeting include global warming and measures required to limit the quantum and period of the overshoot to the minimum. Some countries stressed on deep emissions reductions, while some called for addressing the impacts through adaptation. Others stressed on addressing loss and damage.

Discussions touched on atmospheric carbon removal being a critical element of addressing the overshoot. Finance, particularly tripling of adaptation finance, was another key issue raised by countries.

PHDCCI Wants Capital Gains Tax Scrapped, Halving of STCG Levy

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The PHD Chamber of Commerce and Industry (PHDCCI) has urged the government to abolish long-term capital gains (LTCG) tax on equity investments, halve the short-term capital gains (STCG) tax to 10% and lower securities transaction tax (STT) rates.

In its pre-budget recommendations for FY28 submitted to finance ministry on Tuesday, it also suggested to improve access to equity financing for businesses particularly MSMEs, eliminating basic customs duty (BCD) on rayon-grade wood pulp, LNG, naphtha and certain heavy petroleum feedstocks, while seeking lower duties on petroleum coke used in aluminium manufacturing.

"Strengthening India's manufacturing competitiveness requires a comprehensive approach to reducing the cost of critical industrial inputs. Energy and feedstock costs have a cascading impact across multiple sectors, influencing production economics, investment decisions and the competitiveness of downstream industries," said Anil Gupta, president, PHDCCI.

The Chamber has also sought an increase in loan ceilings under the PMMY

To promote the domestic manufacturing ecosystem in consumer durables and electronics, the chamber has proposed increasing the BCD to 20% on imports of finished, completely built units of washing machines, dishwashers, vacuum cleaners and robotic vacuum cleaners besides localisation of components and strengthening the competitiveness of Indian manufacturers.

The industry body has also called for the continuation of the existing customs duty framework on steel scrap beyond March 2028, arguing that competitive access to critical industrial inputs is essential to lowering manufacturing costs and improving India's global competitiveness. A predictable duty framework would help ensure access to the raw material for steelmakers and support downstream sectors such as construction, infrastructure, automobiles, engineering and capital goods, it said.

The chamber has also sought an increase in loan ceilings under the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY), proposing limits of ₹1 lakh under Shishu, ₹10 lakh under Kishore and ₹20 lakh under Tarun and Tarun Plus categories. Another key recommendation is to extend the overdue period for classifying MSME loans as non-performing assets from 90 days to 180 days, citing longer working capital cycles and delays in realisation of receivables.

'Profound Transformation'

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"Management education is undergoing a profound transformation, driven by advances in artificial intelligence and data science. We are working to embed AI literacy, data-driven decision-making and digital strategy into management education, while ensuring that our graduates develop the judgement, ethical grounding and strategic thinking required to lead in an AI-augmented world," said Debashis Chatterjee, director, IIM Kozhikode.

At BITSoM, every MBA student is required to build an AI agent. The exercise puts students in the position of creating something that works, taking them beyond discussing what technology might do.

The school integrates AI across business functions, from operations and decision-making to marketing and customer engagement, according to Saravanan Kesavan, dean and professor of operations at BITSoM. "Rather than treating AI as a standalone subject, BITSoM integrates it across the curriculum, helping students understand how it is transforming every business function, from decision-making and operations to marketing and customer engagement," he said.

Students also work alongside startups through BITSoM VERTEX, an AI venture incubator developed with Silicon Valley innovation studio LENZ. "Business schools need to shift the balance from teaching about management to helping people learn to manage," said Madan Pillutla, dean, ISB.

For young graduates, the stakes are particularly high. The routine work that AI can absorb has also traditionally been done at the entry level. "For fresh graduates, the case for business school may strengthen as AI absorbs routine work through which they once learned how organisations function," added Pillutla.

IIM Lucknow says it is attuning to the AI-driven future of work and has taken steps including faculty recruitment in the field of AI and cybersecurity, training and development of existing faculty and staff, the launch of new programmes in AI and data analytics at undergraduate and postgraduate levels, as well as the integration of various optional courses in AI for MBA students.

"We're also working on setting up AI labs for students," said Arunabha Mukhopadhyay, professor of IT and systems at IIM Lucknow.

The institute has started integrating AI across the MBA curriculum. "The focus is to help students make responsible business decisions using AI. Our aim is to make students capable enough to work effectively with AI in their organisations." IIM Kozhikode is embedding AI literacy, analytical decision-making and digital strategy into management education. It is also rethinking what assignments should test. "AI skills are tools; wisdom in applying them is what creates value," said Chatterjee.

For instance, at Nanyang Business School, Singapore, MBA students exploring retail transformation through agentic AI and digital twins had to look beyond technological possibilities to commercial viability, customer experience, trust and implementation.

AI could generate options. Students still had to determine which would work, for whom and at what cost, said dean Jun Yang. "AI is not making the MBA obsolete. It is making an MBA built primarily around knowledge transmission obsolete," she added.

Driven More by Need for Security

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Tan90 and Enerzolve didn't respond to queries.

The driver for this funding is energy security more than climate, according to Vishesh Rajaram, founding partner at venture capital firm Speciale Invest. "India imports most of its oil, a large share of its gas, and nearly all its battery cells, electrolyser stacks and critical power electronics."

Unless the hardware underpinning renewable energy and storage is built domestically, the expansion of these technologies could deepen import dependence. This is shifting the investment opportunity toward building sovereign infrastructure, with demand supported by national energy targets and government policies, he added.

Emo Energy, which develops integrated battery systems and thermal management solutions, raised $6.2 million in January. The company is in talks to raise ₹150-200 crore ($16-21 million) in a new round, nearly thrice its previous round, ET reported in June.

But the larger round sizes are partly structural, said Rajaram.

"Energy hardware moves from lab to pilot line to commercial plant, and each step needs far more capital than the last," he said. "A big step-up is the natural shape of the business, not just exuberance."

Founders now arrive at the follow-on with working cells, stacks or prototypes and validated performance data, he said. Moreover, policy-backed procurement and purchase pledges mean investors can underwrite orders, not just a market size.

ET's June report also said that EarthEn Energy, which is developing heat-storage batteries for industrial customers, and Arkle Energy, which develops vanadium redox flow batteries, were in various stages of discussions with investors.

Among recent funding deals this year, rapid-charging battery startup Exponent Energy raised $22 million in February, while sodium-ion battery maker Naxion Energy secured $2.62 million in August. Gandhinagar-based Cellegant Energy Systems, which develops hydrogen fuel-cell systems for drones, raised $275,000 in November. Noida-based battery storage startup VoltSeal raised $1.5 million in June in a round led by Theia Ventures. The spread of investments shows how the opportunity extends beyond renewable energy generation and electric mobility to the underlying hardware needed to manage, store and distribute power.

"The country has reached approximately 299.25 GW of installed renewable energy capacity as of September 2026, compared to 76.38 GW in 2014," said Anjali Bansal, founding partner, Avaana Capital. "This rapid expansion is creating a growing need for proprietary technologies, advanced materials and hardware solutions across the energy value chain."

Avaana has invested in energy startups such as solar finance company Aerem, charging infra startup Kazam, and Dreamfly Innovations, which makes smart battery systems for drones and aerospace.

"Recent global events have reminded us how closely energy and security are linked," said Kajal Shah, cofounder and CEO of Dreamfly Innovations. "Most drone batteries used in India have historically been imported, so building design capability at home is our way of adding resilience to that part of the chain."

Dreamfly's revenue jumped to ₹8.6 crore in FY26 from Rs 93 lakhs the year before.

In a blog post in June, Theia Ventures noted that India's renewable energy accounts for 43% of the country's installed power capacity but just 22% of actual generation due to its intermittent nature. The mismatch between daytime solar generation and evening industrial demand creates reliability gaps.

This is creating an opportunity for distributed energy storage, the post said. Falling battery costs and improvements in technology are also making storage viable for applications beyond backup power.

Temperature Control Systems an Opportunity

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Specialised manufacturing in these segments would offer higher margins even at relatively low volumes, he said.

Industry executives said local production could help India emerge as a challenger to established manufacturing hubs such as China, Taiwan and South Korea. The government estimates that investments of around $200 billion could flow into India's data centre industry.

Dixon is actively pursuing opportunities in silicon-photonics, optical transceivers and advanced packaging through acquisitions and partnerships. It is forming a joint venture with Taiwan's Gemtek Technology to manufacture optical transceivers, with operations expected to begin next quarter. The company is also exploring precision engineering and deeper technological capabilities in optical solutions. South Korean electronics firms Samsung and LG are also looking to make India an export base for specialised HVAC systems used to cool AI data centres. Samsung group company FläktGroup set up a dedicated factory in Pune last quarter for these products, with exports destined for Asia-Pacific. The facility is expected to scale up production to 6,500 units annually. LG will manufacture specialised HVAC solutions at its upcoming plant in Sri City, which is expected to go on steam in December, an industry executive said Domestic companies are also eyeing data centre cooling as a growth opportunity. Blue Star managing director B Thiagarajan said the company expects a significant increase in order inflows from data centre projects in the coming months. "We estimate that this year, perhaps around ₹10,000 crore to ₹12,500 crore worth of orders (from data centres) might be finalised. We have indicated that we are already close to ₹2,000 crore worth of orders, and we will do another ₹2,000 crore," he said. PG Electroplast managing director (operations) Vikas Gupta said that HVAC systems for AI data centres involve a completely different technology from conventional room air conditioners.

The company is evaluating an entry into the segment, given its high growth potential.

Tracing Goods' Potential

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The industry is also trying to zero in on products with strong export demand or potential in these countries, the person said.

Indian turmeric and chilli exports to Sri Lanka have faced issues over pesticide residues beyond accepted levels, while yarn exporters to Bangladesh have sought expedited certification of rules of origin, exporters said.

"Not only South Asia, but there are many countries across the world where India's exports are $800-900 million and can be easily scaled up to $1 billion," another person aware of the exercise said. India's goods and services exports touched a record $863 billion in 2025-26.

The development comes against the backdrop of existing regional trade arrangements. All South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (Saarc) members – India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Maldives and Afghanistan – are part of the South Asian Free Trade Area (Safta). India, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka are also members of the Asia-Pacific Trade Agreement, which includes China. Separately, India and the Maldives have concluded the first round of negotiations for a bilateral free trade agreement. "It is strategically a good move to improve trade flows in the South Asia region and boost India's export diversification efforts to be able to meet the $1 trillion export target," said Ajay Sahai, director general of Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO). A yarn and fabric exporter to Bangladesh said there are no major non-tariff barriers in the region because most of the countries are raw material suppliers in the textile value chain. However, exporters sometimes face delays in obtaining certificates of origin from designated agencies, particularly when seeking preferential tariff treatment under trade agreements, the person said.

Bangladesh buys roughly 45% of India's total cotton yarn exports. Another industry representative said political issues within the region need to be resolved for trade to increase.

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

E-Tendering Notice

Sr. Divisional Materials Manager, N.E. Railway, Varanasi for and on behalf of President of India, invites Tender through E-Procurment system "Open Tender" for the supply of the following item. Complete description of the item and other terms and conditions are available on website ***www.ireps.gov.in*** **Sr.No.-1,** E-Tender No.: 50265617, Due Date: 09-12-2026, Description: Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of 01 No. Drop Pit Table along with concomitant accessories as per COFMOW Spec. No. COFMOW/IR/DPT/2020"for ELS/ SYH, Quantity: 01 No., Earnest Money: ₹ 8,20,000/-,

Sr. Divisional Materials Manager,
CPRO/S-84 **Varanasi**

Never travel on roof and foot boards.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E- TENDER NOTICE

NO.- ECR-CAO-C-N-EPC-23-26-27

E- TENDER IS INVITED ON BEHALF OF THE PRESIDENT OF INDIA FOR THE UNDER MENTIONED WORK **(1)Name of work with it's location:** Engineering Procurement and Construction (EPC) Tender for Track works, including supply of ballast and P-Way materials, laying and linking of track, and other related miscellaneous works in connection with the doubling of the Darbhanga (excluding)-Sitamarhi (excluding) section from Ch. 39.400 km to Ch. 103.850 km (total length: 64.450 km), for 25-tonne axle load, under Samastipur Division of East Central Railway **(2)Approx, cost of the work of:** Rs. 173,23,19,625.56 **(3)Earnest money to be deposited:** Rs. 3,46,46,400.00 **(4)Date and time for closing of tender.:** 04.03.2027 at 14.30 hrs. **(5)Website particular, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and addressed of the office from where the tender form be purchased etc.:** The above E-Tender, E-Tendering document alongwith full information is available on websie i.e. **http://www.ireps.gov.in.** Note: In case of any descripencies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website **http://www.ireps.gov.in** atleast 15 days before last date of closing for latest corrigendum/corrections etc in response to this E-tender

CAO/Con/North
EC Rly. MHX, Patna
PR/1306/CN/N/MHX/CONST/T/26-27/40

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

NO.-T-SEE-GSU-2026-27-08

CAO/CON/RSP/MHX for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tenders for the following works. The last date of online E-tendering is 08/12/2026 up to 15:00 hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on **website-www.ireps.gov.in. (1)Name of Work:**Construction of Road Over Bridge and other related works in lieu of (1) level crossing no. 25 (spl) at kilometer: 104/37-39 between Mansi-Mahesh Khunt station., (2) level crossing No. 53 (spl) at Kilometer: 169/28-29 bet. TilrathBegusarai station. & (3) level crossing No. 30 (spl) at Kilometer: 115/28-30 between Khagaria-Mansi station, in the jurisdiction of Sonpur Division. **(2)Advertised Value (Rs.):** 2007232191.99 **(3)Earnest Money/Bid Security (Rs.):** 40144700.00 **(4)Date and Time of the Pre-Bid Conference:** 18/11/2026, 11:30 Hrs. **(5) Tender Closing Date Time:** 08/12/2026, 15:00 Hrs. The above tender notice is available on website **www.ireps.gov.in.** RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER: Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone /modify or to cancel any one or all the tenders without assigning any reasons. **Dy. Chief Project Manager**
GatiShakti/Sonpur
PR/1301/SEE/GS/T/26-27/36

उ0प्र0पा0ट्रा0का0लि0
मुख्य अभियन्ता (पा0प0), मेरठ

ई-निविदा सूचना दिनांक : 07.11.2026

निविदा सं0 एवं कार्य का संक्षिप्त विवरण

1. 19/CE(TW)/MT/2026-27 विद्युत 400 के0वी0ए0 उपकेन्द्र खण्ड, ग्रेटर नोएडा के अन्तर्गत 400/220/33 के0वी0 500 एम0वी0ए0 परिवर्तक के लोडिंग एवं ट्रासपोटेशन के कार्य हेतु, प्रपत्र शुल्क :– 1,770/– धरोहर राशि – रू0 53 हजार ।

ई-निविदा की अंतिम तिथि : क्रम सं0 01 हेतु 21.11.2026 :– 17:00 बजे

विस्तृत जानकारी एवं प्रपत्र वेबसाइट https://entender.up.nic.in पर उपलब्ध है। अग्रेतर समस्त सूचनाएं वेबसाइट पर ही प्रदर्शित की जाएंगी।

पत्रांक/4701/मु0अ0(पा0प0)मेरठ/T-19/2026-27 दिनांक 07.11.2026

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E- TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRS, East Central Railway, Barauni on behalf of the President of India invites "Open" E-tender from the eligible and experienced agencies or contractors for E-Tender No. ELS-BJU-TRS-2026-27-05. Particulars are as under: **(1)Name of the work with its location:** Uncoupling, Dismantling/Stripping, Cleaning and Painting of different component of electric locomotives at ELS/BJU **(2)Approx. Cost of the work:** 66,40,156.16 (Rupees Sixty six Lakh forty Thousand one hundred fifty six & sixteen only) **(3)Earnest Money:** Rs. 1,32,800.00 **(4)Date and time of pre-bid meeting:** NA **(5)Last Date & Time for submission of bid:** 30/11/2026 12:00 Hrs. **(6)Website particulars where Tender document is available: https://www.ireps.gov.in** Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria and tender document can be seen from above website. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website, if required.

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRS
East Central Railway/Barauni
PR/1311/ELS/BJU/LS/T/26-27/28

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager, N.W. Rly. Bikaner for and on behalf of President of India invites sealed open tender for the following works on the date shown as below. **Tender No.:** SnT-BKN-2026-27-31R. **Name of Work with its Location:** "S&T Associated Works in Connection with Provision of CTR (P) in Suratgarh-Sarupsar Section (7.368 Tkm), CTR (P) in Suratgarh-Lalgarh Section (6.506 Tkm) and TRR (P) of 60 Kg-R260 Rail in Suratgarh-Sarupsar-Anupgarh Section (18.199 Tkm) under Bikaner Division, North Western Railway." **Approx. Cost of Work: 6162321.70. Bid Security: 123300. Date & Time for submission of Tender & opening of tender:** Up to 15.00 Hrs. of 30.11.2026. **Website from Which complete Tender details can be seen & download:** www.ireps.gov.in.

1619-MG/26

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NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/ General, North Western Railway, Bikaner for & on behalf of the President of India, invites E- tenders for the following work. **1) Tender Notice No.:** 01-El-BKN-E-Tender-26-27R. **Name of work:** Electrical work in c/w provision of minimum essential amenities at various stations of BKN div to recoup shortfall in the jurisdiction of DEN/East/BKN, provision of high level island passenger platform & other. passenger amenities between line no. 9 & 10 & extension of platform no.6 at Hisar station, raising of PF no. 1 at Lahli & Bamla station to high level & extension to accommodate full length trains & raising of PF no. 1 at Dhana Ladanpur halt station & extension to 480 m, raising of rail level PF no. 1 at Jodhkan halt, Kharak halt & Bhojawas Halt station over BKN division along with extension to 480 m, raising of rail level PF no. 1 at Khabra Kalan halt, Nangal degrota halt, Nyoli kalan halt & Bajekan halt station along with extension to 480 m, provision of 6 m wide FOB at Jharli & 3 m wide FOB at Nangal Pathani halt station (double line section), provision of 3 m wide FOB at Manheru, Sudhrana, Kishangarh Balawas, Patuwas Mehrana halt station (double line section) & provision of 6m wide FOB at Jatusana & 3m wide FOB at Fatehgarh Haryana halt station, provision of additional HL full length passenger platform and FOB at Mandi Adampur station over Bikaner division. **Approx. Cost of the work (in Rs.):** ₹ 24681139/- **EMD/SD (in Rs.):** ₹493600/- **Tender Documents cost:** Nil. **2) Tender Notice No.:** 15-El-BKN-E-Tender-26-27. **Name of work:** Electrical work in c/w provision of Distributed Electronics Interlocking at Hisar & Sri Ganganagar station over Bikaner Division. **Approx. Cost of the work (in Rs.):** ₹11543539/- **EMD/SD (in Rs.):** ₹230900/- **Tender Documents cost:** Nil. **3) Tender Notice No.:** 14-El-BKN-E-Ten-24-25R. **Name of work:** Electrical work in c/w provision of new Hot standby El architecture at 09 stations of SOG-HMH-SGNR section, construction of OFC room with toilet facility at Tibi & Jaitsar station, Provision of RO plant with 225 KL RCC OH Tank & 40kL cap UG tank at SGNR and replacement of old corroded pipe line for drinking water supply at Khinania & Nohar railway colony and Conversion of non-running line no. 4 into running line at Mandi dabwali, provision of new booking office, waiting hall, waiting room, circulating area with separate gate and extn of PF shelter by 6 bays at Pilibanga and Allied Infrastructure Development for the CNC Tandem Under floor Wheel Lathe provision at SGNR Depot over Bikaner Division. **Approx. Cost of the work (in Rs.):** ₹8766302/- **EMD/SD (in Rs.):** ₹ 175300/- **Tender Documents cost:** Nil. **4) Tender Notice No.:** 06-El-BKN-E-Tender-25-26R. **Name of work:** Electrical work in c/w provision of tool room cum rest room 36 nos. in jurisdiction of ADEN/RTGH & 94 nos. in the jurisdiction of ADEN/Line/BKN, SDLP & SOG over BKN division. **Approx. Cost of the work (in Rs.):** ₹3620578/- **EMD/SD (in Rs.):** ₹ 72400/- **Tender Documents cost:** Nil. **1. Complete details of tenders can be seen on Website No.:** http://www.ireps.gov.in. **2. Date & time of closing of e-tenders:** 30.11.2026 at 15.00 hours. **3. Date & time of opening of e-tenders:** After 15.00 Hrs on 30.11.2026 **1618-MG/26**

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EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E- TENDER NOTICE

(1)Name of work with its location: Umesh Nagar-Yard remodeling work for extension of CSL of lines at UMNR station. **(2)Approx.cost of the woks (रु):** रू 7203373.5/- **(3)Earnest Money to be deposited (रु):** रू 144100/- **(4)Date & time for submission of e-tender and opening of e-tender:** Opening of e-tenders: on 30.11.2026 at 12.00 Hrs. in the office of the Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer (TRD), DRM Office, E.C. Railway, Sonpur. **(5)Website particulars and notice board location where complete details of e-tender can be seen.:** WEBSITE: **http://www.ireps.gov.in NOTICE BOARD:** DRM Office Campus, E. C. Railway, Sonpur.

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRD
East Central Railway/Sonpur
PR/1309/SEE/TRD/T/26-27/24

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E- TENDER NOTICE

(1)Name of work with its location: Danauli Phulwaria Yard remodeling work for extension of CSL of lines at DPL station. **(2)Approx-cost of the woks (रु):** रू 6620038.5/- **(3)Earnest Money to be deposited (रु):** रू 132400/- **(4)Date & time for submission of e-tender and opening of e-tender:** Opening of e-tenders: on 30.11.2026 at 12.00 Hrs. in the office of the Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer (TRD), DRM Office, E.C. Railway, Sonpur. **(5)Website particulars and notice board location where complete details of e-tender can be seen.:** WEBSITE: **http://www.ireps.gov.in NOTICE BOARD:** DRM Office Campus, E. C. Railway, Sonpur.

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRD
East Central Railway/Sonpur
PR/1308/SEE/TRD/T/26-27/24

विद्युत पारेषण मण्डल, मुजफ्फर नगर

उ0प्र0 पावर ट्रांसमिशन कारपोरेशन लि0

जैम-बिड सूचना,

दिनांक – 07.11.2026

निविदा संख्या एवं कार्य का संक्षिप्त विवरण

1. GEM/2026/B/8254141:- विद्युत मण्डल, मुजफ्फरनगर के नियन्त्रणाधीन 400 के0वी0, 220 के0वी0 एंव 132 के0वी0 पारेषण उपकेन्द्रों पर CCTV Camera's स्थापित करने का कार्य। धरोहर राशि रू0 20000.00 मात्र। निविदा की अन्तिम तिथि 18.11.2026 समय 12:00 बजे। विस्तृत जानकारी एवं प्रपत्र जैम पोर्टल (www.gem.gov.in) पर उपलब्ध है। अग्रेतर समस्त सूचनायें बेबसाइट पर ही प्रदर्शित की जायेगी। **अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, विद्युत पारेषण मण्डल, भोपा रोड, मुजफ्फरनगर**

पत्रांक/No. 1344/वि0पा0म0(ETC)/मु0नगर(MZN)/ दिनांक/DATED 10.11.2026 **राष्ट्र हित में बिजली बचायें।**

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E- Open Tender Notice

E-Tender notice no.: CRW-HRT-M-OT-OP-IGP-26-2

For and on behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, Carriage Repair Workshop. Harnaut invites open e-tender for the following works as detailed: - **(1)Name of work with its location :"** Operation and maintenance including spare parts during repair of Inoculum Generation Plant, capacity of 100 cubic meter capacity at Carriage Repair Workshop. Harnaut for three years." **(2)Approx. cost of the work:**Rs. 52, 93,779.15 (Rupees Fifty-Two Lakh Ninety-Three Thousand Seven Hundred Seventy-Nine and Fifteen Paisa Only). **(3)Cost of Tender Form:**Nil **(4)Earnest Money to be deposited:**Rs.1, 05,900.00 (Rupees One Lakh Five Thousand Nine Hundred Only). **(5)Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of Tender:** The tender have to be submitted online on **https://www.ireps.gov.in** website up to 11:00 hrs. on 27.11.2026 and will be opened on the same day at 11:15 hrs. **(6)Website particulars, Notice board. location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.:** Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website:**https://www.ireps.gov.in** & full details of notice can be seen on notice board in the office of Chief Workshop Manager, Administrative Building.. Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut, Nalanda, Bihar - 803110. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website if required.

Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer
Carriage Repair Workshop/Harnaut
PR/1299/CRW-HRT/MECH/T/26-27/40

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

Online E-Tender Notice

The Dy.CE/BRL, E.C.Railway, Hajipur is inviting online (E-Tendering) Open Tender for and on behalf of the President of India from reputed contractors with experience, financial capability including those registered/working with Railway/Irrigation/CPWD/MES or any other public sector undertaking for the following work.

S.N. : 1, **Tender Notice No. : BRL-DNR-26-10-01**, **Name of work :** Replacement of corroded/perforated members in UP & DN line, regirdering of all 4-shore span of Br. No 200 'A' UP & DN Line (2x12.2 m + 28x45.76m) at KM 577/21 579/2 between Bihta & Koilwar stations under SSE/Br/DNR of Danapur division., **Approx. Cost (Rs.) :** 7,61,26,533.30, **Earnest Money to be deposited (Rs.) :** 15,22,500.00

- Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of tender : The tender uploaded on 04.11.2026 online on www.ireps.gov.in. and the date of tender opening is 27.11.2026 and will be opened on the same day after 12:00 hrs.
- Website particulars, notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. : Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: **http.//www.ireps.gov.in** & full details of notice can be seen on notice board. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website if required.

Executive Engineer/ Bridge/Line
East Central Railway, Danapur
PR/1298/DNR/ENGG/T/26-27/44

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

No. DNR/S&T/Tele/2026/10

Divisional Railway Manager (Signal & Telecom), East Central Railway, Danapur Division, for and on behalf of President of India invites tenders on web portal **www.ireps.gov.in** for the following work **(1)Name of work with its location:** Upgradation of various Telecom Facilities alongwith passenger amenities at different stations of Danapur Division **(2)Approximate cost of work:** Rs. 164738306.93 **(3)Earnest Money:** Rs. 3294800.00 **(4)Last Date & Time of Submission:** Up to 15.00 hrs. on 30.11.2026 **(5)Opening of tender:** 15.00 hrs. on 30.11.2026 **(6)Website particulars where detail of the work and criteria can be seen: www.ireps.gov.in (7)Address of the office from where detail information can be obtained.:** Sr. Divnl. Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, East Central Railway, Danapur **Note:** Any corrigendum if required will be uploaded on above website before 14 days

DSTE
E.C. Railway, Danapur
PR/1312/DNR/S&T/T/26-27/28

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

ई–निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

मंडल रेल प्रबंधक, इंजीनियरिंग, उत्तर पश्चिम रेलवे, जोधपुर द्वारा भारत के राष्ट्रपति के लिए एंव उनकी ओर से ई–निविदा के माध्यम से प्रचलित नियमो के अंतर्गत निर्धारित प्रपत्रों में निविदा निम्रकार्यों के लिए क्रमानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती है– **ई–निविदा सूचना सं.: 2026–27. 1730f2026-27. कार्य का नाम व स्थान: Replacement of existing pipe bridges below of size 0.90m dia in to RCC Box bridges on SMR (ex.) to MBF Section in the jurisdiction of Sr.DEN/West of Jodhpur Division. अनुमानित लागत रुपये: 37717700.51. बयाने की राशी रुपये: 754400.00.** निविदा सूचना संख्या **1730f2026-27** निविदा प्रस्तुत करने की तिथि **26/11/2026** को **15.00** बजे तक है वेबसाइट का विवरण जहाँ पर ई–निविदा देखी व भरी जा सकती है– **www.ireps.gov.in 1621-MG/2026**

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Expression of Interest

Reputed experts/consultancy organisations having proven expertise and successful track record in conducting Upgradation, Expansion and Revamping (UER) Studies of cement plants are invited to submit their Expression of Interest for undertaking UER studies of three existing cement plants of Cement Corporation of India (CCI).

Interested experts with more than 15 years of demonstrated experience and proven results may submit their EOI to Sh. Alok Shukla GM Commercial Cement Corporation of India Ltd., within 10 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Mr. Alok Shukla,
General Manager (Commercial),
Cement corporation of India limited, Core-5, Scope Complex, Lodhi Road, New Delhi 110003.

Email: alok.shukla@cciltd.in; Phone no. 9993752836.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Const./Northern Railway, 4th Floor, DRM Office, New Delhi-110001 invites e-tender under **single Packet System** for the under noted work:-

1.	**Name of work and location :** "Dismantling of Towers causing Hinderance in Railway working in connection with 3rd-4th line in DLI-Ambala section."
2.	**Completion period of the work :** 12 (twelve Months)
3.	**Approx. Cost of work :** Rs. 37,78,450/-
4.	**Earnest Money amount (to be deposited Online) :** Rs. 75,600/-
5.	**Date & Time for submission of E-tender and opening of tender :** Tenders may be uploaded by **11:00 hrs.** on **11.11.2026** by Railway on IREPS website i.e. **www.ireps.gov.in**. The bidders can participate in the e-tender, the tender will be opened at **11:00 hrs.** on **03.12.2026**.
6.	**Detailed Tender Notice & Tender Document :** The detailed e-tender notice and tender document is available on **www.ireps.gov.in**. Above tender document will be available for submission of offer on IREPS website i.e. **www.ireps.gov.in** from **19.11.2026 to 03.12.2026**. All other terms and conditions in respect of above tenders are given in tender document. The detailed tender notice also can be seen on the Notice Board of the above office.

No.: 349-Dy.CEE/C/NDLS/2026-27 Dated: 10.11.2026 3937/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

BIHAR STATE MILK CO-OPERATIVE FEDERATION LTD.

DAIRY DEVELOPMENT COMPLEX, P.O. - BIHAR VETERINARY COLLEGE, PATNA-800014(BIHAR)
E-Mail: engineeringcomfedpatna@gmail.com, Website: www.sudha.coop

Notice Inviting Tender

(Through e-tendering mode only on website- www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

NIT No.: Comfed:Engg:6332 Date: 06.11.2026

1.0 Name & address of advertiser: Managing Director, Bihar State Milk Cooperative Federation Ltd. (COMFED), Dairy Development Complex, P.O. – B.V. College, Patna – 800014. **2.0 Bid submission start date:** 11.11.2026 (Wednesday) on **www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in 3.0 Date & time of pre bid meeting:** 18.11.2026 (Wednesday) at 11:00 A.M. at COMFED, Dairy Development Complex, P.O. - B.V. College, Patna – 800014. **4.0 Bid submission End date and time by the bidders:** 01.12.2026 (Tuesday) up to 17:00 Hours on **www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in 5.0 Last date, time & place for submission of original instrument of EMD etc. as allowed in tender:** 03.12.2026 (Thursday) up to 15.00 Hours at COMFED HQ, Dairy Development Complex, P.O. – B.V. College, Patna-800014. **6.0 Date time & place of opening of Techno commercial bid:** 03.12.2026 (Thursday) up to 15:30 Hours on **www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in 7.0 Date & time of opening of price bid:** Date & time will be communicated later subsequent to approval of techno commercial bid. Place - **www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in 8.0 Validity:** 180 Days (One hundred eighty days) **9.0 Details of work:**

Name of the work/item	Estimated amount	Cost of tender documents to be paid through online.	Earnest money to be deposited.	Bid processing fees to be paid through online (Non-refundable)	Completion Period.
Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Automatic Double Circuit CIP system at Jamshedpur Dairy Under COMFED as per Technical Specification & B.O.Q of tender document.	Rs. 1,60,70,992.00	Rs. 10,000.00	Rs. 3,21,420.00	As per EPROC 2.0	05 (Five) Months

10.0 For participation in the above e- tender process the bidders are required to get themselves registered as per details given at www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in so that the user ID, Password and digital signatures are issued to them. 11.0 Tender Document can be seen and purchased on web site www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in. Any modification/amendment in tender will be notified on e-portal. The Managing Director, COMFED reserves the right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason.

Asst General Manager (Engg.)

Government of Punjab
State Health Agency, Punjab
Department of Health and Family Welfare
BSNL Circle Office, 4th Floor, Sector-34, Chandigarh
Visit us at: www.sha.punjab.gov.in, E-mail: ceo.sha.pb@punjab.gov.in

No. SHA/Admin/2026 Date:

Notice Inviting Tender
FOR HIRING OF CONCURRENT AUDIT AGENCY
(Medical Audit, Field Investigation and Verification)

Online Competitive bids are invited from eligible bidders for hiring of concurrent Audit Agency (Medical Audit, Field Investigation and Verification) at State Health Agency, Punjab.

The Tender Document shall be available on the website/ e-tender portal eproc.punjab.gov.in with effect from 11.11.2026. Bidders shall submit their Bids on this website/ e-tender portal as per the guidelines specified in the Tender Document. It shall be the responsibility of the Bidders to regularly check the website/ e-tender portal for any notice/ addenda issued in this regard.

All correspondence/ communications on the Tender Document should be made at the above address and at email id: shapunjab.tender25@gmail.com

Any corrigendum/addendum issued in connection with the tender shall be uploaded on the e-Procurement Portal and the official website of SHA Punjab (shapunjab.gov.in).

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer
State Health Agency, Punjab

DPR/Pb.:1957/12/2026-27/16936

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-AUCTION NOTICE

No. 23AC/Ctg./e-Auction/AVM/2026 Date : 09.11.2026

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through 'REPS **(https://ireps.gov.in/)** for allotment of contracts of Automatic Vending Machines (AVMs) at following railway stations/locations:

Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Railway Station	Lot No.
AVM-NOV - 03-26	25.11.2026 11:00 hrs.	ANVT	MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-158-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-159-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-160-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-161-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-162-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-163-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-164-26-1 MSS-DLI-ANVT-AVM-165-26-1
		DLI	MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-150-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-151-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-152-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI AVM-153-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-154-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-155-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-156-26-1 MSS-DLI-DLI-AVM-157-26-1
		NZM	MSS-DLI-NZM-AVM-166-26-1 MSS-DLI-NZM-AVM-167-26-1 MSS-DLI-NZM-AVM-168-26-1 MSS-DLI-NZM-AVM-169-26-1
Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen			**https://ireps.gov.in/ (E-Auction-Leasing)**

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:

- Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module - Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module
- Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details.
- A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism.
- The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions.
- Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender /E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query	Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055. Email: **catering.delhidivision@gmail.com** Tel: 011- 23743084

3923/26

Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G,
Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

FORM NO.14
[See Regulation 33(2)]
OFFICE OF THE RECOVERY OFFICER - I/II
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL DELHI (DRT 3)
4th Floor, Jeevan Tara Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi-110001
DEMAND NOTICE

**NOTICE UNDER SECTIONS 25 TO 28 OF THE RECOVERY OF DEBTS & BANKRUPTCY ACT, 1993 AND R

After 'Regime Change' at Capitol Hill, Trump Hints at Diplomacy

DON SAYS WAR EFFECTIVELY OVER; OIL TANKS

After Falling 5.9% in Previous Session, Brent Crude Slides Below $90, a First Since Aug 31

US President Donald Trump indicated he's keen to pursue diplomacy with Iran and wind down the war following a White House meeting with the prime minister of Qatar, the main mediator between the warring sides.

Further strikes on Iran won't be necessary, though the US remains "locked and loaded," Trump said on Monday after talks with Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani. "Iran, militarily, is effectively over. We're just keeping it at the status quo, and we're doing that really at the behest of countries that are their neighbours."

The comments reflect the change in Washington since the Nov 3 midterm elections. Many members of Trump's Republican party blamed the war and resulting surge in energy prices for their loss of both houses of Congress to the Democrats.

Sheikh Mohammed thanked Trump and Vice President JD Vance—who said the conflict was the primary reason for the Republicans' rout—and said he was "grateful for the positive discussions on reaching a deal and bringing peace to the region."

Oil prices extended losses from the previous session after Trump's meeting with the Qatari PM. Brent crude futures were down $2.92, or 3.15%, at $89.65 a barrel by 6:00 PM. West Texas Intermediate (WTI) futures fell $2.33, or 2.68%, to $84.52.

Having lost 5.9% in the previous session, the Brent benchmark dropped below $90 on Tuesday for the first time since August 31. Later in the day, crude breached the $90-mark again.

Negotiations between Iran and the US will carry on and there likely won't be any military escalation while they do, according to an official familiar with the matter. In the meeting with the Qatari prime minister, the US signaled that maintaining the status quo of diplomacy and applying economic pressure on Iran was the best way to resolve the conflict, said the person, who declined to be named discussing sensitive matters.

The comments from Trump and Sheikh Mohammed built on signs over recent days that the US and Iran are closer to a diplomatic breakthrough. "The political window for escalation has closed," Eurasia Group analysts including Gregory Brew and Clayton Allen said in a note to clients late Monday, lowering their odds of such an outcome to 30% from 60%.

That's "based on evidence of increasing political constraints on Trump following last week's midterm elections and the mounting opposition from inside the administration and the Republicans" to another round of all-out hostilities.

An Iranian woman takes part in a military course in Tehran on Tuesday AFP

POST-POLL DANCE?

US PRESIDENT: "We're just keeping it (Iran war) at the status quo, and we're doing that really at the behest of countries that are their neighbours"

QATARI PREMIER JOINS PARIS TALKS

Qatar's premier on Tuesday joined talks on the G7 sidelines in Paris with four European top diplomats and the Saudi foreign minister hours after meeting Trump, Paris said.

"The ministers will discuss the situation in West Asia—with a particular focus on the Iran crisis and its security and economic repercussions—both for the region and for the international community as a whole," the French foreign ministry said before the talks. **Agencies**

Rubio: We Will Keep Imposing Devastating Costs on Tehran

Paris: United Sstates secretary of state Marco Rubio told G7 foreign ministers on Tuesday that the US would keep imposing "devastating" economic costs on Iran, saying it had options beyond war or agreeing to unacceptable Iranian demands, four G7 diplomats said.

Rubio's comments came during a meeting in Paris of foreign ministers from the Group of Seven, which comprises Britain, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan and the United States, as well as the European Union.

Rubio used strong language to describe the Iranian authorities. Two diplomats said he had referred to them as "lunatics"

The diplomats said Rubio had used strong language to describe the Iranian authorities. Two said he had referred to them as "lunatics".

The diplomats quoted Rubio as saying that, rather than resuming the war or accepting Iran's demands, Washington's current policy of tough economic sanctions is working and is limiting Tehran's ability to fund its regional activities and proxies. "Rubio said that they will continue with... (imposing) devastating economic operating costs on Iran," said one of the diplomats, who all spoke on condition of anonymity. **Reuters**

SHAREHOLDER SUES CEO AND NVIDIA

Jensen & Alice in Blunderland

Now FBI Comes Knocking

Washington: US President Donald Trump said on Monday the FBI was looking into Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang's affair with a Chinese businesswoman alleged to be a spy for Beijing.

Trump said he "was amazed" by allegations about Huang, among the president's closest allies in Silicon Valley. Trump said he had spoken to the CEO, who told him that he had no idea that the woman was a spy.

"I know the FBI is looking into it," Trump said. "I think that he'll be in good shape," he added.

The probe, announced on Sunday, has put a spotlight on 63-year-old Huang's future given Nvidia's status as the world's most valuable chipmaker and the CEO's role as the most prolific salesman of the AI boom. Huang told Nvidia's employees that he had been unfaithful to his wife, without disclosing details of the relationship.

A shareholder sued Nvidia and Huang on Monday, accusing them of deceiving investors in their responses to media reports about Huang's affair that threatens national security.

The affair, which is also being scrutinised by Nvidia's board, has raised concerns that Beijing is using nefarious means to gain access to Nvidia 's cutting-edge microchips which power the development of artificial intelligence but face export restrictions to China. The complaint in a California court says the company misled investors about Huang's relationship with Alice.

The lawsuit accuses Nvidia and Huang of failing to disclose the affair and issuing false statements about Nvidia's relationship with Megaspeed, which posed a "material risk" to Nvidia's reputation and business prospects. **Agencies**

Microsoft Goes Past Nvidia in Mcap; Now No 2

Microsoft overtook Nvidia as the world's second-most valuable company on Tuesday, as the chip giant's shares fell 6% while Microsoft's stock was down 0.4% during trade.

The chipmaker was on track to shed more than $470 billion in market value over two sessions (after a 4.3% drop on Monday) as concerns mounted over the fallout from Jensen Huang's affair with a Chinese businesswoman alleged to be a Beijing spy. **Reuters**

'US Removes Aircraft from 2nd British Base after Iran Threat'

London: The US military evacuated planes from a second British airbase on Monday after a threat from Iran, the Wall Street Journal reported, weeks after Washington withdrew bombers from another British base over suspected Iran-linked security threats.

Two US refueling tankers that were using the RAF Mildenhall base were diverted to Germany earlier on Monday, while several other tankers at the base were moved to Germany and other locations later in the day, the report said, citing sources.

"For operational security reasons, we are unable to discuss specific force protection measures," a spokesperson said. "We constantly assess a variety of factors that determine what measures are implemented or modified."

Two refueling tankers that were using the RAF Mildenhall base were diverted to Germany

THUMBS UP FOR KUWAIT HQ

The six Gulf Cooperation Council states have approved the establishment of an advanced headquarters for their Unified Military Command in Kuwait and the deployment of "appropriate" forces to it, the bloc's secretary-general said.

No further details on the headquarters or the forces to be deployed were immediately available. **Reuters**

US DEFENCE SECY SLAMS EFFORTS TO IMPEACH HIM

History Will Judge Iran War Quite Differently: Hegseth

Washington: US defence secretary Pete Hegseth on Tuesday blasted efforts to impeach him as a farce that would embolden US adversaries, as he lashed out at his political opponents in Congress and the media in an unapologetic defence of his record. Hegseth also thanked President Donald Trump for his continued support as the House of Representatives scheduled a procedural vote for his impeachment.

Hegseth said past impeachments of Trump had ultimately failed. "Both times he came back stronger, and the American people sent him back to the White House. Now they're trying against a member of his cabinet."

Hegseth declined to be drawn into responding to Vice President JD Vance, who had publicly questioned the Iran war. "History will judge the Iran war quite differently than the conventional wisdom right now," he said.

Trump repeated his backing of Hegseth in Truth Social post. "Pete Hegseth gets an 'A' PLUS, PLUS, PLUS for his defence against a disgruntled, angry, defeated, former Congressman, Thomas Massie, a TOTAL LOSER!" he wrote. **Reuters**

Gift of Love 'At Least $7.5 Billion Worth of Chips Shipped to China'

Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang's affair with a Chinese businesswoman alleged to be a spy for Beijing facilitated the shipment of at least $7.5 billion worth of the company's chips to Chinese firms, The Information reported on Tuesday, citing sources.

Alice Huang, along with her husband and sister, built a network of companies across China and Singapore to acquire Nvidia chips, according to the report. At the centre of the network was Shanghai Century Litong, a China-based company founded in June 2023 that secured preferred cloud partner status with Nvidia by October, giving it priority access to the company's chips.

Century Litong was initially linked to Alice Huang's sister, Huang Yu, through a founding shareholder that was ultimately controlled by Huang Yu before exiting the company in 2024, according to the report

When orders for Nvidia chips subject to US export restrictions stalled, Alice Huang used ties to Nvidia and its distributors to secure supplies, helping move about 240,000 H100, H200 and some A100 chips into China, the report said. Century Litong rented computing capacity and operated data centers using Nvidia chips, including some barred from sale to China. **Reuters**

Britain's John Harrison Wins Booker Prize for 'The End of Everything'

London: British author John Harrison has won the 2026 Booker Prize for his novel, "The End of Everything," a dystopian satire that the prize says probes the limits of human understanding, becoming the oldest winner in the literary award's history at age 81.

Harrison's 13th novel follows Phillip Tennent and his elderly aunt Marnie on England's south coast years after social order has broken down and mysterious entities known as the iGhetti have arrived.

The Booker judges unanimously selected the 198-page book, saying it "turns you upside down, raises a wry smile and, surprisingly, given the subject matter, leaves you with a twinge of optimism."

The victory was the first Booker Prize for Harrison, whose career as a novelist and critic spans six decades and includes acclaimed science fiction and fantasy works.

His win also marks a rare triumph for speculative fiction.

Mary Beard, chair of the judging panel, described the book as "the politics of now seen through the lens of the future", saying it depicts a society grappling with a catastrophe its inhabitants do not fully understand.

The judges unanimously selected the 198-page book, saying it 'turns you upside down, raises a wry smile'

Accepting the $67,235 prize at a ceremony in London, Harrison said literary awards remained important in a "landscape of industrialised fiction."

Speaking to the Booker Prize in August, Harrison said his novel was inspired by the 2008 financial crisis and asks what happens when "all of our expectations and explanations of the world become an ongoing disaster, but we still have to make a life."

Harrison beat a shortlist that included former Booker winners Douglas Stuart and Marlon James. **Reuters**

October Consumer Prices in US Rise Slightly On-month

Washington: US inflation was higher than expected last month in a sign that the rising prices that powered sweeping Democratic victories in last week's midterm elections will continue to pose challenges for the White House and the Federal Reserve. The consumer price index rose 0.4% from September to October, the Labor Department said Tuesday, down from 0.6% the previous month. The government did not report a yearly inflation rate because last year's government shutdown meant no data was released for October 2025. Excluding the volatile food and energy categories, core prices rose 0.3%, the same as the preceding month. **AP**

California Voters Reject Measure to Tax Billionaires

Sacramento: California voters have rejected a first-in-the-nation tax on the net worth of billionaires following a contentious ballot fight that generated huge spending by some prominent tech leaders eager to stop their taxes from going up. The measure's failure is a win for Democratic leaders who opposed it, including Gov. Gavin Newsom, who may run for president in 2028. Critics of the tax, known as Proposition 40, said it would have prompted ultrawealthy taxpayers to leave the state. Most Californians vote by mail, and any ballot postmarked by Election Day that arrives within a week is counted, meaning it often takes days or even weeks for close races to be settled. The "no" side raised roughly 10 times as much as the "yes" side. Google co-founder Sergey Brin alone dumped more than $100 million into a political action committee working to defeat the measure. **AP**

China's Trade Surplus Goes Past $1 T for 2nd yr Running

Hong Kong: China's trade surplus exceeded $1 trillion for a second straight year, according to official data released Tuesday, as pressure mounts for greater balance in trade with Beijing.

Exports in October surged 35.2% from a year earlier, the customs agency said. Exports have grown rapidly this year, supported by high-tech goods like semiconductors and autos.

Imports rose 41.6% year-on-year. Between January and October, China logged a $1.04 trillion trade surplus, even as the trade surplus narrowed last month to $105.3 billion from $133.5bn in September as imports picked up pace.

Exports in October surged 35.2% from a year earlier while Imports rose 41.6% YoY

That puts China on track for surpassing last year's record $1.2 trillion trade surplus in 2026.

"We expect Chinese exports to stay strong for the rest of this year, led by electronics and autos," said Dave Chia, an economist at Moody's Analytics.

China's imports soared in October partly because of a recovery in shipments of crude oil from the Persian Gulf. **AP**

US First to Take Away UN's Right to Review Human Rights

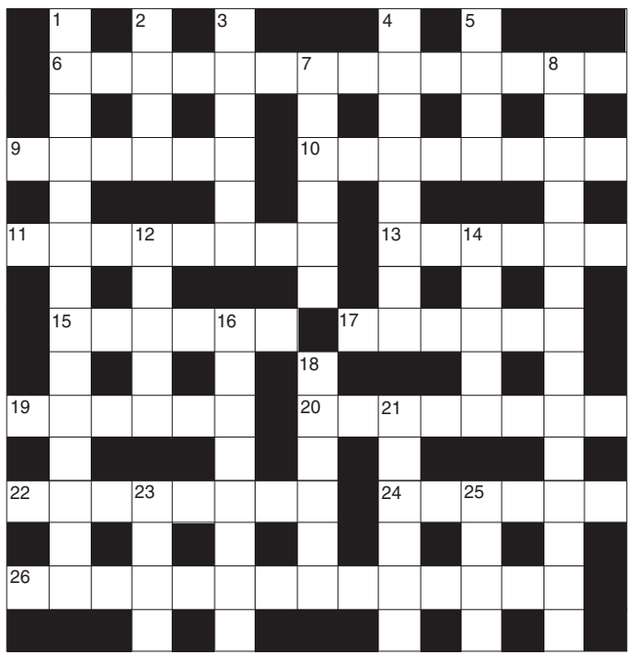
Geneva: The United States is set Tuesday to become the first country to fully shun a regular review of its human rights record at the UN's top rights body since it was created two decades ago.

The Trump administration last year pulled the US out of the Human Rights Council, accusing it of an anti-US and anti-Israel bias, and alleging that it didn't uphold the very values it promotes. Supporters back the council's mandate to keep tabs on human rights in all UN member states including the US, which has drawn criticism for its policies including strong-arm deportations and targeted killings of alleged drug-runners in the Caribbean and Pacific.

The Geneva-based council regularly examines the rights records of all 193 U.N. member states — generally about every four to five years — as part of a process known as the universal periodic review. **AP**

NON-SEQUITUR

Crossword 9753



ACROSS

6 At an advantage, like a batter near the pitch of the ball? (2,3,5,4)
9 Infuriate a Green becoming ruffled (6)
10 Terribly inaccurate and in a poor state? (5,3)
11 Start to welcome criticism by attendant for packaging (8)
13 Inferior lot of spots in borders of Turkey (6)
15 Carefully arrange uniform put in wooden container (6)
17 Follows top ads when broadcast (6)
19 Coloured pencil caught by shaft of light at work (6)
20 Independent soldier and diplomat firstly ignored, travelling together for protection? (2,6)
22 Emergency vessel on water struggling for a bit to retain energy (8)
24 Urges simple reforms (6)
26 Slight break after activity? (6,8)

DOWN

1 Worker on set discounts order surprisingly (5,9)
2 Part of racket, namely, is feature of Sicily (4)
3 Woman has container for storage near ground (6)
4 Deed unit prepared, like a first submission? (8)
5 Dubious moment without leader (4)
7 Given gentle mockery with raised lines? (6)
8 Lots offered, huh, possibly typifying some dresses? (3-3-8)
12 Lively element in supper ky boshed (5)
14 A second enclosure for tree (5)
16 Eccentric toasting South American dancer (8)
18 Model's chance that should be easily taken? (6)
21 Determine odd characters in cell in Switzerland (6)
23 Smooth figure with no front (4)
25 Chap in darkness, we hear (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9752:
ACROSS: 1 Off the charts. **8** Extinct. **9** Shiatsu. **11** Peacemaker. **12** Best. **14** Resonate. **16** Closer. **17** Saw. **19** Leonie. **21** Reappear. **24** Onyx. **25** Sharp-edged. **27** Emptier. **28** Odorous. **29** Hallucinates.
DOWN: 1 Outlays. **2** Fingernail. **3** Hot pants. **4** Costed. **5** Akin. **6** Tethers. **7** Temporal lobe. **10** Uttar Pradesh. **13** Clapped-out. **15** Ear. **18** Wear down. **20** Olympia. **22** Engross. **23** Choric. **26** Fill.

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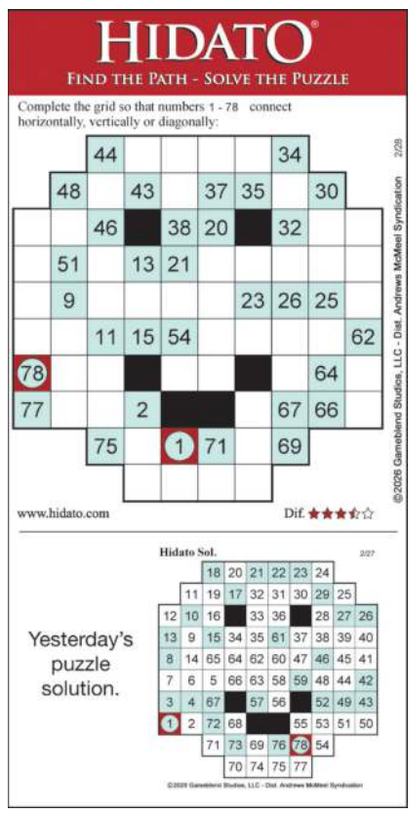
HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 78 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:



7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 hangar denizens (6)	
2 bob or beehive (6)	
3 they close between acts (8)	
4 in a foolish way (8)	
5 "King Kong" star Watts (5)	
6 Philippines' capital city (6)	
7 blows (9)	

NES	PLA	IR	AI	CU
DO	NS	MAN	SQ	LY
ND	UA	HA	STU	NA
ERS	OMI	ILA	PID	RT

Yesterday's Answers: 1. BIDDABLE 2. PLASTIC 3. MONEY 4. JEROME 5. CHONGQING 6. MESSENGER 7. DRIVE

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BRAND EQUITY
THE ECONOMIC TIMES NOVEMBER 11-17, 2026

IMAGE: AI GENERATED

Instagram's 90-minute video bet could soon take it into direct confrontation with the Big Daddy of online platforms, YouTube

CoverStory
By **Javed Farooqui**

Instagram is looking beyond the scroll. As it tests videos of up to 90 minutes, the Meta-owned social media platform is seeking to turn its short-form video audience into long-form viewers, opening a new front in its competition with YouTube and premium over-the-top platforms for consumers' time and advertising budgets.

The move comes as digital video consumption expands beyond smartphones to connected televisions (CTVs) in India, where a growing creator economy, rising content consumption across languages, and increasing large-screen viewing are creating new opportunities.

Instagram is initially testing the 90-minute video format with select creators in Brazil and the US, with a broader rollout planned over time. The company has not announced a timeline for its India launch, but with the country being its largest market by viewership, it will only be a matter of time.

The proposed format could accommodate podcasts, comedy specials, and episodic videos, allowing creators to use reels for discovery and audience building before directing viewers to longer content on the same platform on larger screens. Instagram is working on a TV version of reels, aiming to bring its video experience to larger screens.

Continued on Page 2 >>

THE BIG AD RUSH
(Increase in gross advertising revenue from India for FY25)

Meta India: Grew 29% to ₹29,392 crore

Google India: Grew 11.3% to ₹34,742 crore

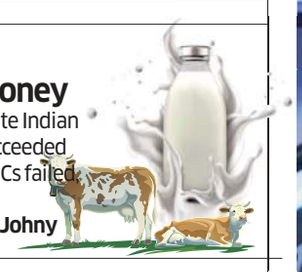
INSIDE BE

PG2
Beauty Gets A Facelift
In a crowded category, brands are looking at another way to stand out - packaging, finds **Shannika Ramos**

PG3
7 Trends in Gen-Z Weddings
The next generation of weddings are heavily tech mediated, says **Madhulika Sachdeva Mathur**

PG3
Crafting to Be Remembered
There are ads that are meant to be remembered. This maison's brand film is one of them, says **Sagar Mahabaleshwarkar**

PG4
Milk Money
How private Indian dairies succeeded where MNCs failed, reports **Alenjith K Johny**



Temple Run

Deepinder Goyal's latest venture has turned into a clash between blind faith and scientific scrutiny

By **Pratishtha Bagai**

Deepinder Goyal's big bet on wearables – Temple – has spent the week standing trial in the social media courtroom.

Much of the controversy stems from a claim that the device tracks blood flow to your brain, and measures a biomarker – called entropy – that Goyal's Temple team claims to have discovered, that is "only readable on the temple region, and nowhere else, that measures the real-time cost of you being alive".

The debate became a playground for tribalism

That claim, along with the price of the device, triggered backlash online. Doctors armed with medical literature led the inquest. Goyal conducted his own defence, telling critics to "keep raging". The public gallery, packed with fans and trolls, promptly sat in judgement.

In the middle of the Temple debate – one that should ideally be about the efficacy of claims – became a playground for social-media tribalism and founder worship.

The Billionaire Effect

Success in one industry can make a founder's confidence and competence in tackling entirely different problems seem convincing to their followers.

"Once you get immensely wealthy, you think you can solve the problems of the world," says brand consultant Santosh Desai.

One side believes such founders have the resources and ability to contribute something valuable, he says, while the other sees people with too high an opinion of their own ideas. The Temple debate plays out against these competing perceptions.

"Nobody currently knows whether Temple has any merit or not. Everybody is arguing on the basis of the larger narrative," he says.

Desai does not expect the row to leave a lasting mark on Zomato or Eternal, drawing a distinction between Goyal's personal brand and the business he built.

PV Sindhu seen wearing a Temple device

Product of Beliefs

For Temple, the question is what all this attention does to trust in the product. On social media, the volume of support can also drown out the substance of a criticism.

"It's a numbers game; it's not a weightage game. There are more trolls than there are doctors involved in this debate. Therefore, the debate goes from the sublime to the ridiculous," says Harish Bijoor, who runs an eponymous brand consultancy.

His warning concerns trust in Temple. "Temple is a branding headache today. But this branding headache can become a branding heart attack. So let the headache not become a heart attack."

Zomato did not respond to queries from *Brand Equity* by press time.

Social Media Bouts

The speed with which a product debate becomes a loyalty test says as much about social media as it does about Temple.

"People begin associating themselves more to a person or a brand or a country or a viewpoint, and that's where anything that is said against it becomes a personal attack," said Nirali Bhatia, cyberpsychologist and founder of the cyber wellness foundation, Cyberbaap.

When national pride enters the argument, the person asking for evidence can end up having to defend their own loyalty instead. The burden shifts from explaining the product to explaining why one questioned it.

"Once you bring in the nationalism card, the other person is on the back foot. The moment you are accused of being anti-national, you have to prove you are not," said Rituparna Patgiri, assistant professor of sociology, IIT Guwahati. For her, the row also sits inside a wider devaluing of expertise.

"There is a disdain for scientific expertise and expertise of any kind," she says. Opinions rooted in research and training can be dismissed, she says, while statements by innovators and company CEOs are treated as credible.

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Vice Hits India

Industry places bets on the GTA VI release to bring a console gaming boom

By **Abhishek Manikandan and Sneha Joseph**

In just a few weeks, gamers across India will grab their controllers and return to the streets of Vice City. With Rockstar Games' blockbuster GTA VI set for its console launch on November 19, this time, it's not just the game that is different. The graphics, the protagonists, and the hype are all going to be off the charts.

The game launches on consoles first; industry hopes to draw serious gamers in India

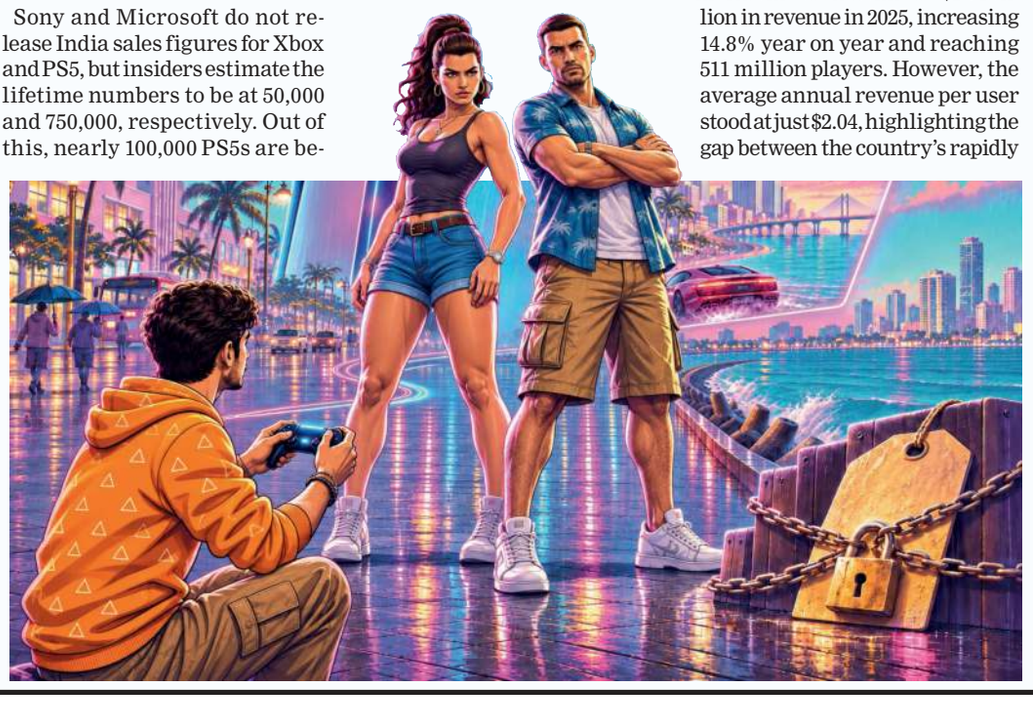
Industry players hope the release will draw more people towards serious gaming in India. But with the game launching on consoles first, and its price far above India's average annual gaming revenue per player, how much of that hype can turn into sales?

What is clear is the release of the much-awaited AAA title has kicked off the excitement.

"Globally, in the short term, GTA VI will turn the spotlight towards the gaming ecosystem and bring lost players back into gaming overall," says Anuj Tandon, global partner, emerging markets, at gaming investor BITKRAFT Ventures. While Tandon's thoughts on the global scene are positive, he's more optimistic about what the title can do in the country.

According to him, GTA VI can plug the culture gap in Indian gaming. "We've not had real gaming culture for quite some time. GTA VI can really be the game that brings that in," he says.

Sony and Microsoft do not release India sales figures for Xbox and PS5, but insiders estimate the lifetime numbers to be at 50,000 and 750,000, respectively. Out of this, nearly 100,000 PS5s are believed to have been sourced from the grey market.



According to Game Developer Association of India's GameDev Outlook 2026, India's video-game market made an estimated $1.04 billion in revenue in 2025, increasing 14.8% year on year and reaching 511 million players. However, the average annual revenue per user stood at just $2.04, highlighting the gap between the country's rapidly expanding gaming ecosystem and its monetisation potential.

GTA VI is priced above ₹5,999, translating to over $59.45, which is significantly higher than the average annual gaming spend of a domestic player. This raises questions about how much of the Indian player base will be willing to pay for the title.

GTA VI is priced ₹5,999+, which is a lot higher than the average annual gaming spend of a domestic player. How much of the Indian player base would be willing to pay for the title?

While the game can look pricey when adding in console costs, an insider tells *Brand Equity* that "personal computer is where the unlock will be". Unfortunately, the PC impact is a longer-term possibility, dependent on a PC release that has not been announced.

Some gamers also think this is going to happen as and when a PC version is released.

"People who play on their phones might get a PC or gaming laptop when GTA VI hits the market just to jump on the hype train," says Asin Iqbal, a PC-gaming enthusiast.

"GTA, in a way, is a pop culture moment, and gamers, especially those in tier-1 cities, are looking forward to it," says Anurag Choudhary, CEO of agentic game publisher Felicity.

Choudhary also predicts a potential boost in PC and console sales following the game's release. "[The release of GTA VI] will be a defining moment for PC and console sales. Around 3–4% of Indian gamers are console gamers, and I think that share might rise," he says.

How will the launch affect indie gaming companies in India? Choudhary says several players in the segment are looking to stay out of the spotlight during the release period, as consumer spending is likely to be concentrated on the highly anticipated title.

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BE Interview **Hardeep Singh Brar,** CEO, BMW Group India

Beyond the Badge: BMW's Luxury Pitch in India

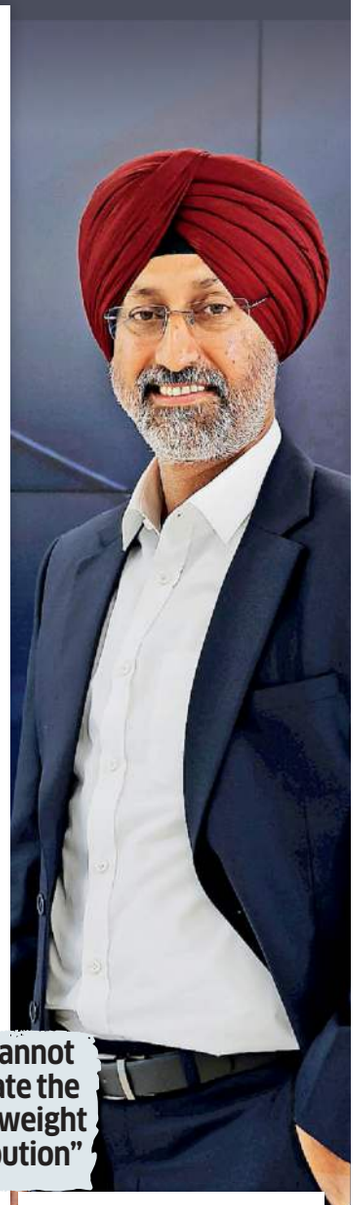
The luxury buyer is changing. So is the market. The brand leading sales is the one adapting with the times

By **Lijee Philip**

BMW India has spent much of the past nine months at the top of the luxury car sales charts. But the more interesting story is what is driving that position. In a market where mainstream cars increasingly offer technology and features once associated with luxury, BMW is making a case for engineering, driving dynamics, and a broader definition of comfort. **Hardeep Singh Brar**, CEO, BMW Group India, says it's about the changing luxury buyer, the EV opportunity, the rise of smaller markets, and why the brand isn't chasing every emerging segment.

With cars in the ₹40–50 lakh bracket offering technology and features that can sometimes surpass those in entry-level luxury models, what is the luxury buyer really paying a premium for today? Just the badge?

The badge is important, but it cannot be the only reason someone buys a luxury car. At BMW, our differentiation comes from engineering and driving dynamics. Our cars are known for their 50:50 weight distribution, which gives them exceptional balance and stability. The precision of the steering, tyres, and mass distribution, along with a low centre of gravity, are engineering nuances that are difficult to replicate.



"You cannot replicate the 50:50 weight distribution"

We also offer rear-wheel drive in several mid- and top-end models, unlike most cars in the market, which are front-wheel drive. This contributes to the balance and makes the driving experience distinctly different.

Beyond the product, we offer experiences through the BMW Excellence Club, including concierge services and the M Drift Academy. As customers move from a 3 Series to a 5 Series and then a 7 Series, the experience must keep getting better. Luxury is about delivering that progression, not simply putting a badge on a car.

BMW has traditionally been seen as a driver's car. Yet its long-wheelbase strategy suggests it is also making a strong pitch to the chauffeur-driven Indian buyer. How important has this shift been?

Indian customers value space and rear-seat comfort. Our long-wheelbase models deliver these without compromising BMW's driver-centric DNA. This has been a winning formula in India because customers get the comfort they want alongside the performance and driving character they expect from a BMW.

More than 50% of our luxury customers choose a long-wheelbase car, while 52% of our portfolio this year comprises these models. Customers are now buying BMW not just for the driving experience but also for rear-seat comfort.

Continued on Page 2 >>

THE BRAND EQUITY SHOW
by THE ECONOMIC TIMES

CAN INDIA BUILD ITS OWN SPORTSWEAR GIANT?

Abhishek Ganguly spent years building Puma's business in India. Now the former Puma India and Southeast Asia CEO is trying to build something more ambitious: An Indian sportswear company with its own manufacturing engine, brands and retail network, and the means to compete beyond India.

Agilitas Sports started with a factory, and acquiring Mochiko Shoes before building out brands such as Lotto and One8 and opening the multi-brand store SportsYard. Ganguly says greater control over the value chain can help the company move faster. "The thought was how do we crash the time between actually reacting to a consumer signal and delivering a consumer experience?"

It is a striking bet in a category where global brands have set the pace for decades. Ganguly knows the risk: "Either we are crazy, or we are smart."

But manufacturing scale and partnering with famous names will only take Agilitas so far. "Consumers don't need more products, more brands, or more retail," he says. The question is can the company give them products worth choosing again and build a business that makes money as it grows?

This week on *The Brand Equity Show*, **Sonali Krishna** speaks with **Abhishek Ganguly** about why he is building Agilitas from the factory floor up, how he plans to turn One8 and Lotto into lasting brands, and what it will take for Indian sportswear to compete globally. His measure of success is blunt: "Sales without margin, sales without bottom line, sales without cash flow are not a reflection of it."

Scan QR code for *The Brand Equity Show*

GlobeTrotting

Fox Completes $22B Roku Deal to Expand Digital Reach

Fox Corp completed its $22 billion acquisition of Roku last Friday, a major bet that the streaming platform will bolster the broadcaster's advertising business and expand the online reach of its sports and news programming.

Announced in June, the cash-and-stock deal gives Fox access to the more than 100 million households using Roku's platform, potentially helping the cable TV-reliant media company build a larger digital audience and better target ads.

–Reuters

Beauty Gets A Facelift

In a category as crowded as beauty, brands are looking at another way to stand out: Packaging

By **Shannika Ramos**

Before the product, there's the box. What was once an afterthought has now become a core aspect of the unboxing process, one that creates anticipation before the product is even out.

"From a consumer perspective, I believe in love at first sight," says Akanksha Kommirelly, a lifestyle influencer. "It's human to be drawn to something that creates curiosity."

According to reports from consulting firm Nextdigm, about 67% of urban and young Indian consumers say product aesthetics and quality packaging directly influence their purchasing decisions.

"Packaging is more than just a protective layer," says Manav Sachdev, who redesigned a Forest Essentials product lineup in 2011. "It's a silent brand ambassador that communicates value and it immediately connects psychology with touch."

A Premium Lens

For Forest Essentials, Sachdev designed the Sanjeevni and Soundarya ranges that redefined how the brand was perceived through its elegant packaging. "The brief was to create packaging that reflected the authenticity of Ayurveda while steering away from the clinical look that was common in the category."

This intention also defined brands like Kama Ayurveda, which reinterprets the traditions of Ayurveda through a premium lens. "Our design language is clean and contemporary while drawing inspiration from India's visual and cultural heritage," says Vivek Sahni, founder of Kama Ayurveda.

When Forest Essentials' founder Mira Kulkarni went to Shruti Singhi, creative director, Mother Tongue Design, the original package only had white labels on it.

"We needed to introduce colour," Singhi says. "The main word we circled back to was 'premium'. We took inspiration from mythological paintings seen in royal palaces and built on that layer by layer."

Carving A Niche

Packaging is not about decoration. "It stands out when there is a strong idea pushing it and every detail feels intentional," says Adwaita Nayar, CEO, House of Nykaa.

Packaging also taps into the desire for status and visibility; a distinctive box or bag or colour can become instantly recognisable and come to be associated with a brand – like the Hermes orange.

"Today, packaging is being designed to be distinct on screen, participate in cultural trends, and give consumers something they want to be seen with," says Manoj Kumar, co-founder of luxury consultancy Val-More. "Nothing stands out more than something consumers want to display."

Design Communication

Is display the only factor that matters in package design? Silki Agrawal, Ekta Agrawal, and Ally Matthan of PEKKO Beauty say, "We did not want to imitate a Western visual language. The idea was to create a design that does not need to explain its Indianness visually."

> Packaging's not decoration. It's a silent brand ambassador that communicates value

Every element, from design and materials to the way a product is revealed, can strengthen the brand's connection with the consumer. From the anticipation of a product reveal to the ritual of a 'Get Ready with Me', packaging becomes the face of a brand before its product has even had a moment.

How do you rise above the din? Sahni says, "Packaging is often the first point of engagement with a beauty product."

For Nayar, "No matter the category, thoughtful storytelling can make the experience memorable before the first application even begins."

Recycling Rates

According to reports, the global beauty industry generates an estimated 120 billion units of packaging waste every year, with overall consumer waste jumping roughly 43% during the winter holidays.

"D2C brands, especially during the festive season, come to us with special requests for PR kits," says Varsha Anchan, founder, Mindful Official Sustainable Packaging Solutions. "We try to downsize the packaging. Instead of having five layers, we recommend two. We ask brands to consider a compostable bag instead of a fancy PR box," Anchan says.

When asked about the recycling rate of beauty packages, Anchan notes only 50% of it is truly recyclable and this is because the base material most brands use is paper.

Discovery and Desirability

As beauty products move from vanity tables and into online content, they have to perform on the camera, in the hands of creators, and within everyday life. "Packaging is moving from something that merely contains the product to something that the consumer can carry, display, collect, and be seen with," Kumar says.

Packaging has moved beyond functionality. "In a category as crowded as beauty, distinctive and innovative packaging creates an immediate point of recognition, communicates a brand's personality, and makes a product more discoverable," says a spokesperson from Tira Beauty.

In a market where the smallest details can shape perception, packaging now is no longer an afterthought – it is part of the brand's identity.

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Beyond the Badge: BMW's Luxury Pitch in India

Are luxury EVs attracting existing luxury car owners looking to experiment with electric mobility, or creating a new entry point for buyers upgrading?

We are seeing both, almost equally. Around 50% are existing luxury car owners adding an EV as their second or third car. The other 50% come from the mass and mass-premium segments, looking to upgrade to luxury while embracing electric mobility.

One in four cars we sell today is an EV, and our EV sales grew by 78% in first half of the year. Models such as the i5 and i7 appeal to existing BMW customers, while the iX1 is bringing new buyers into the luxury fold.

As charging infrastructure improves, EVs will play an increasingly important role in expanding the luxury market.

> "The luxury car market could reach 3% by 2030"

As affluence spreads beyond metros, are tier-2 and tier-3 markets creating a different kind of luxury buyer? What is driving their growth?

The aspirations are broadly similar. Customers in these markets love the brand and what BMW represents. Interestingly, they also have access to newly developed highways, where they can experience our cars' driving dynamics in a way that is sometimes difficult in congested metros. This is helping sales.

The contribution of markets beyond the top 10 cities is increasing. Earlier, the top 10 markets accounted for almost 85% of sales. Today, metros contribute around 70–75%. Markets beyond the top 10 cities are growing at approximately 20% or more, compared with overall market growth of around 14–15%.

As brands establish themselves in larger cities, their appeal gradually travels to smaller markets. We are seeing that happen and are expanding into the next set of cities to improve customer access and confidence.

> "The luxury car buyer is no longer just behind the wheel"

Luxury cars still account for a small share of India's passenger vehicle market. What will change that equation, particularly as a younger generation of affluent consumers emerges?

During Covid, luxury cars accounted for around 0.8% of the overall market. That has since increased to approximately 1.1%. I believe it could reach 3% by 2030.

The younger generation, particularly startup founders and entrepreneurs, has a different attitude towards luxury. Earlier generations sometimes viewed spending on luxury as unnecessary. That mindset is changing.

Electrification is another catalyst. The total cost of ownership gap between mass-market and luxury EVs is not always as wide as customers might imagine. Also, the luxury market is present in only around 50 cities, compared with nearly 1,000 for the mass market. Expanding our retail network will help unlock this opportunity.

Around 40% of our customers come from other luxury brands, while another 40% are upgrading from near-premium cars. We are therefore attracting competitors' customers as well as bringing new buyers into luxury.

With Mercedes-Benz entering the luxury multi-purpose vehicles space with the V-Class, is BMW missing out by staying away from a segment that plays to India's appetite for chauffeur-driven comfort and space?

We understand that Indian customers value space and rear-seat comfort. That is one reason our long-wheelbase strategy has worked so well.

But we believe that even when someone buys a car for the rear-seat experience, they should be able to enjoy driving it themselves over the weekend. We have no plans to introduce an MPV at present. Our focus will remain on sedans and SUVs. That balance between rear-seat luxury and driving pleasure is central to what BMW stands for.

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For Your Eyes Only

That means they want to keep audiences from drifting to YouTube and capture a share of the advertising moving to CTV. But in India, where YouTube has greater reach and a proven creator revenue model, Instagram's bet will depend on whether it can make long-form video pay.

The New TV

India has established itself as the global epicentre of digital video consumption. Instagram commands a massive 480.55 million users in the country, while YouTube has an even larger reach of 573 million users, according to data from Statista and DataReportal.

For both, India is their single largest market.

The move comes as YouTube doubles down on premium long-form content amid the growth of CTV. They struck a partnership with Ekta Kapoor's Balaji Telefilms to launch five premium original shows comprising 200 episodes. The digital-first model allows the production house to retain ownership of its intellectual property.

> Instagram's new video format could reshape creator deals

Announcing that partnership, Gunjan Soni, managing director, YouTube India, says, "The future of TV has to be designed around a digital-first audience that wants the best of both worlds: High-quality shows on the biggest screen in the home, with the flexibility of on-demand."

YouTube has been positioning itself as the "new TV".

According to Ormax, the country's active CTV audience reached 206.9 million, up 60% from 2025, underscoring prominence of TV in digital consumption.

Instagram's move could potentially accelerate the shift of advertising. "With CTV homes expected to reach over 80 million by 2030, all content platforms – across long form, short video, music, and news – are building their CTV products," said Ashish Pherwani, partner and leader, Media & Entertainment Sector, EY India.

Creator Battle

Instagram's ability to attract serious long-form creators will depend on whether it can offer a sustainable and transparent monetisation model.

"YouTube will face serious competition at scale. However, YouTube's monetisation model is very transparent, and that is what drives creators," says Uday Sodhi, partner, Kurate Digital Consulting.

Instagram will need to develop an effective monetisation strategy and share revenue aggressively to attract creators, he says. The cost of producing 90-minute content will need to be supported by strong monetisation, an area where YouTube has an established advantage.

"It will not be easy to wean away the big, serious creators who produce or share long-form content," Sodhi says.

Instagram has traditionally been an engagement destination for creators, with brand collaborations serving as a key revenue stream. The new strategy could create opportunities for independent creators and regional media players to reach wider audiences.

Rajesh Sethi, PwC India's leader for media, entertainment, and sports, sees the move more as an attempt to retain viewers within Instagram's ecosystem. "Instagram has built a large audience for short videos. It now wants to retain that audience for longer content rather than lose viewers to YouTube," he says.

The Metric System

For advertisers, the shift could change how creator-led content is packaged and measured. Anil Pandit, founder, Advantage Insights, says Instagram's 90-minute video test could reshape creator deals even before it has an impact on media budgets.

A Hindi podcast, for instance, could offer sponsors both the full episode and the reels that drive viewers towards it. However, advertisers would need deeper engagement metrics to assess the value of such integrations.

"If my brand appears at minute 18, I want to know how many people reached minute 18. A million views on a reel won't answer that," Pandit says.

Another important metric, he adds, would be whether viewers return for subsequent episodes. A Marathi cooking creator who attracts viewers to a full recipe and gets them to return the following Sunday could build a series that brands can sponsor over an entire season.

"The number I will watch is how many people discover a show through a reel and come back for episode two. That's when Instagram starts competing for a viewing habit," he says.

Instagram would also need to show incremental reach to convince advertisers to shift budgets from YouTube.

"If Instagram can do both, the question I want to ask is simple: What audience does the next ₹10 lakh on Instagram add that my YouTube plan hasn't already reached? That's the kind of data that moves a media budget," Pandit says.

The Wait

Vikas Khanchandani, founder, Sproutside, believes Instagram and YouTube serve different viewing needs, despite significant audience overlap.

"Instagram is about people, while YouTube is about intent. The audiences overlap, but we open these two apps for different fixes," he says.

Instagram's strength is in personality-led content where the relationship between a creator and their audience is central. YouTube, meanwhile, is better suited to search-driven and evergreen content, tutorials, music, film catalogues, and shared family viewing.

Deepak Dhar, founder and group CEO of Banijay Asia and Endemol Shine India, says the move challenges the assumption that social media content must be short and snackable. "That said, the feature hasn't trolled out in India yet, and we'd like to see how it performs during the testing phase, particularly in terms of audience behaviour and monetisation, before making any firm plans."

Instagram may be able to make videos longer, but the harder task will be giving viewers, creators, and advertisers a reason to stay.

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From Face Recognition to WhatsApp Control Room

7 Trends in Gen-Z Weddings

BE *Dope*

Move over Pinterest boards, Instagram photographers, and WhatsApp groups. The next generation of weddings are heavily tech mediated, says **Madhulika Sachdeva Mathur**

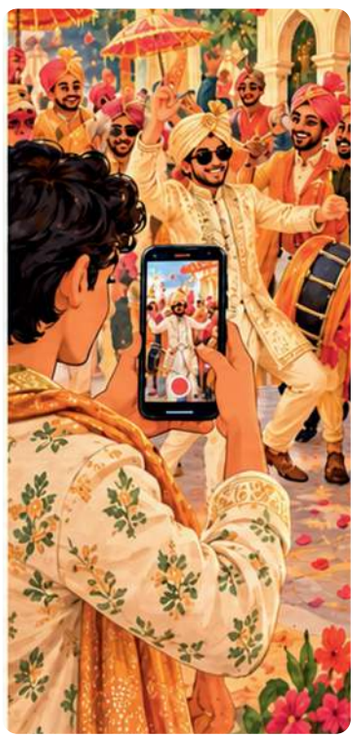
Ask a Gen-Z couple how their wedding planning is going, and they will reach for their phone to show you something. A Pinterest board, a photographer they found on Instagram, a WhatsApp group for their wedding planning? No. For these couples, technology is now part of how the wedding is announced, how it is personalised, how guests are drawn into it, and how it is remembered. Here are seven tech and media trends that are reshaping the wedding industry.

1 Pre-wedding shoots, AI-generated

Remember the Nano Banana AI craze from last year? It was a wild reminder of how fast technology can upend things. Suddenly, couples were taking casual selfies and generating unreal pre-wedding portraits with Lake Pichola in Udaipur as the backdrop, perched on the cliffs of Santorini, or starring in a vintage Bollywood poster.

People aren't ditching real photographers. They are using AI to create mood boards. Couples are using it to visualise outfits, locations, and colour palettes before even briefing a decorator or a designer. For vendors, the dynamic has shifted. Clients no longer show up with vague Pinterest ideas; they walk in holding a finished picture of their exact vision, and the job is to make it real and better.

2 The wedding content creator is the latest vendor



Alongside the photographer, cinematographer, and decorator, couples now book a wedding content creator: Someone armed with a smartphone, whose job is to shoot vertical, trend-led clips and turn them around in hours, not months. It's all about the raw, candid moments – the backstage getting-ready frenzy, the big outfit reveals, and the madness of the *baraat* shot from the perspective of a hype-bestie, all cut to trending audio and posted while the celebrations are still on. Some agencies even livestream the wedding throughout, charging anywhere between ₹2.5 lakh and ₹4.5 lakh for a three-day celebration. Couples show up with shot lists of reels they want to recreate. The traditional wedding film still matters for posterity, but the creator delivers what Gen Z values most: Immediacy.

3 WhatsApp becomes the wedding's control room

India runs on WhatsApp, and so do its weddings. The family broadcast list has evolved into proper guest-management tech built on the WhatsApp Business: One-tap RSVPs for each function, automatic reminders, personalised itineraries, collection of flight tickets and ID proofs for destination venues. There are dedicated AI concierges fielding panicked "what time does the *haldi* actually start?" messages at 2 a.m. For a generation that dreads chasing people on the phone, WhatsApp has become a dashboard.

4 QR codes and face recognition replace "send me the pics"

The post-wedding scramble for photos is being solved by tech. Guests now walk into venues where a standee with a QR code invites them to upload whatever they shoot to a shared gallery, and Indian platforms like Samaro let them do it over WhatsApp, too.

The more interesting bit is face recognition. On apps such as Kamero, Samaro, and Dreamcast's Picbot, a guest takes a selfie, and the platform pulls out every photo they appear in, professional and candid, sometimes while the event is still on.

No more blurry phone photos forwarded on family groups, no more waiting weeks for the photographer's drive link. For hosts, it is a guest-experience upgrade; for guests, it is the instant gratification they expect from everything.

5 Cash gifts go UPI

The crisp cash envelope with the ₹1 coin stuck to it may soon retire for a quick QR scan. A Kerala wedding went viral when the bride's father taped a Paytm code to his shirt so guests could send over their cash gifts without having to juggle envelopes.

6 AI to call guests and collect RSVPs

Every Indian wedding has those relatives who never reply to the invite. Instead of parents spending exhausting evenings chasing them down, new services let AI do the legwork.

If guests ignore the initial WhatsApp invite, an AI voice agent rings them up, speaking naturally in Hindi, English, or regional languages. It confirms headcount, tracks dietary preferences across different functions, and logs everything straight into the couple's dashboard.

7 The caricature corner gets an AI makeover

The live caricature artist patiently sketching guests in the corner has been a *sangeet* classic for years. Now, that corner is powered by AI. Guests pose in front of a camera and, within seconds, get a caricature, a bobblehead, or a Ghibli-style portrait of themselves, printed on the spot and sent to their phone. Vendors across Delhi, Gurugram, and Kolkata are already plugging these setups right alongside 360-degree video booths and magic mirrors. The appeal is simple: No queue. A live artist can sketch maybe six to ten guests an hour, while an AI booth can get through the whole wedding party in the same time.

The author is co-founder, WeddingSutra. Views expressed are personal.

In BE Dope, experts unpack big questions shaping the consumption economy.

Side Take

Amazon adds Uber Eats to List of Services for Amazon Prime Members

Amazon is adding a new restaurant delivery perk for its Prime members, escalating the food delivery wars.

The Seattle-based online behemoth said that it has agreed to add Uber Eats to its list of services for Amazon Prime members in the US. The service, which will be effective immediately, will allow members to order from hundreds of thousands of restaurants from Uber Eats directly from Amazon.com and within the retailer's shopping app with no delivery fees for orders over $25.

The tie-up with Uber Eats marks Amazon's second partnership with a restaurant delivery partner. In 2024, Amazon added Grubhub for Amazon Prime members.

The announcement comes as DoorDash announced last month that it was offering $17 billion to buy Instacart in a deal that could consolidate the grocery delivery business in the US and abroad.

Walmart is also pushing into restaurant delivery. In its first deal with a restaurant delivery partner, Walmart partnered with Subway, its largest in-store restaurant tenant, this past summer. It has since expanded to select locations at Dunkin' and Papa Johns. The company said it now has 2,400 restaurant locations on its restaurant delivery platform. **–AP**

New Godzilla Film Tops Box Office in the US

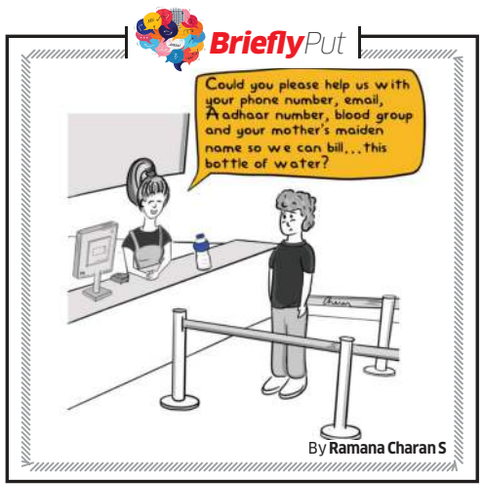
Godzilla Minus Zero was the highest-grossing movie in the US last weekend, setting a record for a Japanese-language, live-action picture in the world's largest theatrical market.

Produced by Toho, the latest instalment in the reptilian monster franchise generated $31.6 million in US and Canadian theatres, as per estimates from Rentrak, finishing ahead of Warner Bros. Pictures' *The Cat in the Hat*.

Its predecessor, *Godzilla Minus One*, opened with $11.4 million in 2023 and slowly built momentum. The movie won an Oscar for best visual effects, becoming the first Godzilla movie to win one.

Japan isn't the only Asian country making a push on to US Imax screens. India's *Ramayana* grossed $8.9 million in the US and Canada. The film was shot for Imax and enlisted Oscar-winning composer Hans Zimmer, part of an effort to position the Indian blockbuster for a wider global audience. **–Bloomberg**

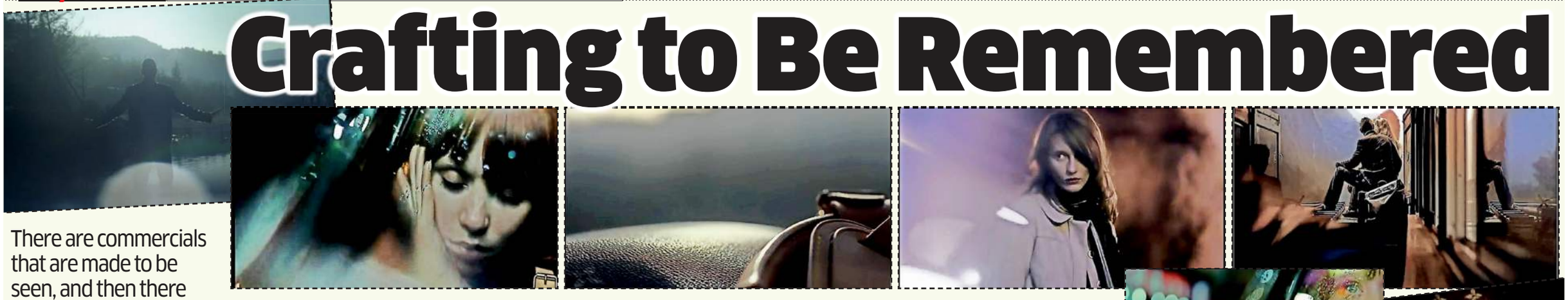
Briefly *Put*



By **Ramana Charan S**

BE/G.O.A.T. ***Sagar Mahabaleshwarkar,*** *executive director, Salt Brand Solutions*

Crafting to Be Remembered



There are commercials that are made to be seen, and then there are the ones that meant to be remembered. This maison's ad campaign falls in the second category

French fashion house Louis Vuitton's 'A Journey' creates an experience that stays long after the screen goes dark.

There are thousands of advertisements made every year. Most are seen and forgotten. Some stay with us for a while. And then there are a rare few that become a part of us.

'A Journey', directed by Bruno Aveillan in 2008, is a beautiful example of this. The film starts with a simple but profound question: What is a journey?

That question is interesting because it takes us beyond the obvious. Louis Vuitton is a brand associated with luxury travel, with a coveted catalogue of designer travel bags and paraphernalia, but the film is not just about travelling from one place to another. It makes us think about our own journeys, the people we meet, the experiences we gather, and the memories we carry.

That is where the idea becomes powerful. It moves the conversation from the product to the person.

The Power of Making People Feel

The film's beauty is not just in the images. Beautiful cinematography, evocative music, and impressive production can make a film look good. But looking good and making people feel something are two very different things.

The real question: Does every element of the film serve the idea?

In 'A Journey', the visuals create a world we want to enter. A montage of misty rivers, sun-kissed alleyways, ancient temples take us through a journey of different landscapes. The narration gives us something to think about. The music connects the images emotionally, and the editing allows the story to unfold at its own pace.

Nothing feels as though it is in a hurry to sell us something.

The film gives us the space to interpret what we see and connect it with our own experiences. It does not spell everything out. It trusts us to find our own meaning in the story.

You don't always have to tell people what to feel. Sometimes, you just have to create the right conditions for them to feel it themselves.

Where the Idea Comes Alive

The way an idea is expressed is as important as the idea itself. We often talk about the big idea as if the job is done once we find it. But that is where the real work begins.

How do you compose a frame? How long do you hold a shot? When should the music rise, and when should it step back? What do you reveal, and what do you leave to the audience's imagination?

These may seem like small decisions, but they can completely change how a story is experienced.

ONE OF A KIND

The first-ever brand film by Louis Vuitton since its founding in 1854, 'A Journey' was created by Ogilvy Paris under the creative direction of Christian Reuilly. Directed by Bruno Aleillan and scored by Academy Award winner Gustavo Santaolalla, the film won 15 international awards and two gold Clios.

Bruno Aveillan's background in fine arts makes this film particularly interesting. You can look at the relationship between composition, movement, light, and emotion and appreciate how visual thinking can shape the storytelling. But the lesson is much bigger than any one director or film.

The best craft is not something that sits on top of an idea. It is what allows the idea to come alive. There is a question I often find myself coming back to when I look at advertising today: Are we making work to be seen or remembered?

Views expressed are personal.

BE/G.O.A.T. features all-time favourite campaigns that ad professionals fondly remember.

Milk Money

How private Indian dairy players succeeded where MNCs failed

By **Alenjith K Johny**

For decades, dairy in India primarily meant cooperatives, such as Amul, Mother Dairy, and Nandini. But a new generation of entrepreneurs and their dairy brands are changing that.

Companies such as Milky Mist, Hatsun Agro Product, Parag Milk Foods, Heritage Foods, Akshayakalpa, Country Delight, and Dodla Dairy are all building strong businesses in this difficult category.

What makes their growth remarkable is that they are succeeding where global dairy companies struggled. Fonterra and Danone exited the market, while others shied away from investing in dairy.

So how did the homegrown brands do it?

1 WOOING THE FARMER

The new generation of players was able to ride the success of the cooperative movement better than their foreign competitors.

"The cooperative movement helped mature the entire industry. Farmers became more educated and an ecosystem for cattle rearing developed," said **Ankur Bisen**, senior partner at The Knowledge Company, a consulting firm.

This ecosystem meant foreign dairy companies entering India could not simply rely on capital or a strong consumer brand. They had to build relationships with farmers and create a supply chain that could handle a highly perishable product, said **C**, co-founder of MilkMantra, which was later acquired by Hatsun Agro.

The new generation of entrepreneurs have managed to offer higher premiums to dairy farmers, which helped them build closer relationships. Companies like Dodla Dairy use a model involving its own cattle, while Country Delight focus on direct milk collection.

These companies also work with banks to help farmers finance the purchase of cattle, with repayments deducted from their milk payments.

Such relationships are aimed at making procurement more stable while giving farmers access to capital.That has allowed them to have greater say in controlling factors, such as milk quality and fat content.

2 SHARP REGIONAL FOCUS

The importance of procurement has kept dairy a largely regional business. Companies typically build dense farmer and distribution networks in one market before expanding.

Misra says companies such as Nestle and Danone misread the importance of India's fragmented retail and cold-chain network. Dairy products cannot be treated like conventional packaged FMCG. Freshness, refrigeration and frequent distribution require companies to build infrastructure close to the consumer.

"You start at the source. You do your sourcing, procurement, manufacturing, and branding [locally]," Misra said. "The freshness of the product depends on your control of the supply chain."

Only once they get the region right do they expand. Take the example of Hatsun Agro Product, which reportedly expects revenue to rise as much as 50% over the next two financial years, supported by a wider milk procurement network and expansion beyond south India.

3 SAYING NO TO MILK

For the likes of Milky Mist, a key decision was to stay away from a massive category – liquid milk, and instead focus on products such as paneer, cheese, curd, ghee, butter, and ice cream.

The attraction is higher margins. Liquid milk typically gives dairy companies margins of around 5–8%, according to India Ratings and Research, while products such as paneer, ghee, cheese, and yoghurt can deliver margins of 15–45%.

"So, we are only on value-added products. That is our strength because you don't have the pressure to sell milk," said **K Rathnam**, chief executive of Milky Mist.

Numbers of the Week

According to Nielsen's Annual Marketing Report 2026, a vast majority – as much as 94% – of Indian marketers expect to increase sponsorship and event media spend over the next couple of years. India recorded the highest share among the six markets surveyed – the US, the UK, Italy, France, and Germany. The report says, 98% of marketers now use AI. Interestingly, measurement of return on investment was one area where India was behind other markets, with only 42% of Indian marketers measuring ROI across media.

A Boston Consulting Group study finds just 54% of consumers across 10 countries trusted that advertised Black Friday discounts were genuinely lower than usual; one in five actively distrusted them. Twenty-two per cent planned to spend less or skip year-end sales. In that same study, social media's share as an inspiration source fell 9%, to 46%. Planned use of AI for shopping reached 56%, up eight points year on year.

BRAND EQUITY QUIZ ANSWERS: 1. INDIGO; **2.** AKASA; **3.** VISTARA; **4.** KINGFISHER; **5.** FLY91.

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90 MINS* EXPRESS SERVICE
AUTHORIZED NISSAN DEALERS: DELHI/NCR: DELHI: DWARKA (NEW DELHI): RELIABLE NISSAN- 9619363038, MOTI NAGAR (NEW DELHI): RELIABLE NISSAN- 9619340206, PRASHANT VIHAR: RELIABLE NISSAN- 8291023597, MATHURA ROAD: BRITE NISSAN- 8879865805, BHIKAJI KAMA PLACE: BRITE NISSAN- 8879865796, PATPARGANJ: BRITE NISSAN- 8291095433, HARYANA: GURUGRAM SECTOR 14: VERTEX NISSAN- 8291044902, SOHNA ROAD: VERTEX NISSAN- 9167041673, FARIDABAD: HARITASH NISSAN- 8291014764, SONIPAT: KUNDLI: MALWA NISSAN- 9167998356, KARNAL: PEARL NISSAN- 8291013115, KURUKSHETRA: PEARL NISSAN- 8422831424, ROHTAK: BA NISSAN- 8291041277, UTTAR PRADESH: NOIDA SECTOR 63: BRITE MOTORS- 9167258352, NOIDA SECTOR-22: BRITE NISSAN- 8291023643, GHAZIABAD: DREAM NISSAN - 8291051681, MEERUT: NATH NISSAN- 9619230167, RAJASTHAN: ALWAR: TIRUPATI NISSAN- 9619894676.
*Terms & conditions apply: The scheme/benefits mentioned are applicable on select vehicles/variants of MY 2026 which will be booked and invoiced on or before 30th November 2026 or till stocks last. All prices ex-showroom Delhi. The model shown are Magnite Tekna+, Tekton Tekna+ & Limited-Edition Nissan Gravite. **1 gm. gold coin offer is applicable on selected variants of Nissan range demonstrated here. Customers opting for CNG option will not be eligible for gold coin & other benefits. ^Assured gift on test drive is applicable only on completion of test drive. Dealership team will guide on participation before the test drive. For customers booking and taking delivery until 16th November'26 will be eligible to scratch a physical coupon to win exciting gifts post invoicing. Process of claiming the gift will be specified on the voucher. Scratch and win assured gift offer is not applicable in Tamil Nadu. Features may vary from variant to variant. Color, models are indicative and for depiction only and may vary due to printing constraints. Accessories shown may not be part of standard fitment. Please visit your nearest Nissan dealer for more information. Finance is on the sole discretion of NRFSI. ~Standard warranty 3 year or 100k km whichever comes first and can be extended to 10 years 200K on additional cost. Offer applicable on Nissan Nissan Range and customer needs to provide certificate of deposit. #Government approved CNG Kit full developed, manufactured & quality assured bv a 3rd party. CNG kit warranty & any other related terms & conditions are applicable as specified by third party. @GNCAP rating for Nissan Magnite published in 2025 - 5 Star for Adult Safety and 3 Star for Child Safety rating from VIN: MDHFBADD0Z0037139. Detailed report available on website: www.globalncap.org/indiaresults.
NISSAN FINANCE